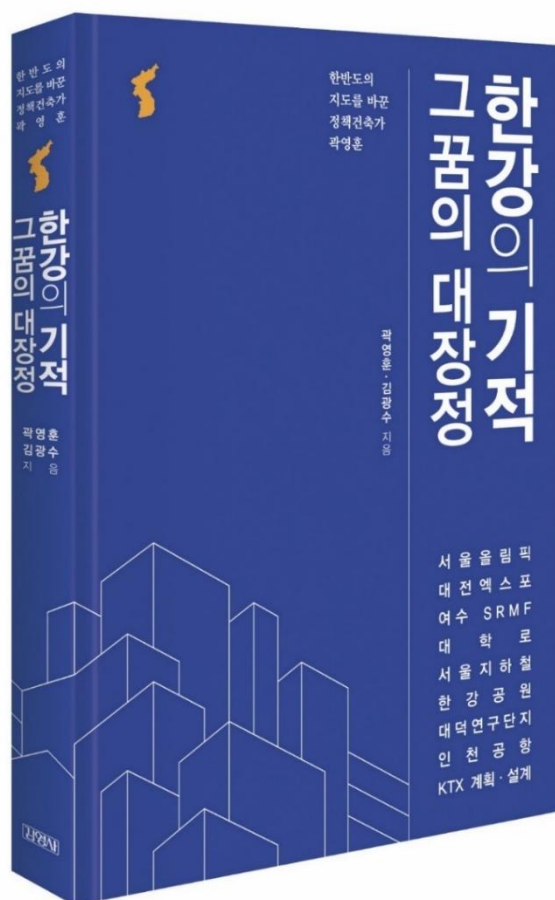


Miracle on the Han River

A Long Journey of Dreams

**Policy Architect KWAAK YoungHoon
Who Changed the Map of the Korean Peninsula**

**Seoul Olympic, Daejeon EXPO, Yeosu SRMF,
University Street, Seoul Subway, Daedeok Science Town,
Han River Park, Incheon International Airport, KTX High-Speed**



Dr. KWAAK YoungHoon

After completing both his undergraduate and graduate studies at the MIT School of Architecture and Planning, he also pursued political science and public policy at the Harvard Kennedy School and education at the Harvard Graduate School of Education. As he was about to complete his studies in the United States, he developed the conceptual *Master Vision and Implementation Plan* (MVIP) for Korea which became the blueprint for Korea's miraculous development. From this book, readers will gain insight into Dr. KWAAK's extraordinary dedication over the past 50 years in developing strategies and implementing Korea's national projects.

He always combined theory and practice in his life. While completing his journey in American academia, he established KMR Associates with Miller, and Rushbrook in Cambridge, Massachusetts to collaborate on generating environmental and educational alternatives for the conversion of Otis Air Force Base in Cape Cod, Massachusetts. After returning to Korea, he taught city environmental design at the newly established Seoul National University Graduate School of Environmental Studies. He also assumed the position of the Founding Advisor to help launch the field of landscape architecture at the Korea Landscape Development Corporation. Throughout his life, he continued to teach and practice at various universities and national public policy organizations. The 1988 Seoul Olympic Games, the Daejeon Expo 1993, and the Expo 2012 Yeosu Korea (the Yeosu Expo 2012) were the main strategic major global events he conceptualized under his MVIP.

Having experienced the Korean War as a child, he has been leading the world peace movement as the Founder President of the World Citizens Organization (WCO). The WCO was established in 1987 to persuade world leaders not to boycott the 1988 Seoul Olympics, and readers will gain insight into the details of its activities. He is also active as the President of the UN Association of the ROK, the Co-President of the Happiness Inexperience and Sharing Movement (THIS), and leads the globalization of Taekwondo as a Grand Master, 9th-degree Black Belt.

This book introduces his life and work, highlighting Korea's rapid development over the past 50 years.

Professor KIM Kwangsoo

After graduating from the Department of Philosophy at Seoul National University, he earned his master's and doctoral degrees in Philosophy from the University of California, Santa Barbara. He served as a Professor of Philosophy at Hanshin University, the President of the Philosophy Research Society, and an advisor to the journal *Life Philosophy Quarterly: Philosophy and Reality*.

His major books include *Logic and Critical Thinking*, *The Dream of Rounded Squares*, *Philosophy of Mind*, and *Philosophizing Man*. He has also written and directed *madang* plays, a form of traditional Korean outdoor theater, such as *To Search for Red Cheeks*.

Miracle on the Han River: *A Long Journey of Dreams*

Foreword

Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon, my 60-year-old friend, has been planning global events and public infrastructure at the right time and in the right place for the past 50 years. He truly sees the future, understands the nation, and envisions the world. I have always admired him for dedicating his life to the development of the country, dreaming and planning with a vision that spans 100 years.

BAN Ki-moon (Former UN Secretary-General)

Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon reminds me of the etymology of the word “architect.” In ancient Europe, *architectus* — a compound of *arkhi* (best) and *tekton* (builder) — referred to the most creative individual who mastered all knowledge. For him, an architect in the truest sense, the Korean Peninsula was too small a stage.

SEUNG H-sang (Architect)

Have you ever imagined Seoul without the Han River Park? Looking at the scenery of the Han River Park, I am reminded that South Korea has become a great country to live in. How did South Korea grow so quickly from a recipient nation to a donor nation? I believe the answer lies in people like Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon.

CHOI Bool-Am (Broadcaster)

Among the countless individuals who made significant contributions to host the Olympics in Korea, Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon stands out for something special. He has built a cross-border human network through his long-term vision and exceptional persuasive skills. His foresight and boundless energy will serve as a valuable guide for the next generation.

KIM Jin-sun (Chair of the PyeongChang Organizing Committee for the 2018 Olympic & Paralympic Winter Games)

Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon has traveled the world as an architect, public policy planner, and peace activist with the dream of creating a harmonious global village where all of humanity can coexist. The marks he has left along the way testify to his remarkable status as a true ‘world citizen.’

LEE Sam-Yeol (Secretary-General of the Korean National Commission for UNESCO)

Before Korea's rapid development, known as the 'Miracle on the Han River,' Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon played a monumental role in the field of architecture. It is no exaggeration to say that there is hardly a place in Korea that has not been influenced by his work. His philosophy and approach to his work serve as an inspiring model for everyone.

JEONG Dae-cheol (Former Member of the National Assembly)

There is no single category in modern professional classifications that can fully encompass Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon, as his fields of activity are so diverse. *Uomo Universale*, regarded as the ideal human form during the Renaissance, is perhaps the most fitting description for him.

SON Bong-Ho (Emeritus Professor, Seoul National University)

Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon is an artist who creates original works from familiar materials. He possesses a sensibility that can be described as 'political' in a positive sense. Anyone who reads this book will immediately recognize him as an extraordinary individual.

Emanuel PASTREICH (President, Asia Institute)

As a citizen of Yeosu rather than its mayor, I could truly feel that Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon's interest in and affection for Yeosu were extraordinary. There were many moments of gratitude during the years I spent with him. His words, spirit, and footsteps, as recorded in this book, will help readers chart the course of their own lives.

KIM Chung-seok (Former Mayor of Yeosu)

To ordinary people, Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon — always ahead of his time — may seem like the eccentric philosopher Diogenes, who carried a lamp even during the daytime. I believe that after reading this book, readers will come to understand the true value of Dr. KWAACK to some extent.

LEE Myung-Hyun (Former Minister of Education)

I have always hoped that Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon's dreams, ideas, and achievements across various fields would become better known to the world, so that he may receive the recognition he truly deserves. I was therefore truly delighted to hear of the publication of this book. I hope that those who read it will be able to build upon the point he has reached.

UHM Jung Sik (Philosopher, Emeritus Professor, Sogang University)

Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon is a true worker who gives his best even in unseen places. He is a hidden contributor to the 'miraculous' development of the Republic of Korea, consistently working silently without ever seeking personal benefit. His biography offers new guidance for those who have lost their dreams and feel adrift.

SHIM Woo-kyung (Environmental and Ecological Engineer, Emeritus Professor, Korea University)

Preface

No artifact in the world exists independently of its creator. Yet, we often feel no need to know who made each artifact, and sometimes we even prefer not to know. There is nothing wrong with this, and no particular reason or meaning behind it. However, there are certain individuals we must know. Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon, the central figure of this book, is one such individual.

The National Portrait Gallery in Washington, D.C., USA, displays portraits of individuals who have made significant contributions to the founding and development of the United States. As you move through the exhibition, American history — from the 17th century to the present — unfolds before your eyes. Portraits of many people including Native Americans, politicians, judges, entrepreneurs, writers, artists, athletes, Nobel laureates, actors, pop singers, antiwar activists, and even dreamers and villains are presented alongside their biographies. The figures featured in this museum are not those ‘we do not need to know.’ Rather, they are recognized as ‘must-know’ individuals in the history of the United States.

Visitors to this museum do not merely admire the artistic value of the portraits. They understand that it is no coincidence that the fledgling United States became one of the world’s greatest powers. Moved by the dreams, wisdom, courage, and sacrifices of the individuals on display — those who laid the foundation for the nation’s development — visitors are inspired to reflect deeply on their own lives. This is not just an art museum; it is a space for guidance and inspiration, where visitors can cultivate their minds and envision a new future.

While visiting the National Portrait Gallery, I thought it would be wonderful to have a similar portrait museum in Korea — a place where we could honor the people who contributed to building the Republic of Korea. It is often said that Korea became an economically advanced country thanks to a particular president, and of course, the president played a significant role. However, such statements often overlook the many individuals, other than the president, who devoted themselves to the country’s development. That is not true. If Korea had a portrait museum, we would be able to recognize the many unsung heroes who contributed to the advancement of the Korean economy — people beyond the powerful and wealthy. If I were to choose an outstanding figure among them, it would be Dr. KWAACK YoungHoon.

I first came to know Dr. KWAACK when he participated as an actor in the play *Finding Red Cheeks*, which I directed in 2002 (If there had been a portrait museum, I might have known him earlier). It was a satirical play about a society in which people no longer blush, even after committing shameful acts. The cast were not professional actors but amateurs — professors, religious leaders, and lawyers. Philosopher and Protestant leader, Professor SON Bong-Ho played a con artist, Prosecutor KANG Jiwon took on the role of a gang leader, and another professor portrayed the villainous barmaid. Meanwhile, Dr. KWAACK was entrusted with the role of the ‘caller’ — a ‘good’ character searching for red cheeks.

There was a reason for that. He came across as someone who didn’t want to cause any disruption, even on stage. And yes, my judgment was correct. He was always serious, dreamed like a true dreamer, and once he took the microphone, he seemed to have endless things to say. He didn’t know how to tell a white lie or refuse someone’s request, and he was as pure as a child. Even on stage, he appeared to be someone who wished to remain that way.

In his research library, ZipEnvision, the past, present, and future coexist. The various maps and blueprints reveal projects that have already been completed, those currently underway, and those to be carried out in the future. Just looking at these maps leaves me speechless.

Even more astonishing is Dr. KWAAK's memory. As he points to a map, he recalls events from decades ago as though they occurred just yesterday — effortlessly remembering names, dates, and even precise years, months, and days. Watching him vividly describe the atmosphere of that time and recount the words he heard as if broadcasting them live, I realized how much he carried within his own black box.

While writing this book, one of the biggest challenges was finding the right word to describe Dr. KWAAK's profession. Simply calling him an 'urban environment designer' or 'architect' felt far too limiting. It is because he also planned national land development policies. He serves as the President of the UN Association of the ROK and founded the Beautiful School Movement. He is actively involved in numerous civic organizations, including the Citizens' Coalition for Economic Justice, and currently serves as the Founder President of the World Citizens Organization (WCO). Dr. KWAAK's work is so broad and multifaceted that defining his profession in just a few words proved to be a true challenge.

The interviews were mainly conducted at the WCO Olympeace House, Namsan Garden, and ZipEnvision. We talked over meals, in the car, and while walking. Interestingly, our discussions often went off track. He would criticize politicians who stirred up conflict, scold political commentators who misled the public, and lament a society swayed by fake news. Eventually, he would even turn to me and ask, "What are philosophers doing?"

Many years ago, Dr. KWAAK asked me to write his autobiography. At the time, I couldn't accept it because I was already working on a book I had long been planning. Although I had to refuse, I was always felt sorry about it. Later, he suggested that we simply have open conversations and turn them into a book instead. I gladly accepted his offer. My acceptance wasn't merely out of guilt for having refused his suggestion before. This book will show you why.

It was never my intention, in these interviews, merely to list or praise Dr. KWAAK's many achievements. My focus was elsewhere: What kind of spirit enabled him to accomplish so much? What drove him? How did he manage to carry out these ambitious projects successfully? I was searching for answers to these questions. So I want to ask readers not just to look at what Dr. KWAAK has accomplished, but to read this book with curiosity about the spirit that drove him — questioning why and how he achieved these things.

Dr. KWAAK's pen name is *U Gong*. When asked how he writes it in Chinese characters, he replied that he writes only in Korean, because there are too many "U" characters he wants to use. Let us summarize what he said.

"I like to fly high to see the world from a broader perspective (feather U 羽), and I look far and dream (far U 迂). What I can do (helping U 佑) for the people I love (friend U 友) is to create a place where they can live happily (house U 宇). I like to work like a cow (cow U 牛). I am sometimes foolish (foolish U 愚) and sometimes upsets (worry U 憂). I welcome rains (rain U 雨) come again (again U 又), and I am preoccupied with the thought (fathom U 虞) of planting new seeds (meeting U 遇)."

In Plato's *Politeia*, he asserted that only the 'Iron King' — one who possesses both philosophical wisdom and power — can achieve an ideal society. However, Plato's ideal society reveals the paradox of the 'ideal without power': philosophers have no power, and those in power lack philosophical wisdom. Surprisingly, Dr. KWAAK has shown that national development can be achieved without wielding formal power. He has skillfully leveraged the power of eight presidents, regardless of whether they led authoritarian or democratic regimes. I would like to whisper Dr. KWAAK's wisdom to Plato, who has long been buried beneath the ground.

At the end of the interview, I was reminded of Master Seosan's poem, *Walking on Snow at Night*. This is the poem that helped KIM Gu, the Korean independence leader, regain his determination.

답설야중거 踏雪野中去 When walking on snow at night
불수호란행 不須胡亂行 Do not walk erratically.
금일아행적 今日我行跡 The way I walked today,
수작후인정 遂作後人程 It will become a milestone for others in the future.

Dr. KWAAK YoungHoon has lived his life by forging a path that never existed — one that now stands as a meaningful milestone for others to follow. I hope this collection of interviews will inspire the emergence of a second and third KWAAK YoungHoon, who will lead the continued development of the Republic of Korea.

For the publication of this book, many people — including YANG Buyeol and KIM Huiyoung from KWAAK Environmental Studies and Policy Research Institute, Inc. (KWAAK E.S.P.R.I.), and LEE SangJoon from ZipEnvision — made significant contributions by planning the interviews and providing data. I sincerely applaud their enthusiasm and dedication.

I would like to thank Gimm-young Publishers for graciously accepting the publication of this book. My heartfelt gratitude also goes to SHIM Seongmi and PARK Wanhee, who transformed a rough manuscript into a polished and meaningful work.

December 2021

KIM Kwangsoo



Dr. KWAAK YoungHoon (seated) and Professor KIM Kwangsoo at Professor KIM's Library, 2021

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1

Dreaming of Something from Nothing : A Big Picture Drawn Half a Century Ago

The Reason for Choosing the Path of Architecture

Dreaming of Architecture in a Land of Ruins

KIM Kwangsoo: Have you ever heard the saying, “I knew if I waited around long enough, something like this would happen.” It was mistakenly known as the epitaph of playwright Bernard Shaw. I think these words describe well the lives of ordinary people. Most of the time we live ‘just fine.’ But if you spend your life being pushed and pulled around just to make a living, you may one day find yourself standing in the twilight of life without even realizing how you got there.

But in your life, there doesn’t seem to be any room for words like ‘hesitate’ or ‘just getting by.’ How can one person achieve so much in just one lifetime?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It’s true that I’ve done a lot of work. Even now, approaching eighty, I’m still fully engaged in my work. So, people say I’ve been successful. However, I can’t say that I’ve lived a successful life. There are many things that didn’t go as planned, and there’s still a lot of work left to do. I’m just an architect who loves to work.

KIM Kwangsoo: You humbly call yourself ‘just an architect,’ but I don’t think it’s possible to talk about Korea’s development — what many call the ‘Miracle on the Han River’ — without mentioning you.

You and I belong to the generation that experienced the Korean War in our youth. Being born into a land of ruins must have influenced your decision to pursue the path of architecture.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I think so. When I look back on the time I decided to become an architect, what comes to mind are the gloomy landscapes from just after the war.

It was 1958, as I remember. I was a middle school student at the time, and while sitting on the wooden floor at home with my older brother, I made up my mind to devote my life to Korea’s development. As for the methodology, my brother promised to create policies like a *Unification Constitution*, and I promised to create a peace city near the DMZ where North and South Korea could live in harmony. My brother envisioned a ‘frame of life’ and I envisioned a ‘site of life.’

KIM Kwangsoo: But why architecture? There are so many other ways to contribute to our country.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I believe that each person has their own unique aptitudes and abilities. I was especially interested in geography. When I was in school, my hobby was spinning the globe to locate various countries around the world and memorizing the names of their capitals. I also enjoyed reading books about how civilization was born and spread.

Then one day, I discovered the field of urban environmental design and architecture. I was fascinated by the fact that it encompasses almost all disciplines such as geography, engineering, aesthetics, politics, landscape architecture, and education, as well as my favorite geography. Above all, I was excited that I could learn how to expand the infrastructure necessary for the economic development of Korea.

Going to America to Seek the Best Education

KWAAK YoungHoon: When I asked my brother which university has the most prestigious architecture department in the world, he said MIT. However, with my family's circumstances, going to study in the U.S. was simply unthinkable.

KIM Kwangsoo: However, you eventually entered the Department of Architecture at MIT immediately after graduating from high school. It was a time when even attending a university in Korea was not easy. Did you perhaps feel that studying in Korea was simply unappealing to you?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Unappealing? Not at all. I'm not a fatalist, but I do believe I was destined to study in the United States, and there are two reasons. First, when I was in high school, I spent a month in America, experiencing a broader world. In 1962, during my third year at Gyeonggi High School, I was selected as a Korean representative for the "Youth Red Cross Operation VISTA" (hereafter referred to as VISTA), an international student exchange program jointly hosted by the American Red Cross and the White House, and I traveled to the United States. At that time, I was amazed by the development of the United States, and I set a goal to develop Korea to the same level. To that end, I thought that I would have to study and live in America.



▲ VISTA Korean Delegation

BAN Ki-moon, Former Secretary-General of the United Nations (far left), and KWAAK YoungHoon (far right)

Secondly, I had no real chance of going to college in Korea anyway. I was marked as anti-government person. Here's the story.

When I returned to Korea after VISTA and went to school as usual, a new principal was appointed — former teacher of PARK Chung-hee, then President of the Supreme Council for National Reconstruction. Students protested against the sudden 'orders from above,' and the school quickly descended into chaos. I was accused of being an instigator simply because I was the Student Council

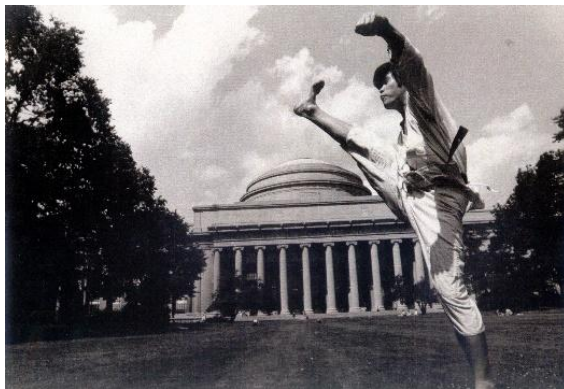
President, and I was suspended indefinitely without being given any reason. Although they promised to give me a diploma, they told me to stay away from school. So, I ended up not going to school until graduation. Instead, I prepared to study abroad.

KIM Kwangsoo: It looks like you were forced into exile by circumstance.

KWAAK YoungHoon: (Laughs) That's right. When I arrived in the United States, all I had on me was 200 dollars.

KIM Kwangsoo: The long-awaited journey to study abroad must have been exciting and exhausting at the same time. Studying at an American university right after graduating from high school in Korea could not have been easy. Many international students often struggle with language barriers and experience culture shock and homesickness. Did you have any of these problems?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Not at all. I didn't have time to think about anything else because I was fully focused on learning and absorbing new things. Also, I was able to overcome the language barrier because I had studied English seriously in Korea. My time studying abroad was a very interesting and rewarding period in my life. I studied, traveled extensively across the United States and Europe, and worked as an instructor at a Taekwondo studio to earn money.



▲ Taekwondo Demonstration in Front of the MIT Main Building

KIM Kwangsoo: How many years have you been in America?

KWAAK YoungHoon: I was there for about ten years. After finishing my studies, I gained practical experience in landscape design at SDDA, the world's best-known landscape architecture and planning firm. I was thirty when I returned home.

KIM Kwangsoo: Ten years is quite a long time — long enough for even mountains and rivers to change, as the saying goes. You must have studied a lot.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Looking back on my twenties, I was crazy about studying. There were countless nights I stayed up in the library or laboratory. I felt that I had to learn as much as I could before I went back, so my passion for studying was endless. In particular, what my roommate said during my last semester at MIT really inspired me. He said, “Creating a *DMZ Peace City* is a public policy project, right? Then shouldn’t you study political science as well?” When I heard that, it struck me as absolutely right. From that moment on, the scope of my studies gradually expanded.

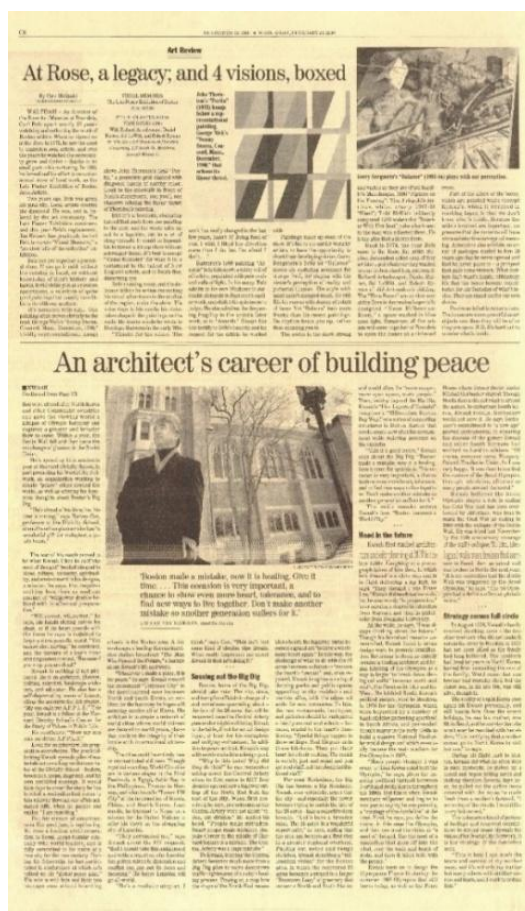
From 1999 to 2000, I had the opportunity to lecture alongside Professor Harvey Cox in the Theology Department at Harvard University. During that time, a reporter from the *Boston Globe* interviewed me and published an article titled “A.P.P.L.E.” This was because the first letters of the subjects I studied in the United States spelled A.P.P.L.E. — Architecture, Planning, Political Science, Landscape Architecture, and Education, in that order. I also studied Theology, but it was left out.



▲ Article in the *Boston Globe* Introducing Dr. KWAAK YoungHoon, Titled “A.P.P.L.E.” (February 23, 2000)

KIM Kwangsoo: You are the walking “A.P.P.L.E.”

KWAAK YoungHoon: (Laughs) The reporter was witty.



A Map of the Future for the Korean Peninsula Drawn Far from Home

New York, 1964, World's Fair

KIM Kwangsoo: I also studied in the U.S., but I found it very difficult to keep up with my coursework. However, you managed not only to focus on your studies but also to dream ambitiously.

KWAAK YoungHoon: It wasn't something I achieved, but rather an accidental opportunity that came to me. In my second year of studying in the United States, I received a call from the American National Red Cross in Washington, D.C. They asked me to speak as the VISTA student representative at the annual general meeting held at the Hilton Hotel in New York. When I hesitated and said that I was not confident, Ms. Dorothy Taaffe, Director of International Affairs at the American National Red Cross, encouraged me by saying, "It's okay if your English isn't perfect. You just have to speak from your heart."



▲ American National Red Cross Speech (1964) and a Revisit to the Same Place (2022)

Somehow, I was walking down from the podium after giving my speech in front of a thousand people, and the audience gave me a standing ovation. I was really embarrassed, because I didn't feel like I had spoken well enough to deserve it. But what happened next was unforgettable. Just as I was stepping down from the stage, a blonde Junior Red Cross student rushed toward me. She introduced herself as Debbie and said that the last sentence of my speech had really impressed her. Then she asked me to follow her because there was a place she wanted to show me. She was like an angelic guide, but what she showed me — the site of the 1964 New York World's Fair — hit me like a thunderbolt.

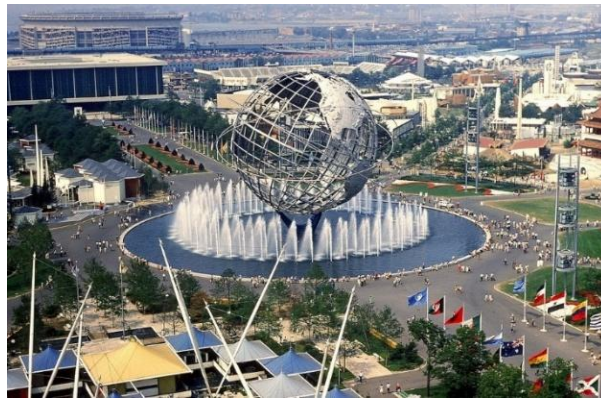
KIM Kwangsoo: I wonder what the last sentence of the speech was.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I don't remember exactly, but the last words were "It's up to you!" I wanted to convey a message to the people gathered there that the future depends on you.

KIM Kwangsoo: It's not a very big phrase, but it really moved Debbie's heart. (laughs) So, where did she take you?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It was the World's Fair in Brooklyn, New York. I was overwhelmed when I encountered an enormous globe at the entrance — 43 meters tall and 37 meters in diameter. It was a festival where people could preview the future civilization of mankind.

At that moment, I thought it would be wonderful if my friends in Korea could come here and see things like this together. But I knew it was an unrealistic wish. Still, an even bigger dream stirred my heart. I thought, "Oh, I wish a World's Fair like this could be held in Korea as well. If we couldn't bring all Koreans to a World's Fair abroad, we could host such an event in Korea" I also felt a growing sense of hope that Korea would come to know the world more deeply, and that the world would come to know Korea better.



▲ The 1964-1965 New York World's Fair Site

KIM Kwangsoo: However, at that time, Korea was one of the poorest countries in the world and had almost no infrastructure.

KWAAK YoungHoon: "There is no infrastructure." To me, having no infrastructure seemed more like an opportunity. In order to host the World Expo in Korea, it was imperative to build the necessary infrastructure. Constructing infrastructure itself was the first step toward the development of Korea.

KIM Kwangsoo: It's kind of a reverse idea — building infrastructure to host global events, and hosting global events to build infrastructure. It seems like an idea that addresses both cause and reality.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Until the Daejeon Expo 1993, people dismissed this idea as just a 'daydream.' If we had met in our twenties, you probably would have laughed and called me a 'dreamer.'

KIM Kwangsoo: (Laughs) You're someone who has bold dreams that often seem impossible to achieve. So yes, 'dreamer' is the right word.

KWAAK YoungHoon: (Laughs) Dreams are free. Anyway, thanks to Debbie, I was able to have a concrete dream of hosting a global event. I would like to find her before I die. That day, we were even able to see the layout of the global event venue. If I hadn't toured the World Expo site back then, I would have had to start everything — including the master plan and venue design — from scratch when preparing for the Daejeon Expo.

A New Target, the Olympics

KWAAK YoungHoon: In 1964, there was another event that made my heart race — the Tokyo Olympics. It was the first Summer Olympic Games held in Asia. While watching the broadcast on TV, a sudden thought crossed my mind: “Why not Seoul? If Tokyo could host it, why not Seoul?” That's exactly how I felt.

“If the Olympics were held in Seoul, wouldn't the world's attention be focused on Korea? Wouldn't democracy flourish in Korea as well? To host the Olympics, we would first need to build domestic infrastructure, which would then accelerate national development. The Olympics would also give a significant boost to the national economy.”

The more I thought about it, the more the Olympics seemed like a global event essential to Korea's development. At that moment, I made a firm resolution to study harder so that I could contribute to hosting the Olympics in Seoul.

KIM Kwangsoo: You were right. Just as the 17th Tokyo Olympics became a stepping stone for Japan to rise from a nation defeated in World War II to a developed country, the Seoul Olympics became a turning point that enabled Korea's rapid growth.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Exactly! Four years later, in 1968, while watching the Winter Olympics in Grenoble, France, I dreamed once again of hosting another Olympics, thinking to myself, “We should also host the Winter Olympics near the Daegwallyeong area.” Fifty years after that vision in 1968, the 2018 PyeongChang Winter Olympic Games were finally held — and this time, North Korea participated unexpectedly.

I had also conceived the main theme for the Seoul Olympic Games, “Hand in Hand — Breaking the Ideological Wall between the East and the West,” as well as for the PyeongChang Olympics, “Step by Step — Melting the Frozen Path between North and South.”

KIM Kwangsoo: So during your studies abroad, you not only focused on your coursework but also envisioned practical opportunities to apply what you were learning. As a result, Korea successfully hosted the 1988 Summer Olympics in Seoul and the 2018 Winter Olympics in PyeongChang. I know that you played a significant role in both the preparation and the hosting of these two Olympic Games.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, once you set a clear goal, a path to reach it somehow emerges, and people who want to walk that path with you gradually gather along the way. Especially in the case of a large global event like the Olympics, once the entire nation rolled up its sleeves and joined in, even things that seemed impossible miraculously became reality.

KIM Kwangsoo: Hosting the Olympic Games is the result of many people's efforts, but it seems that you have been preparing for it the longest.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I visited Olympic sites abroad as benchmarks to prepare the Olympic master plan in advance. The 1972 Munich Olympics, the 1976 Montreal Olympics, the 1984 Los Angeles Olympics... I observed that many aspects changed every four years, from the structure and layout of the venues to the way the Games were conducted. I went from place to place, diligently taking photos and making notes. I learned and realized far more from visiting the actual sites once than from reading a hundred books.

KIM Kwangsoo: It seems that the saying "Actions speak louder than words" is true. Which Olympics impressed you the most?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It was the Munich Olympics, as it was the first Olympic Games I personally attended. At the end of my studies in the U.S., I founded the MIT-Harvard Taekwondo Club and taught Taekwondo to students and professors to save money for my trip to Munich and Europe.

KIM Kwangsoo: If you were able to start your own Taekwondo club, you must be quite skilled.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I am a certified 9th Dan from Chung Do Kwan, the highest-ranked Taekwondo school in Korea.

KIM Kwangsoo: Oh wow, I need to be more careful from now on.



▲ Certificate of 9th Dan Black Belt
Awarded by the World Taekwondo Chung Do Kwan Federation

KWAAK YoungHoon: (Laughs) When I left for Europe with just a backpack in the summer of 1972, all I had was a Eurail Pass, which allowed unlimited travel on European railroads for a set period. My pass was valid for three months because I had made a long list of the contact information for the European friends I had met in the United States, even though I had only a few bucks in my pocket. I

traveled to Amsterdam, Paris, Venice, Zurich, Geneva, Vienna, Oslo, Copenhagen, Stockholm, and then to Germany — Duisburg, Aachen, Köln, Bonn, and Munich, of course.

KIM Kwangsoo: Why did you travel through so many countries instead of going straight to Germany? It would have cost more.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Travel is also a study. People like me need to know the real world. Through my travels, I learned a lot, and coined a new word “inperience” as well as “inspeience” to describe a deeper kind of experience beyond the usual.

KIM Kwangsoo: I see. It seems to me that you didn’t go directly to Munich upon arriving in Germany.

KWAAK YoungHoon: That’s correct. In Germany, I first stopped by Duisburg, a coal mining town on the Rhine River, where I met Korean miners and nurses who had been dispatched to West Germany for job opportunities at the time. Seeing them work tirelessly — taking on even the toughest jobs without rest to earn foreign currency to send back home — deeply moved me.

I suggested that we watch the Munich Olympics together, hoping to give them even a small joyful memory of their time in Germany. However, everyone hesitated because they couldn’t afford the tickets. Although I didn’t have much money myself, I said, “I will take care of everything.”

In that way, I went to watch the Munich Olympics together with about 20 miners and nurses. We watched games in which South Korea or North Korea competed against other countries. Because of our limited budget, we only bought a couple of tickets for each game, yet, surprisingly, the gatekeepers allowed our entire group to enter. It seemed that the ticket inspectors took pity on us and let us in out of generosity. But I also realized that there were not many spectators at the Korean games. Most people attended games involving their own countries, and not many Koreans were there to support the Korean teams.

A Sketch of Fifty Years Forward: The Green Axis and The Active Axis

KIM Kwangsoo: For ten years, you observed how people in developed countries like the United States and Europe lived while Korea was suffering from absolute poverty. You must have felt the stark contrast between these two worlds.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, my entire body and mind felt it. I realized the huge gap between the rich and the poor, and between developed countries and Korea in terms of national standing. I kept asking myself, “How can the difference be this big? How is this possible?” I was confused and even angry.

All I could do was push myself to keep coming up with new ideas. I became hungry for knowledge and innovation, and determined to catch up. Honestly, there were no days or nights. Majoring or even double majoring wasn’t enough. I was like an American football player — grinding, grinding, and when the moment came, launching the ball downfield for a touchdown.

Many nights, before going to bed — no, not even a proper bed — I slept on the sofa or the carpeted floor of the Stratton Student Center Library, which stayed open 365 days a year. Before closing my eyes, I would always ask myself, “What did I do today for Korea?” I never asked “What could my country do for me.”

I was determined to formulate a master vision and an implementation plan for Korea’s development — one that would promote balanced growth across all regions and harmonize with the natural environment of the Korean Peninsula, preserving the mountain landscapes, the natural topography, the rivers, and the flow of water into the oceans.

KIM Kwangsoo: You wanted to balance between development and preservation.

KWAAK YoungHoon: You are absolutely right. After extensive and careful consideration, I came up with my first concept, *the Green Axis*, stretching from Mt. Baekdusan in North Korea to Mt. Hallasan in South Korea.

KIM Kwangsoo: What is *the Green Axis* specifically?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It literally means “the Axis of Greenery.” It represents a grand line on the map of the Korean Peninsula aimed at preserving as much green nature as possible.

KIM Kwangsoo: Do we need to mark the green areas to be preserved in advance?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Absolutely. Otherwise, politicians, business people, citizens, bureaucrats and everybody would destroy the nature, only thinking profits. I foresaw that the ‘inexorable greed’ would flood and damage the green space in the name of national development.

KIM Kwangsoo: You have set a development restriction zone by drawing the Green Axis to prevent the chaotic spread of the city and preserve the natural environment.

KWAAK YoungHoon: That’s right. In contrast, there are areas that must be developed to promote national growth, and the line connecting them is referred to as *the Vigor Axis*.

At first, I tried drawing *the Vigor Axis* only on the map of South Korea. However, it didn’t work well, because the Korean Peninsula, excluding North Korea, is almost like an island. If it were an island, at least one could take a boat to cross over. But since access to North Korea is completely restricted, the shortest routes to the north are entirely blocked. So, I asked myself, “What if it were possible to cross the 38th Parallel?” Looking at the whole Korean Peninsula on the map, an axis line naturally formed.

KIM Kwangsoo: Can you point out where the Green Axis and the Vigor Axis are located on the map of the Korean Peninsula?

KWAAK YoungHoon: First, I drew a Green Axis stretching from Mt. Baekdusan to Mt. Hallasan. Then I drew a Vigor Axis connecting five vital points, starting from Jian, where the historical monument of King Gwanggaeto the Great is located, and extending through Pyongyang in North Korea, then Seoul, Daejeon, and Yeosu in South Korea.

I thought, “Given the current political circumstances, the development of the Vigor Axis north of the 38th Parallel should be postponed. I should therefore focus first on developing each vital point along the southern Vigor Axis. If we build the necessary infrastructure for transportation, science, technology, culture, and the arts in the Seoul Metropolitan Region, the Daejeon and Central Region, and the Yeosu and Southern Region, and host global events such as the Olympics and the Expo, wouldn’t these three vital points grow and stimulate development in the surrounding areas?”

I have spent the past 50 years planning and executing various domestic and international projects based on the Green and Vigor Axes, concepts I first developed around 1971. All the global events I have been involved in — the 1988 Seoul Olympics, the Daejeon Expo 1993, the Yeosu Expo 2012, the 2018 PyeongChang Winter Olympic Games, and others — were part of the original 1971 vision, centered on the Vigor Axis and its vital points. Can you imagine the path my life has taken over the past fifty years?



▲ Dr. KWAAK YoungHoon’s *Green Axis* and *Vigor Axis* on the Korean Peninsula

Money or Vocation?

KIM Kwangsoo: It is truly amazing to have envisioned the blueprint for national land development in Korea decades in advance and to have turned it into reality.

I have a question for you. What has been your strongest driving force? Is it a sense of calling for national development, or is it money? Don’t get me wrong. I ask this because, after all, everyone chases money.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Everyone is chasing money... That's true. It reminds me of a line from *Jojolbu*, the sudden rich character in the play *To Search for Red Cheeks* that you directed. He said, "Therefore, faith, hope, and money will always exist, but the greatest of these is money. Amen!"

KIM Kwangsoo: This line is a quote from the George Orwell's novel *Keep the Aspidistra Flying*. It satirically twists the biblical passage from *1 Corinthians 13:13* to critique modern society's obsession with money.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Who doesn't like money? But for me, there are two driving forces in life that are much, much stronger than money.

The first is what I learned from my parents. Having endured the hardships of colonization and a civil war among our people throughout their lives, they always told me, "When you leave this world, be a person of clean, unquestioned reputation, and always live honorably for your country." My brothers, sisters, and I have made every effort to live by the teachings of our parents.

KIM Kwangsoo: Your parents were truly remarkable people, and you and your siblings who have strived to live by their teachings, are equally admirable.

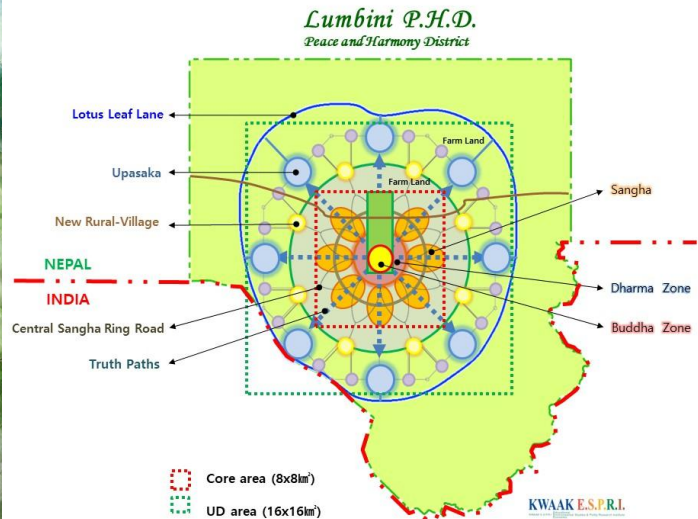
KWAAK YoungHoon: My mother and father first set an example through their own lives. They have always been at the forefront of working for the country and helping relatives and neighbors. They extended their kindness to humanity as well. I saw them help feed soldiers from different countries who participated in the Korean War.

KIM Kwangsoo: I can imagine what the atmosphere in your family must have been like. It seems that there was no room for selfishness to take root in your heart from an early age. What is the other driving force.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I have to say that, 'somehow,' I started to feel some time ago that I am a debtor to the world. It may sound a bit cliché, but it's true. When I was born, the world was already full of many things — the sun, the moon, and the stars, vast lands and rivers, roads, cars, and airplanes, schools and libraries, and books containing all kinds of knowledge. I didn't do anything to earn them, yet much of this was given to me for free.

In a world like this, I didn't want to be just a free rider. I felt it was my duty to live a life that repays this debt however small it may be. I have devoted myself to learning and working to make the world a better place. I'm sharing this with you because you are a respected philosopher, especially in critical thinking.

I also developed the city plan for Lumbini, the birthplace of Sakyamuni Buddha, as the Lumbini Peace and Harmony District (PHD) — a place where people from around the world can live together, learn together, and work together to make the world a better place.



▲ Lumbini Peace and Harmony District (PHD)

KIM Kwangsoo: You believed that, as a human being born into this world, you have a responsibility to help make it a better place.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I am grateful to have been born on this planet Earth and to have lived this far. There were many times I could have died, yet I survived each time.

KIM Kwangsoo: After hearing your answer, I think that I may have asked an unnecessary or wrong question.

By the way, you and I have something in common, do you know what it is?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Let me think....

KIM Kwangsoo: It's that we all don't take money seriously. (laughs)

KWAAK YoungHoon: You're right. You devote yourself to philosophy, even though it doesn't bring much money, and as for me... I have always upheld our family value of not pursuing any undue personal gain.

KIM Kwangsoo: There's something else I have in common with you.

KWAAK YoungHoon: You keep saying things that are too difficult for me. (laughs)

KIM Kwangsoo: Each of us nurtures something meaningful. You care for the urban environment, and I want to care for the mental environment.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Now I understand why I like you.

KIM Kwangsoo: That's also one of the reasons why I like you. I'm very curious about how the national development plan, which born out of your sense of calling, was actually put into practice.

2

The Architect of Miracles : Two Olympics, Two Expos

The 1988 Seoul Olympics: Breathtaking Hurdle Games

From Host-Winning to Preparation: Time of Patience & Persuasion

KIM Kwangsoo: Among the projects that you envisioned while studying abroad, I would like to hear first about the Seoul Olympics. When did you first propose hosting the Olympics?

KWAAK YoungHoon: As I told you earlier, it was 1964 when I said to myself “Why not Seoul?” while watching the Tokyo Olympic Games on TV, which took place from October 10 to 24. After eight years of preparation in various academic fields, as you know, the *Boston Globe* referred to me on February 23, 2000, as “A.P.P.L.E.” — Architect, Planner, Political Scientist, Landscape Architect, and Educator.

As A.P.P.L.E., I came to Korea in 1972 for a short visit to celebrate my mother’s 60th birthday. During this visit, I met with President CHOI Doo-sun and Secretary-General SEO Young-hoon of the Korean Red Cross. Did I tell you that I am indebted to President CHOI? He was the one who recommended that I be issued a Korean passport in 1963, which enabled me to obtain an American visa. Without his recommendation, getting a passport back then would have been impossible.

I thanked them first and then made it clear that I strongly believe Korea should host the Olympics.

KIM Kwangsoo: How did they react?

KWAAK YoungHoon: As you can imagine, they did not agree with me at all. They, along with politicians and academics, dismissed my opinions as not only unrealistic but also detrimental to Korea’s development process. Many of my acquaintances felt the same way. Most people thought it was nothing more than a daydream. They all said, “We don’t have enough national budget or capability, and it will only hinder the country’s economic development.”

KIM Kwangsoo: I heard that they said, “That’s nonsense. It cannot and will not happen. Hosting the Olympics will only ruin the country.”

KWAAK YoungHoon: You are right. Even at the National Cabinet meeting, it encountered harsh criticism. I heard that someone even said, “Anyone who supports the Seoul Olympics is a traitor.” My friend BAN Ki-moon vividly relayed the cabinet members’ criticism, but he told me about it only last year — much, much later.

KIM Kwangsoo: At that time, many people thought, “It’s obvious that the military Yushin regime — a political system that greatly strengthened presidential power and restricted the basic rights of the people — will use the Olympics as a tool to extend its rule.” There were strong voices of concern as the situation under the Yushin regime remained unstable until the late 1970s.

After President PARK Chung-hee was assassinated, a new military government came to power. There were widespread claims that the attempt to host the Olympics was merely a tactic to divert the public’s

attention elsewhere. Anyone who advocated for hosting the Olympics could easily be mistaken for a supporter of the Yushin regime or the military government. It was a time when people were extremely cautious about even mentioning the word “Olympics,” due to both political and economic concerns.

KWAAK YoungHoon: You are absolutely right. I was criticized as if I were supporting a hidden political agenda to extend the regime. But as you now know, my dream of hosting the Olympics first began in 1964 — not for politics, but as a strategic vision to make Korea move forward. I wanted the world to see Korea not just as a war-torn, miserable country, but as a nation with a rich cultural heritage and a long history of peace.

As all Koreans know, we carry the 5,000-year-old spirit of *Hongik Ingan* (弘益人間), which means ‘to widely benefit all humanity.’ I simply wanted to embody that spirit of spreading good to others, reflecting the axiom *Jaese Ihwa* (在世理化), meaning ‘to practice reason and harmony in the real world.’

KIM Kwangsoo: You’re right. Korea has a long-standing spirit and belief rooted in *Hongik Ingan* and *Jaese Ihwa*.

Well, after such a long and tortuous journey, you finally succeeded. In 1981, at the 84th International Olympic Committee (IOC) meeting held in Baden-Baden, West Germany, Seoul was officially selected as the host city for the 24th Olympic Games. The dream you conceived in 1964 was finally realized 17 years later. I assume that you must have been incredibly busy... I mean, even busier than before.

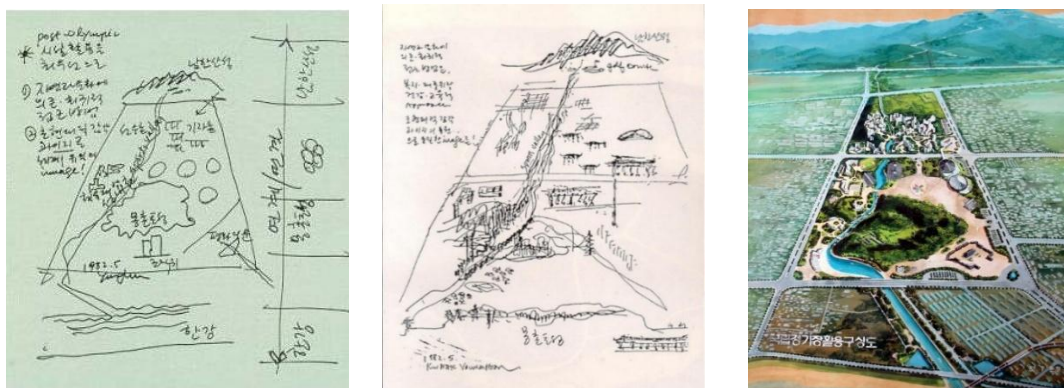
KWAAK YoungHoon: “Thank God,” I said to myself. “I finally made it, after 24 years of preparatory work!” And of course, I became busy, busy, busy... and ‘very’ busy. After Seoul was confirmed as the host city, the Seoul Olympic Organizing Committee was established. The KWAAK Environmental Studies and Policy Research Institute, Inc. (KWAAK E.S.P.R.I.), which I had founded and served as President, was put in charge of designing and supervising the construction of the Olympic Park.

I had already developed a master plan concept that I had been envisioning for a long time. It was designed with the clear intention that the Seoul Olympic Park would be highly functional and well-utilized both during and after the Games. All that remained was to put the plan into action.

KIM Kwangsoo: Did everything go smoothly? I imagine there must have been countless obstacles along the way.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Just as you expected, I encountered many difficulties right from the very beginning of preparations. The government budget was only 12 million won — about 10,000 dollars — which was absurdly small compared to the scale of the project, covering more than 250 hectares. However, it was impossible to reduce the project’s scale to fit the budget. In the end, I decided to invest my own labor and private funds to make it happen.

The athletes’ village, press village, and various stadiums were all to be built on the main site. I also established secondary and higher education sports schools around the Olympic stadium so that the facilities could continue to be used long after the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games. It was truly a project into which I poured both my money and my soul.



▲ Sketch of Olympic Park Master Plan & Conceptual Drawing of Olympic Park Master Plan

KIM Kwangsoo: I feel deeply moved. Were there any other difficulties during the construction process besides financing?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Many, many challenges kept coming one after another. Before constructing the new athletic buildings, the Olympic Preparatory Committee faced intense conflicts over whether to preserve cultural assets or not. Some well-known experts suggested removing *Mongchontoseong* — a more than 2,000-year-old Baekje Dynasty earthen fortress — to build athletic facilities and a TV tower in its place.

KIM Kwangsoo: I can't understand the idea of destroying Mongchontoseong, an earthen fortress over 2,000 years old. In 2001, Taliban leader Mullah Muhammad Omar destroyed the Bamiyan stone Buddhas in Afghanistan, claiming to eliminate idolatry. Then, in 2017, the Islamic Sunni militant group IS bombed the al-Nuri Mosque in Iraq. Such acts of cultural genocide, carried out under the guise of war, are a sin against human heritage. Yet it is even more distressing that, even though it wasn't a time of war, some argued that we should demolish our own cultural heritage for the sake of an international event. It's really shameful.

KWAAK YoungHoon: To them, the 300,000-square-meter Baekje-era heritage site seemed like nothing more than a pile of dirt. To persuade them, I showed a picture of the Rubble Hill in Munich Olympic Park — an artificial hill that Germany built using debris from World War II for the 1972 Munich Olympic Games. "They created a hill from wartime rubble so that spectators and visitors could relax between events," I explained. Then I added, "We already have a large, natural, and historically rich site that offers the same purpose." In the end, the decision was made to preserve Mongchontoseong.

And then, something interesting happened that I wasn't aware of. Although we didn't have much time for construction, the Seoul Olympic Park Master Plan was unexpectedly put into an international design competition, seemingly in an attempt to disregard my original schematic plan. As a result, our firm was forced to participate in the competition as well. But the outcome was quite surprising because there was no winner. In the end, the final master plan was almost identical to the one originally proposed by our company, including the full preservation of the 30 hectares of Mongchontoseong.

Construction of the Olympic Park and all its facilities began in April 1984 and was completed two

years later, in April 1986 — just in time for the Seoul Asian Games. I had also recommended that the Seoul Olympic Organizing Committee host the Asian Games as a test-run for the Olympics. After the successful hosting of the Asian Games, many officials, bureaucrats, and politicians quickly became involved in Olympic preparation meetings.



▲ Mongchontoseong (Earthen Fortress)

The Crisis of Returning the Olympic Hosting Rights Just Before the Event

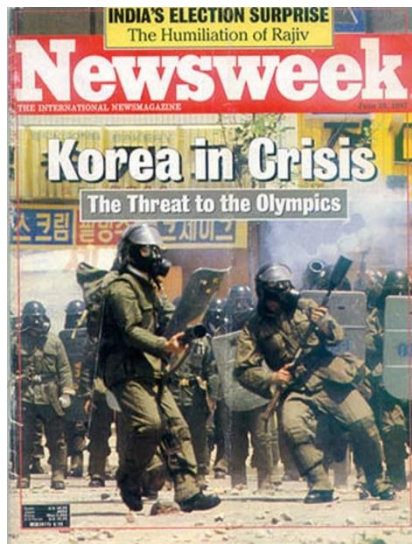
KIM Kwangsoo: As far as I remember, public opinion was largely against hosting the Olympics in Seoul — even up until the year before the Games. Perhaps this was due to the extreme instability of the domestic situation at the time?

KWAAK YoungHoon: That's right. Although government officials were confident of a successful Olympics after the 1986 Asian Games, the public still suspected that the government intended to use the event to extend the military regime. Don't you remember? Even in the middle of 1988 — the very year of the Olympics — the domestic political situation was still terrifying. As vividly portrayed in the movie *1987*, the democratization movement against the new military regime — which had taken power following the previous one — was rapidly spreading across the country. In response, the regime cracked down on the demonstrations.

In January 1987, PARK Jong-cheol, a Seoul National University student, died under torture. Then, in June, LEE Han-yeol, a Yonsei University student, was killed by a police-fired tear gas canister. Protests continued one after another, and the scale of the demonstrations kept growing. To make matters worse, a growing sense of crisis emerged that war might break out again on the Korean Peninsula. This fear was heightened by the bombing of Korean Air Flight 857 in November 1987, which killed all 115 passengers on board.

As a result, the number of foreign athletes openly refusing to participate in the 1988 Seoul Olympics increased rapidly by the day. Even the IOC warned, "If the chaos in Korea does not subside, it will be difficult to host the Olympic Games in Seoul." The likelihood of the Olympics taking place in Seoul grew even slimmer when Tom Bradley, the Mayor of Los Angeles — the host city of the 1984 Olympics — announced that Los Angeles could host the 1988 Games again if given just three months to prepare.

KIM Kwangsoo: However, despite widespread concerns and low expectations both at home and abroad, the Seoul Olympics ultimately achieved unprecedented success in history. How was such a reversal possible?



▲ Chaos in Korea, 1987

KWAAK YoungHoon: You wouldn't believe how this terrifying situation turned around so miraculously, and how it all came about! I firmly believed that the majority of Koreans were eager and anxious for the successful hosting of the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games, hoping it would break down the ideological wall between the East and the West and promote rapprochement between North and South Korea. Honestly, that was my hopeful vision.

KIM Kwangsoo: It seems that you were more eager to host the Seoul Olympics than anyone else.

KWAAK YoungHoon: You are absolutely right. Do you know what I did? I started traveling all over the world. I visited major cities such as Montreal, Tokyo, and Singapore, to appeal for support for Seoul's bid to host the Olympics. However, attracting foreign cooperation was impossible unless domestic political problems were fully resolved first.

Convincing Opposition Party Leader KIM Dae-jung

KWAAK YoungHoon: Out of urgency, I went to meet KIM Dae-jung, the leader of the opposition party, the Peace and Democratic Party, called Pyungmindang. I asked Lawyer LEE Tae-young, who considered me like a son and was very close to KIM Dae-jung, to help arrange the appointment. Then, I went to the Peace and Democratic Party's office, located on the first floor of the National Assembly building. President KIM Dae-jung was there waiting for me.

I said, "For the Seoul Olympics to be held safely, stability in the domestic political situation is absolutely necessary. Please help to calm the so-called democracy protests for a while." Then President KIM replied, "How can I stop the protests? Besides, many believe that the Seoul Olympics are being used to legitimize the illegal rise to power of the current military government and to extend its rule." He also added, "The idea of hosting the Olympic Games in Seoul was originally conceived by the military government."

That second comment gave me a wonderful opportunity to rebut his claim. The first point I made very, very clear was that the idea was originally conceived by me in 1964, not by the military regime. I told him, “I was the one who prepared and advised Mayor KOO Jachoon of Seoul on building the National Sports Center, which began in 1977 and was completed in 1984, just two years before the Asian Games. I also asked him in 1976 to build it with a capacity of 100,000 seats.”

Mr. KOO wondered why it needed to be built so big. I told him we might use it as the main stadium for the Seoul Olympics. He asked me if such a large stadium existed, and I told him about the Los Angeles Memorial Coliseum, which was used for the L.A. Olympic Games. I also explained that the Olympic Park was originally conceived and entirely planned by me. The 1986 Asian Games were held there, and as you know, the facilities and hosting capabilities were all successfully tested.

But he yawned several times because it was after the lunchtime, and it was very difficult to hold his attention. At any rate, I continued with my second point: “I don’t know if the current government is trying to use the Olympics to extend its regime. However, I am absolutely certain that hosting the Olympic Games will draw the world’s attention to Korea, making it nearly impossible to prolong the military regime. The Seoul Olympics will have a global impact, helping to resolve the East-West ideological conflicts, and will undoubtedly serve as a significant catalyst for remarkable economic development.”

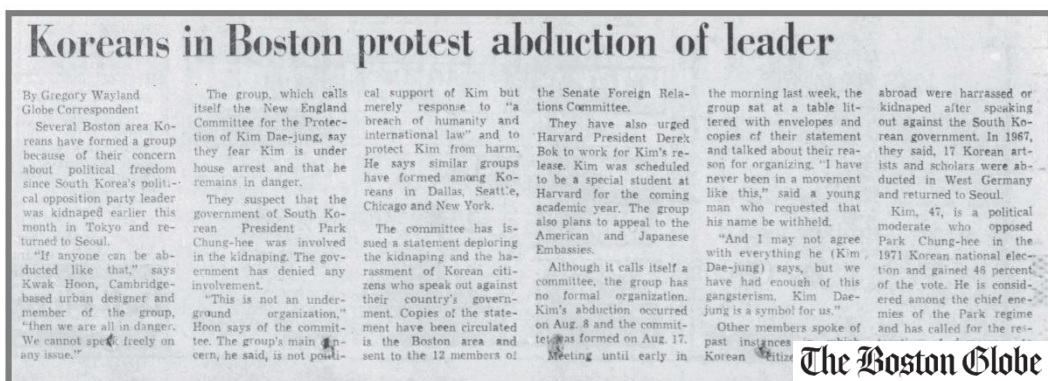
After two hours of persuasion, I finally received a positive response from President KIM. Since he already knew me well, he accepted my appeal without any further doubt.

[KIM Kwangsoo: It’s surprising that you persuaded President KIM Dae-jung, who is known as a master of dialogue and persuasion, through conversation. How did you come to know him?](#)

KWAAK YoungHoon: Persuading President KIM was not easy, because he firmly believed that the military government had started the whole idea to extend their regime. But when I told him that I first conceived the idea of hosting the Olympics in 1964 when I watched the Tokyo Olympics, and that I had studied for 10 years and worked for over 14 years despite harsh criticism from the government, President KIM began to change his mind.

The second — and more important — factor that made the persuasion possible was that President KIM already knew I had played an effective role in helping to rescue him when he was abducted in Tokyo, Japan, on August 8, 1973. At the time, I was studying at Harvard University’s Graduate School of Education. Professor Edwin Reischauer, who was then at his summer home in Cape Cod, informed me of the incident through Professor Gregory Henderson. Upon hearing the news, I went with Professors Richard Wagner and Gregory Henderson to seek help from Harvard University President Derek Bok at his office in Harvard Yard. I had known President Bok since his time as Dean of Harvard Law School, so no formal introduction was necessary. He told us he would take action, although he didn’t specify what. I later found out what he did — but I’ll keep that to myself for now.

When the incident became a diplomatic issue between Korea and Japan, President KIM Dae-jung was released to his home in Donggyo-dong five days after the kidnapping. Some time later, I gave an interview to a reporter from the *Boston Globe* about the incident. At the time, many people suspected that it had been orchestrated by the PARK Chung-hee government. However, I didn’t want Korea’s image to be tarnished in the eyes of the international community. This is exactly what I said in the interview: “I don’t think the Korean government did anything like that. But that case is a clear violation of human rights and a breach of international law.”

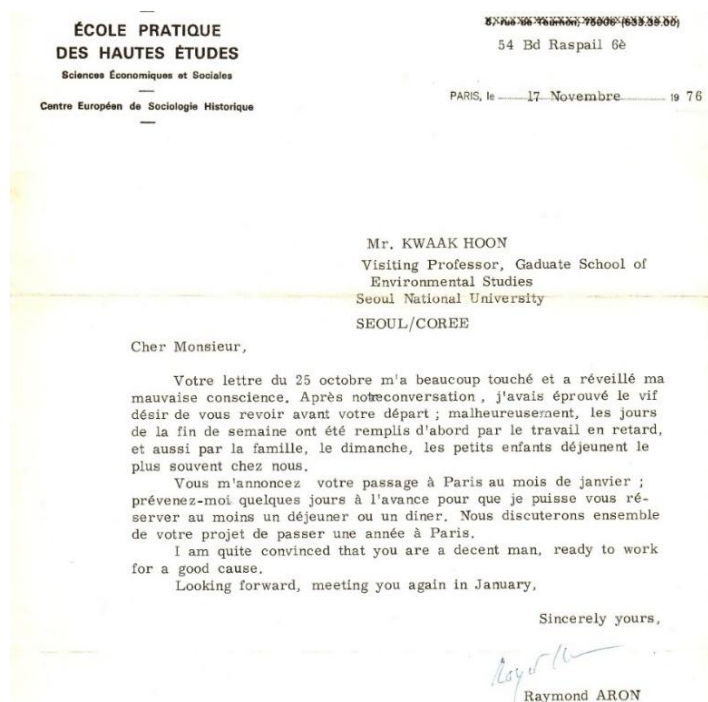


▲ Article on the Abduction of President KIM Dae-jung, September 2, 1973

However, after the interview was published in the *Boston Globe*, flyers began circulating around Boston that read, “KWAACK YoungHoon’s house is the headquarters of the KIM Dae-jung rescue movement.” Shockingly, the flyer even included my home address: 20A Prescott Street, Cambridge, Massachusetts — the apartment where I lived, right next to Harvard Yard.

In the following year, 1974, I was invited to return to Korea as a professor at Seoul National University’s Graduate School of Environmental Studies. However, my appointment was blocked by the Korean Central Intelligence Agency under the pretext of my involvement in the KIM Dae-jung rescue campaign. In other words, my appointment as a professor at Seoul National University was denied.

President YOON Chun-joo of Seoul National University personally informed me of this decision at the so-called *Acropolis* area on campus. I remember that Professor Raymond Aron had visited there not long before and had planted a tree. I later corresponded with him in Paris, and we became close friends.



▲ A Letter from Raymond Aaron

KIM Kwangsoo: It was utterly deplorable that PARK Chung-hee's regime, blinded by its scheme to prolong military rule, failed to recognize and instead obstructed talented individuals who could have contributed to national development.

KWAAK YoungHoon: From this fiasco, I came to understand even more clearly the abhorrent reality of what a bad government can do to harm innocent people. Fortunately, in my case, several private universities offered me professorships, and I accepted a position as an Associate Professor at Hongik University.

Although I had no political ties with President KIM Dae-jung, he likely felt indebted to me because of the unfortunate and unjust treatment I endured after helping to save him during his life-or-death kidnapping.

KIM Kwangsoo: President KIM Dae-jung must have trusted you deeply, as you participated in his rescue despite personal risks. That trust likely played a significant role in supporting the successful hosting of the Seoul Olympics.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Looking back, I believe he was definitely persuaded and came to understand my sincere intentions, even though it was completely contrary to his previous belief. Again, my argument was that by successfully hosting the 1988 Seoul Olympics, the military government would not be able to extend its regime, and Korea would enter a new era of peace and prosperity. I'll leave it to your judgment, but the demonstrations noticeably decreased and eventually stopped.

Hand- in- Hand, We Go Over the Wall

KWAAK YoungHoon: As you and I know, the domestic situation was difficult, but the situation outside Korea was also dismal. Conflicts over religion, race, and ideology intensified, and the Olympic Games, which were supposed to be the world's sports festival, turned into a political battlefield over time.

At the 1972 Munich Olympic Games, members of the Palestinian organization known as Black September assassinated several Israeli athletes. At the 1976 Montreal Olympics, a large number of African nations boycotted the Games in protest of Apartheid, resulting in the absence of many Black athletes. The 1980 Moscow Olympics were boycotted by the capitalist bloc, while the 1984 Los Angeles Olympics were boycotted by the communist bloc in return.

I believed that we could not expect a peaceful Olympics if the Games were allowed to be used as a stage for international conflicts. So, I kept thinking of ways to make the Seoul Olympics a peaceful Olympics. Then, on June 29, 1987, on a flight from Tokyo to Seoul via Singapore, an idea flashed through my mind like a lightning bolt — I would create an organization dedicated to the success of the Seoul Olympics and the promotion of world peace. It seemed far more effective for people with a shared purpose to come together and speak with one official voice, rather than acting individually.

KIM Kwangsoo: The organization that was born from that idea is the World Citizens Organization (WCO), right?



▲ WCO Logo

KWAAK YoungHoon: You're right. At that time, I felt an urgent need to appeal to global leaders who valued peace and thought beyond national boundaries. Amid the height of political turmoil in Korea, the WCO coined the term, "Olympeace" by combining 'Olympic' and 'Peace,' and established a working group called the Seoul Assembly of Olympeace (SAO).

The SAO was established to lead the Olympeace Movement, and its four core principles were as follows:

1. Olympics without Boycotts
2. Suspension of Political Conflicts during the Olympic Games
3. Competition in the Spirit of Fair Play
4. Contribution to World Peace

Fortunately, many Korean leaders from almost every field joined the effort. With the help of SEO Young-hoon, Secretary-General of the Korean Red Cross, the SAO Committee was established, bringing together prominent figures such as peace activist HAM Seok-heon, lawyer LEE Tae-young, former President of the Republic of Korea YUN Bo-seon, Pastor HAN Kyung-jik, former Minister of Education KIM Ok-gil, poets GOO Sang and SUL Chang-soo, children's songwriter YOON Suk-joong, and many other respected individuals. HAM Seok-heon, who had dedicated his life to the peace movement, was appointed chairman, while I served as vice-chairman, taking charge of the committee's operations.

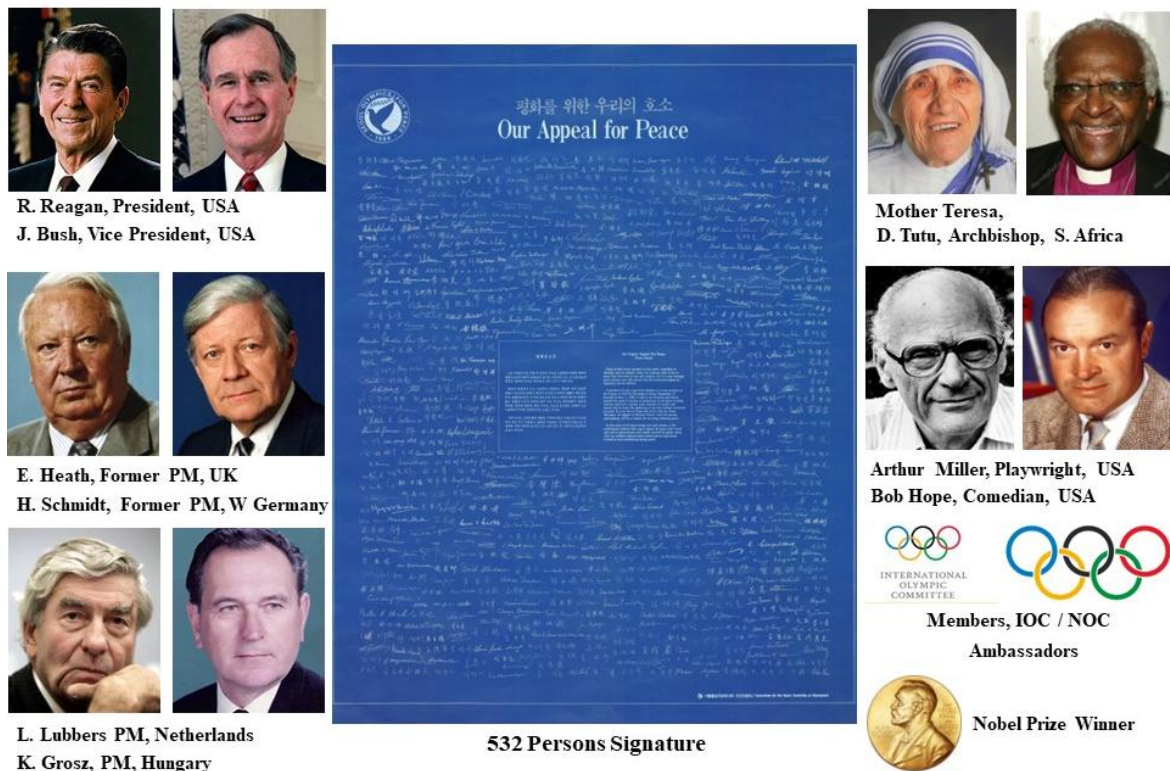


▲ SAO Committee Meeting (1987) and Dr. KWAAK YoungHoon Explaining the Purpose of the SAO's Establishment

KWAAK YoungHoon: The Committee drafted a document titled “Appeal for a Peaceful Olympics” to promote the spirit of Olympeace worldwide. This document was translated into several languages, including English, French, German, Spanish, and Russian, and was sent to influential figures around the world.

KIM Kwangsoo: Did the appeal succeed in moving people?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It far exceeded my expectations. To be exact, 532 people from home and abroad signed the appeal, including President Reagan of the United States, Prime Minister Heath of the United Kingdom, Chancellor Schmidt of West Germany, President LEE Teng-hui of Taiwan, and playwright Arthur Miller. To name just a few more, there were also Father Tutu, Mother Teresa, and comedian Bob Hope. With their signed appeals and support, we were able to overcome the crisis of potentially cancelling the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games, not to mention avoiding a boycott.



▲ 532 People from Home and Abroad Signed the Appeal

Finally, on September 17, 1988, the long-awaited Seoul Olympic Games opened at the main stadium in front of 100,000 spectators. It was the first peaceful Olympic Games in 12 years, with participation from both capitalist and communist countries. After dreaming of hosting the Seoul Olympics for 24 years while watching the Tokyo Olympics in 1964, I was overwhelmed with emotion as I saw that dream become a reality right before my eyes.

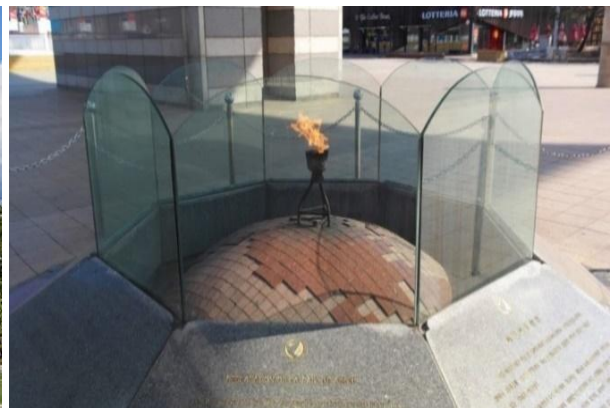
KIM Kwangsoo: This must have been an especially meaningful moment for you. I will never forget that day either. At the opening ceremony, after the Taekwondo team broke down the walls on stage, the scene of a little boy rolling a hoop alone into the main stadium remains vividly etched in my mind. Thousands of spectators held their breath as they listened to the sound of the hoop rolling. When the boy reached the center of the stadium and waved to the crowd, my heart was pounding uncontrollably.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Actually, I cried too. That boy was born on the very day Seoul was selected to host the Olympics at the IOC meeting in Baden-Baden. The dark, war-torn image of Korea — the country of orphans and beggars — disappeared completely. To many global observers, Korea's brilliantly orchestrated and cultured performances were almost unbelievable. This was especially true for people from communist countries. Every Russian and person from communist nations I met after the Seoul Olympics invariably said to me, "We have been deceived for the past 70 years." They also told me, "We thought Korea was so poor, and could never host the Olympic Games!"

From this viewpoint, the fall of the ideological wall marked the beginning of the end of the four-decade Cold War. The spirit of the Eternal Peace Flame, located at the very center of the World Peace Gate, symbolizes the closing of 20th-century history with a celebration of Olympeace rather than with bloodshed and war. Consequently, Koreans contributed to enabling world citizens to travel freely beyond the Iron and Bamboo Curtains.



▲ World Peace Gate



▲ Eternal Peace Flame

KIM Kwangsoo: I also remember the official theme song, "Hand in Hand," performed by the group Koreana at the end of the opening ceremony.

KWAAK YoungHoon: It was a song praying for world peace and for making the world a better place to live. I was so happy that Seoul became a place where people from all over the world could connect "Hand in Hand and over the Walls of Ideology," just like the lyrics of the song.

Did you know I even had a serious series of discussions with the songwriter, Professor KIM Munhwan? He was a brilliant philosopher of aesthetics and a dear friend of mine. His song was deeply meaningful and perfectly expressed the Korean *Hongik* spirit of benefiting others widely.

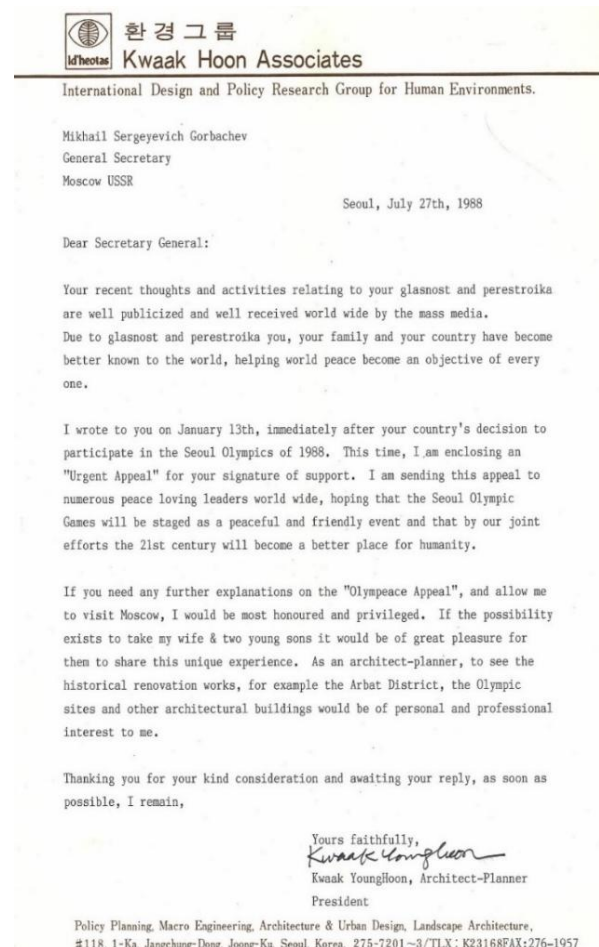
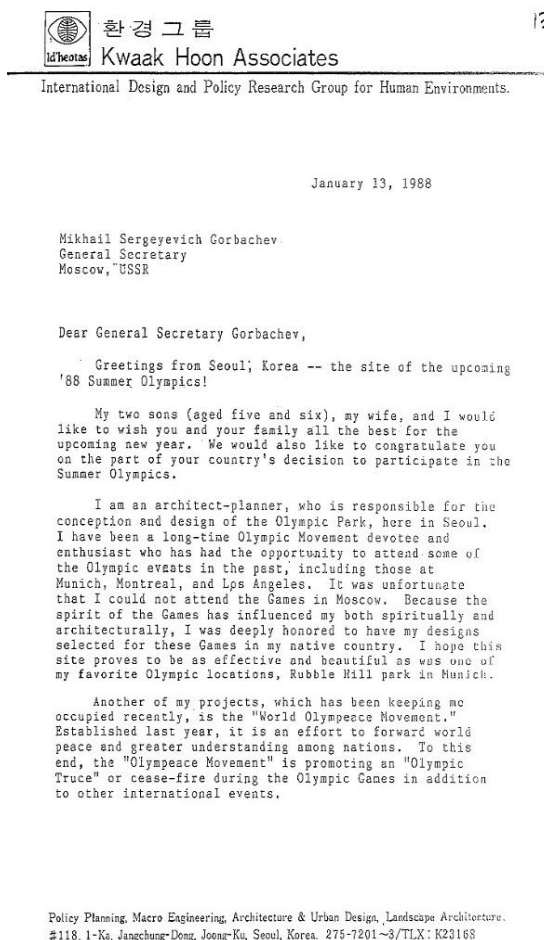
A Letter to Gorbachev

KWAAK YoungHoon: There's an interesting story behind how the Seoul Olympics became a peaceful event, with participation not only from the so-called 'capitalist side' but also from the 'communist side.'

In 1987, the WCO-SAO was actively conducting the *Olympeace Movement*. At that time, direct exchanges between South Korea and the communist bloc were not possible, as South Korea had not yet established diplomatic relations with those countries. After much thought, I had a serious and careful discussion with a foreign ambassador to Korea, with whom I had a close and friendly relationship. I pleaded with him to deliver a letter to Soviet Secretary-General Mikhail Gorbachev. At first, the ambassador firmly refused due to his official position and legal constraints. However, he eventually agreed after hearing my earnest appeal.

The essence of the two letters sent to Gorbachev was as follows:

"The Olympics are a celebration of peace and a festival for the youth, so please do not boycott them. I am merely an architect, planner, and professor, completely unrelated to politics, with no hidden intentions. I will build a Reception House for you in Seoul, where you can stay and receive guests during your visit to the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games. Please consider coming to Korea."



▲ Two Letters to Gorbachev

KIM Kwangsoo: It's like a movie. Did you really build a house for Gorbachev to stay in?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, indeed. His Reception House was completed in November 1987, at the eastern foot of Namsan Mountain in the heart of Seoul. I personally designed and built it for Gorbachev and named it the *Olympeace House*. I had also reached an agreement with Mayor YEOM Bo-hyun of Seoul to build a separate access route to the house for security purposes, once Gorbachev's visit to Korea was confirmed.

As you know, Gorbachev did not end up coming to the Seoul Olympics. But as soon as I completed the Olympeace House in preparation for his stay, very good news came from Moscow — the USSR officially announced their participation in the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games.

I practically catapulted to the ceiling of the newly completed Olympeace House. I was very, very, very happy!



▲ The Olympeace House (Constructed Specifically as a Reception House for Mikhail Gorbachev)

KIM Kwangsoo: It must have been disappointing that Gorbachev didn't come. Could it be that he never actually received the letter?

KWAAK YoungHoon: That's what I thought at first. Although I had no doubt that my ambassador friend delivered the letters, I still wondered if the Kremlin had made a mistake or if something else — something beyond my understanding — had occurred.

However, the big surprise came in 1994, six years after the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games, when a drama-like meeting with Gorbachev confirmed that the letters and my sincere intentions had indeed been delivered to him.

That year, I was able to meet Gorbachev at the World Peace Leaders' Summit hosted by the Moon Sun Myung Peace Foundation. After lunch, I noticed Gorbachev and his wife sitting at the table just across from mine. So, I went over to greet him and said, "I am KWAAK YoungHoon, the architect and planner who built the Reception House for you in Seoul." Gorbachev stood up, shook my hand, and with a bright smile said, "I read your letter." Then he invited me to sit down next to him.

Isn't this like a drama? What followed was a far more unbelievable and shocking conversation. He said, "I'm going to tell you a story I have never shared with anyone before, so make sure to write it in your memoir later."

"Before the Seoul Olympics, KIM Il-sung, President of North Korea, came to Moscow, and I met him at the Kremlin. After talking for a while, I asked him what his purpose was in coming all the way from Pyongyang to the Kremlin. KIM Il-sung said, 'Let's isolate South Korea!' So, I asked, 'What do you mean, and how can we isolate South Korea?' KIM replied, 'Let's boycott the Seoul Olympic Games.' I said, 'As a person who advocates *Perestroika* and *Glasnost*, I cannot agree with your suggestion. Moreover, I cannot support anything that goes against my conviction to open a new era.' Kim Il-sung returned to North Korea greatly disappointed by my refusal."

KIM Kwangsoo: That's what happened. It's a much, much more interesting story — one that historians should record accurately. Thanks to Gorbachev's decision to participate in the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games, every communist country in Eastern Europe and Asia — except North Korea — as well as pro-communist African countries took part in the Games.

Eternal Peace Flame and The Behind-the-Scenes Story

KIM Kwangsoo: Now, the story of the Seoul Olympic Games seems to be coming to an end, but are there any untold stories about the Seoul Olympics?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, there are many, many more — in fact, a plethora of episodes. But you may be particularly interested in the Eternal Peace Flame Lighting Ceremony, which was planned by the SAO and both designed and produced by KWAAK E.S.P.R.I.

As you may be aware, the Eternal Peace Flame was first lit to signal the opening of the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games. Unlike the Olympic flame brought from Greece, it is still burning at the center of the World Peace Gate, and it is intended to burn eternally, as it was conceived.

KIM Kwangsoo: How did the ceremony go?

KWAAK YoungHoon: HAM Seok-heon and members of the SAO were originally planned to light the Eternal Peace Flame. However, just a few days before the ceremony, the SAO Executive Committee was informed that President ROH Tae-woo wished to join the lighting ceremony, and that IOC Chairman Juan Antonio Samaranch also wanted to take part in the ceremony. We welcomed the proposal, but I had difficulty preparing two additional poles.

As you can see in the photo, all three ended up holding a single ignition pole together. It went very well. In fact, I thought it looked even better — one pole held by three people, symbolizing "Hand in Hand" — rather than three separate poles held by separate hands.



▲ Lighting of the Eternal Peace Flame

HAM Seok-heon (in white), ROH Tae-woo (center), and Juan Antonio Samaranch (far right)

KIM Kwangsoo: I heard you also had real big problem of constructing the flame nozzle.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I did! Let me tell you just how precarious the situation was. To prepare for the ceremony, I had only three months to design and construct the Eternal Peace Flame.

As you may know, the base of the Flame combines three traditional Korean shapes — a circle representing the sky, an octagon symbolizing the Earth, and a triangle representing the people. These elements were made from granite stones. The most challenging part was manufacturing the fine flame that appears above the tetrahedron-shaped nozzle. A high level of technology was required to precisely control the volume of the ignited flame. We found that no one in Korea could make it. One of the SAO members found a company in Japan, and I immediately contacted their branch factory in Bucheon, near Seoul. However, the company's estimated manufacturing cost was far beyond our budget, but I had no choice but to ask them anyway. Then an unsolvable problem arose — they were uncertain whether they could meet the deadline.



▲ Construction of the Eternal Peace Flame

KIM Kwangsoo: Oh, you must have been in a panic! The ignition ceremony was less than a week away, right? And they weren't confident they could build a properly functioning flame nozzle in time?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, they couldn't manufacture it in time! I was in really, really big trouble! Let me tell you about those long, agonizing days. I was sitting in my Olympeace House, looking out at the trees of Namsan Forest, thinking about what to do in such a catastrophic situation. I looked down at my hands and counted my five fingers. Couldn't I make it with my own hands? Then I murmured words like "world," "humanity," "environment," "future," and "peace" — one word for each finger.

KIM Kwangsoo: Wait, wait. Did you make it yourself? What does that have to do with making the nozzle?

KWAAK YoungHoon: No, no, I couldn't make it myself. But those words later became a key concept in the master plan for the Daejeon Expo site.

KIM Kwangsoo: I don't quite understand now, but I'll ask you later how these words relate to the conceptualization of the Daejeon Expo Master Plan.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Sorry for the digression, but it suddenly occurred to me that I could find someone with skilled hands in the Cheonggyecheon area, right in the heart of old Seoul. Did you know this local spot was nicknamed the "Silicon Valley of Seoul?" That gave me the hint that I might find someone there who could get the job done.

KIM Kwangsoo: So, did you find someone?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I found a young man like a miracle! I think he was about 28 years old and had come to Seoul a few years earlier from Gunsan city in Jeollabuk-do (North Jeolla Province). He had been working at the Sewoon electronics shop in Cheonggyecheon. I asked him to make the nozzle and the ignition pole. Then I showed him my tetrahedron model and asked him to make a flame nozzle to be placed at the very top of the tetrahedron, which would sit atop the globe-shaped stone base.

KIM Kwangsoo: He accepted your request with only five days left?

KWAAK YoungHoon: He didn't hesitate at all. In fact, he even suggested making three different nozzles with varying flame sizes. He asked me to come back the next day to choose the one I was most satisfied with. Isn't he an angel? If this young engineer hadn't been in Cheonggyecheon, there wouldn't have been a flame on that historic opening day.

KIM Kwangsoo: How much did he ask you to pay for his work?

KWAAK YoungHoon: He charged me... don't be surprised — only 1% of what the Japanese company in Bucheon asked for. Unbelievable, right? It's an amazing story! This young man was an

honest and capable engineer, truly a decent person. He was a savior to the SAO. From that day on, I began to believe that history needs to be rewritten more accurately. It wouldn't be fair to record only the three people who lit the Eternal Peace Flame and overlook him.

KIM Kwangsoo: The Eternal Peace Flame was born from the hands of a young man who worked silently in an unseen place. If you hadn't told me, I would never have known this young man existed.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I couldn't properly express my gratitude to him, nor could I find a way to invite him to the Olympics. Even now, I have no way to contact him. He must be about 64 years old by now.

KIM Kwangsoo: That's right. I wonder where he is and how he is doing now. Did the ceremony to light the Eternal Peace Flame — after so many twists and turns — go off smoothly?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes! But there was another important pre-event that had to take place. On September 11, just a couple of days before the Lighting Ceremony, the 'Seed of the Eternal Peace Flame' was lit atop Mt. Manisan at the worship site called *Chamsongdan*. The first spark was kindled there, at a place embodying the spirit of *Hongik Ingan*, which means 'widely benefiting all humanity' and represents humanitarianism. What I wanted was for the Eternal Peace Flame to burn 'eternally' — not just during the 1988 Seoul Olympics, but long afterward.

I carried the Eternal Peace Flame, which was lit at the Chamsongdan Worship Platform in the morning, to Seoul Olympic Park, where the Lighting Ceremony took place at 3 p.m. the following day.



▲ Lighting the Torch at Chamsongdan

After the successful lighting ceremony, most of the attendees moved to the Global Sculpture Park, located west of Mongchontoseong, a historic earthen fortress. However, peace movement leader HAM Seok-heon did not leave the Eternal Peace Flame. A single tear streamed down the pale cheeks of the 88-year-old man. He took my hand, called me over, and spoke softly, "Now we have triumphed over Japan. I believe I've lived all this time to see this moment. I can die peacefully now."

A few months later, in February 1989, on a day when the winter wind was especially harsh, Ham Seok-heon passed away. The funeral ceremony was held in the auditorium of Osan High School in Seoul. I remember Pastor MOON Ik-Hwan's high-pitched eulogy, and how everyone in attendance was weeping.



▲ HAM Seok-heon Holds Dr. KWAAK's Hand and Weeps
After the Lightening Ceremony of the Eternal Peace Flame

The Daejeon Expo 1993: A Bold Leap into the Future

Making History Once Again

KIM Kwangsoo: Five years after the success of the 1988 Seoul Olympics, another large-scale global event — the Daejeon Expo 1993 — was successfully held, marking Korea’s emergence as one of the world’s advanced nations. You were involved behind the scenes at the Daejeon Expo as well, weren’t you?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I was. As you may know, *the Vigor Axis* was drawn in 1971, and Daejeon — along with the central region of South Korea — was designated as a nexus point for future global events. Naturally, I proposed that the Expo be held in Daejeon.

KIM Kwangsoo: Which government was it?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It was the government of CHUN Doo-hwan. In 1981, when Seoul was confirmed as the host city for the 1988 Olympic Games, I immediately proposed to Dr. KIM Jae-ik — Chief Economic Policy Advisor to the President — that we also bid to host the Expo in Daejeon, the second strategic nexus I had designated in the 1971 *Master Vision and Implementation Plan* (MVIP) for South Korea.

Thanks to Dr. KIM’s remarkable intelligence and extraordinary decisiveness, the process of preparing Daejeon’s Expo bid began smoothly. My dream, first sparked in 1964 at the New York World’s Fair — where I was guided by a local high school student named Debbie — was finally beginning to come true.

KIM Kwangsoo: KIM Jae-ik, the Chief Secretary for Economic Policy, was the person often referred to as the “Economic President” during the Fifth Republic, right? He died in the Aung San Mausoleum bombing.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I was deeply grieved by the loss of one of Korea’s greatest public servants. After Dr. KIM’s sudden death in 1983, the plan to host the Expo in Korea was temporarily put on hold. It was later revived by the ROH Tae-woo administration following the success of the 1988 Seoul Olympics. Despite many challenges, in 1990, Daejeon was unanimously selected as the host city for the Expo at the General Assembly of the Bureau International des Expositions (BIE), headquartered in Paris.

KIM Kwangsoo: Wow, what were the key reasons behind Daejeon’s unanimous selection? Even though Korea’s national status has improved since the 1988 Seoul Olympics, Korea was still classified as a developing country.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Certainly, the successful hosting of the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games played a

significant role in the BIE's decision. However, another important factor was that Korea was still classified as a developing country as you mentioned. Unlike the Olympics, where all stadiums are constructed using the host country's budget, the Expo requires participating countries to build their own pavilions at their own expense. At that time, as countries competed to host the Expo and build their exhibition halls, the cost of participation was rising exponentially in each nation. As a result, developing countries lacking economic power were naturally marginalized and found it increasingly difficult to take part in the Expo.

The Daejeon Expo Organizing Committee emphasized that it was time to move away from selecting venues solely in developed countries. I stressed the importance of hosting an Expo that would facilitate a transition, including not only the so-called developed 'North' countries but also the developing 'South' countries.

That's why the main theme I proposed was "Finding a Technological Way Between North and South." At the same time, Korea was in the process of joining the OECD, and we used this as a key point to emphasize that Korea could serve as a bridge between developed and developing countries.



▲ Interview as the Master Planner of the Daejeon Expo

KIM Kwangsoo: That's how you convinced the President of the BIE and its member countries.

KWAAK YoungHoon: It wasn't me who made the direct persuasion, but I strongly advised NA Woong-bae, the Chairman of the Preparatory Committee.

However, I thought the preparation time was too short to host the event as scheduled in 1992, as I anticipated there would be a lot of confusion. Not only was it difficult to secure a sufficient budget, but the bureaucrats also lacked the necessary experience to manage such a large Expo project. NA's Committee was panicked, so I decided to recommend postponing the event by one year.

No one was optimistic about the postponement. The Committee members were all skeptical because there had never been a case like this before. But I didn't want Korea to perform unprepared, so I pushed very hard. In the end, my suggestion prevailed, and it was decided that the event would be held in 1993 instead of 1992. There were many twists and turns in persuading both the Korean government and the BIE. You probably weren't aware of this fact, as it was never made public.

Daejeon Expo, Road to a New Leap

KIM Kwangsoo: From the Expo theme to the master plan for the venue, I imagine that everything was your work, right?

KWAAK YoungHoon: You're right. As you may already know, the theme of the Daejeon Expo had already been outlined when I drew the Vigor Axis across the Korean Peninsula in 1971 while studying in the United States.

Korea's rapid growth had both its bright and dark sides. As the economy developed, the quality of life improved and the nation's status gradually rose. However, problems such as the destruction of traditional culture, environmental pollution, and regional imbalances also began to accumulate. These issues were not unique to Korea but were common to most countries undergoing industrialization.

While immediate economic development is important, I believed it was equally — if not more — important to preserve traditional culture and the natural environment, ensuring they are passed on to future generations from a long-term perspective.

My original concept was “Finding a Technological Way Between North and South,” which served as a parallel to the 1988 Seoul Olympics' concept of “Breaking the Ideological Wall Between the East and the West.” Based on this conceptualization, the official theme of the Daejeon Expo 1993 was established as “The Road to a New Leap.” The two sub-themes were “Harmony of Traditional Skills and Modern Technology” and “Efficient Use and Recycling of Resources.”

KIM Kwangsoo: I see. I think that was a perfect theme for the Expo — an event that showcases advanced science and technology from around the world while presenting a vision for the future of humanity.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Thank you for your kind words. I set three key principles when drafting the master plan to realized the theme of the Expo:

1. All individual events of the Expo are ultimately planned to converge toward a single theme.
2. While previous Expos focused primarily on the exhibiting material civilization, the Daejeon Expo focuses on individual experiential activities.
3. Facilities are designed with long-term impact in mind, so that the Expo's theme can continue to be realized even after the event has ended.

In accordance with those principles, the Main Tower, called *Hanbit*, was placed at the center of the Expo venu, and it embodied my old motto from 1967 — “Se · In · Hwan · Rae · Pyung” (세 · 인 · 환 · 래 · 평, 世 · 人 · 環 · 來 · 平), which means to think “globally, humanly, environmentally, futuristically, and peacefully.”

Then, I asked Korean business conglomerates to build four pavilions on the west side of the Expo site, each funded by their own budgets and inspired by my finger motto developed in 1967 during the challenging preparation days of the 1988 Seoul Olympics. Samsung built the Astro World Pavilion, Korea Telecom the Human Communication Pavilion, Ssangyong the Earth Environment Pavilion, and POSCO the Future Materials Pavilion.

At the center, I planned for the Korean government to build an underground pavilion where visitors could explore their identity and learn how to balance and harmonize with others. While all four ground-level pavilions were completed, the government's underground pavilion was unfortunately never built, as they did not fully understand the meaning behind my proposal.

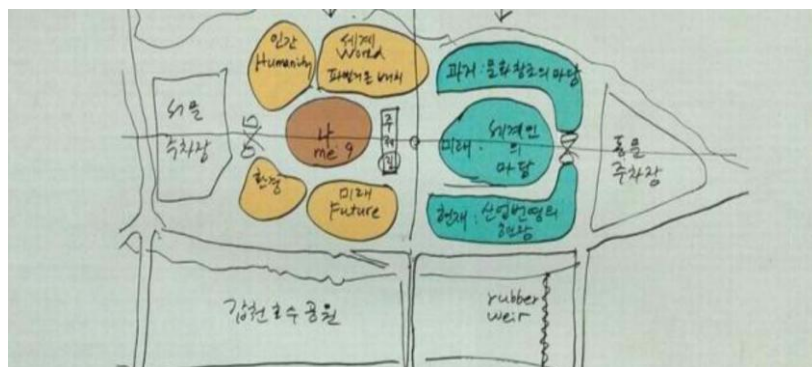
On the east side of the Expo site, the “Past, Present, Future”-themed pavilions were arranged in layers: the northern section represented Korea's past, the southern section showcased Korea's present, and the Pavilion of Korea's Future was positioned at the center. Inside the Pavilion of Korea's Future, space was allocated for participating countries to present their own visionary themes.

As you can see from my sketch plan, all of the pavilions were arranged around a single beltway, rather than using a grid-style circulation system. This design allowed visitors to easily enter and exit all pavilions and facilities from one continuous loop.

KIM Kwangsoo: When designing the venue, you focused on how people would see and move through the space, ensuring that its real focus was not the space itself, but the people who use it.

KWAAK YoungHoon: That's right. Before the Daejeon Expo, most international event venues — including previous Expos — were designed with a grid structure. As a result, visitors often got lost navigating the site. In contrast, the spatial layout of the Daejeon Expo prioritized the convenience of visitors, and it was highly praised by the BIE for its thoughtful and user-friendly design.

KIM Kwangsoo: You must have felt very proud.



▲ Conceptual Sketch of the Daejeon Expo Venue



▲ Model of the Daejeon Expo Venue

The Etymology of ‘Dowoomee’

KIM Kwangsoo: I heard that the word *Dowoomee* was coined by you during the Daejeon Expo1993, is that true?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It was one of the best names I have ever created. The idea came to me during the 1972 Munich Olympics. I was impressed by the event organizers and young guides moving gracefully in their uniforms. Their colors harmonized perfectly with the street flags and even with the colors of architect Otto Piene’s tent-structured stadiums.

For the Daejeon Expo, I asked the Organizing Committee to prepare uniforms and coordinated walking movements for the staff. I also suggested changing the existing name “Companion” to the Korean name “Dowoomee.”

KIM Kwangsoo: The name *Dowoomee* sounds great, and I can immediately understand its meaning. How did you come up with such a wonderful name?

KWAAK YoungHoon: First of all, the word comes from the Korean “도움이” (Dowoom Ee), which literally means “helping person,” but I was not quite satisfied with that. Then, thinking about my main theme, “Technological Way to Be Found Between North and South,” and the site plan with its simple circular road, the character “도 (Do),” meaning “way” or “road,” came to mind.

So, it was easy to come up with the name “도우미” (Dowoomee), written as 道友美, instead of just “도움이” (Dowoom Ee). Here, “Do” (道) means “way” or “road,” “woo” (友) means “friend,” and “mee” (美) connotes “beauty.”

I am still very proud that the name came out as “beautiful friend who helps find your way.” As you know, at every venue and in various meetings across Korea, there are always “Dowoomee” helping to organize and manage events these days. Dowoomee has truly become a respected and proud profession in Korea today.

KIM Kwangsoo: I remember that the *Dowoomee* at each company’s exhibition hall attracted a lot of attention during the Daejeon Expo. They truly became the “Face of the Daejeon Expo.”

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, they were selected through a rigorous evaluation process. First-generation fashion model LEE Hee-jae and renowned actress YOO Ji-in served as judges on my Selection Committee. Actress CHAE Shi-ra was also appointed as an honorary Dowoomee.

The Apex of the Techno-Network

KIM Kwangsoo: I looked up materials related to the Daejeon Expo1993 and found that 108 countries, 33 international organizations, and 200 domestic companies participated, with a total of 14.5 million visitors. By showcasing technologies such as magnetic levitation trains, electric vehicles, and solar-powered turtle ships, Korea was able to demonstrate its scientific and technological advancement to the world. The Expo also received positive reviews from visitors for its emphasis on hands-on, experience-oriented exhibitions, as you intended.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, it was, so to speak, a ‘jackpot’ in the end.

KIM Kwangsoo: This means that Korea successfully hosted the Expo just 100 years after first participating in one — with a small traditional *Hanok*-style house at the 1893 Chicago World’s Fair. When we compare the level of science and technology between the 1893 Chicago World’s Fair and the Daejeon Expo 1993, the pace of development is truly astonishing. It was likely the sufficient infrastructure in place that allowed science and technology to advance so quickly, right?

KWAAK YoungHoon: I completely agree with you. There were so many people who worked tirelessly across various new research centers. I personally carried out the site planning and urban design for the Daedeok Science Town area, which is located right next to the Daejeon Expo site, for the establishment of a new university. I originally named it the Korea Institute of Technology (KIT), which was later renamed the Korea Advanced Institute of Science and Technology (KAIST).

The scholars, engineers, and businesspeople at KIT, Daedeok Science Town, and in various industrial sectors worked incredibly hard to make the Expo a success. Their contributions were essential and should never be overlooked.

KIM Kwangsoo: You mentioned that it was at the 1964 New York World’s Fair where you first dreamed of hosting an Expo in Korea. It seems clear that you were also deeply involved in building the infrastructure necessary for the country’s scientific and technological development.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes. Let me show you a picture of the Unisphere from the 1964 New York World’s Fair. That image and the entire fairgrounds left a deep impression on me. So, I’ve been envisioning what I call the “Dream Project” ever since 1964.

I began to think of not just a single science town or technopolis, but strategically placing key science and technology hubs across the country — and connecting them through information and communication networks as well as transportation infrastructure. This became what I called the “Techno-Network Concept.” Fortunately, in the late 1980s, this vision was adopted by the Ministry of Science and Technology as a part of national government policy under the name “National Techno-Network Plan.”



▲ Unisphere: Image from *Boston Globe* (2004) and a Recent Photo Taken During the Visit

KIM Kwangsoo: Did you also take the initiative to propose this project to the government this time?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I did. I believe it was in 1987 when LEE Sang-hee, a member of the National Assembly, suddenly asked to meet. We had lunch together at a restaurant in Insa-dong, Seoul's traditional district. Mr. LEE, who was also a scientist, seriously asked me what we should do for the future of science and technology in our country. So, I explained the concepts of science and technology cities such as an inland techno-pole, a coastal techno-port, and a river-area techno-valley, and proposed a national network plan for science and technology zones. I also emphasized the need for science and technology education institutions in Korea, similar to MIT. Surprisingly, the very next year, Mr. LEE was appointed Minister of Science and Technology (now the Ministry of Science and ICT), and I was appointed an advisor to the National Techno-Network Planning Committee.

In this way, the project to expand the Techno-Network began, forming a research triangle with Daejeon, Gwangju, and Daegu as its vertices — the primary framework. Daejeon, benefiting from convenient transportation, developed particularly rapidly. At that time, KIT was also established, as I recommended, just northwest of the Daejeon Expo site, on approximately 600,000 square meters of land.

As I mentioned earlier, it is now called KAIST, and it has become the top university in Korea. As you may know, all these institutions are located in Daedeok Science Town, which covers approximately 24 million square meters of land. There are numerous research centers and government as well as private research institutes there. This area has become the seedbed of Korea's miraculous success in high-tech industries and business, of course, a cornerstone of Korea's nation-building.

KIM Kwangsoo: So, the Expo was held in Daejeon a few years after that.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Exactly. Moreover, the Daejeon Expo marked a turning point, setting Korea's science, technology, and culture on a path toward 'a new leap forward.'

KIM Kwangsoo: Since you have achieved most of the biggest goals for Korea's nation-building that you set in your twenties, you must have personally opened up a new path.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I only did my part. I don't know if I opened a new personal path or not, but I still had much to accomplish for Korea's nation-building. After the really challenging times of realizing the 1988 Seoul Olympics and the Daejeon Expo1993, I found myself already fifty years old. (laughs) I couldn't stop because there were many unfinished 'national symphonies' waiting in the Yeosu and Namhae southern coastal regions.



▲ National Techno-Network Plan Led by the Cities of Daejeon, Gwangju, and Daegu

The Expo 2012 Yeosu Korea: A Path Toward Balance and Harmony

Why Yeosu?

KIM Kwangsoo: One of the three hub cities of the Vigor Axis you drew on the South Korean map in 1971 was the Yeosu-Namhae Region. Is that the reason you pushed for Yeosu to host Korea's second Expo?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Exactly! I considered the Yeosu Region as one of the techno-ports in my “Techno-Network” concept. In 2005, I was appointed as the Chairman of the Yeosu Expo Bid Committee. Three years prior to that, Yeosu competed with Shanghai to host the 2010 Expo, but was defeated by Shanghai in the final vote of the the Bureau International des Expositions (BIE). I was in Monaco for the final vote. At that time, I knew Shanghai was unbeatable. Even Moscow couldn't secure the venue, despite Mikhail Gorbachev's efforts. He and I had a pleasant meeting there in Monaco, regardless of the outcome. He was truly a decent man.



▲ Inaugural Address as Chairman of the Yeosu Expo Bid Committee “Let’s Make a Symphony of Hope with Citizen Power”

KIM Kwangsoo: Perhaps Yeosu was at a disadvantage because it was too small a city to host the Expo. Compared to cities like Daejeon, its transportation infrastructure was also not very convenient.

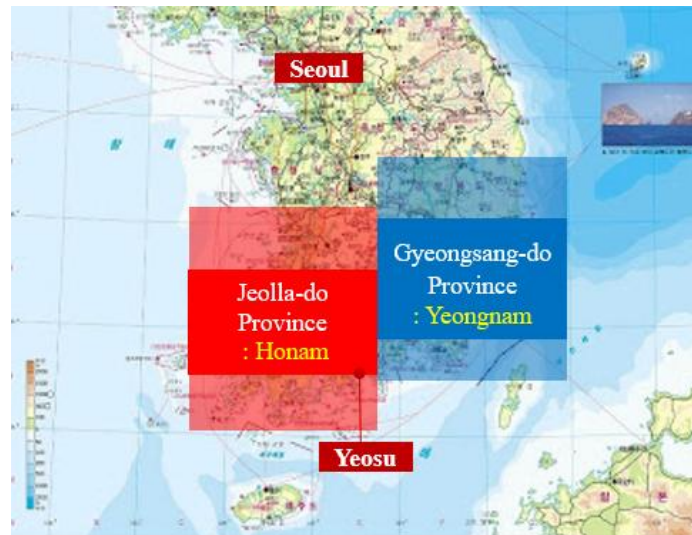
KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, Vicente G. Loscertales, the Secretary-General of the BIE, visited Yeosu and also expressed clear doubts for the same reasons. He said, “Yeosu has a small population, lacks hotels, and has limited tourism infrastructure. Is it really possible to host a large international event like an Expo here?”

However, I felt it was unfair to say that Yeosu was unsuitable as an Expo site simply because it was a relatively underdeveloped area. I thought, “Isn’t it precisely because Yeosu and the surrounding Jeolla Region were less developed that hosting the Expo would help promote further development?”

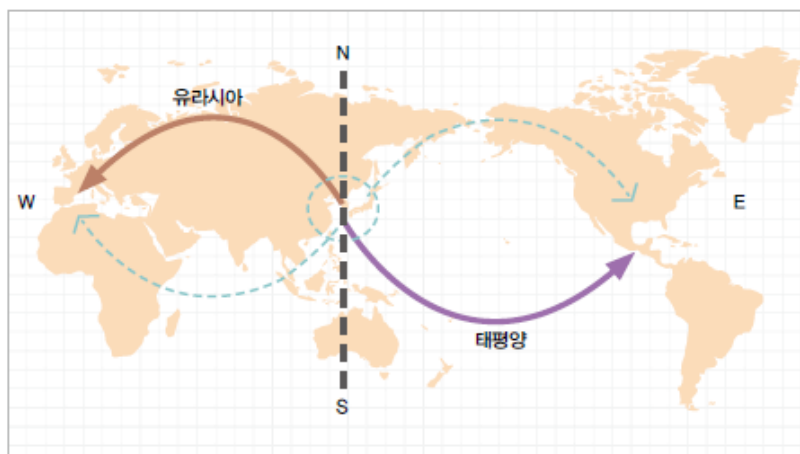
After all, the reason areas like Jeolla Province, including Yeosu, were less developed in the 1960s and 1970s was that during industrialization, the government concentrated infrastructure in the Seoul Metropolitan Area and Gyeongsang Provinces, leaving Jeolla Province relatively neglected. This has been an issue I have been keenly aware of throughout my career as an architect.

As an architect planner and public policy-maker, I believed that hosting the Expo would stimulate growth in this lagging region. I aimed to promote a deliberate development policy effort specifically for underdeveloped areas.

In addition, I was convinced that Yeosu, Gwangyang, and the South Sea Region could develop into a major financial and logistics hub, similar to Hong Kong. I believed that if the sea route from the southern coast to the Pacific Ocean, with Yeosu and Gwangyang as container port bases, were activated, it would increase the economic benefits for the entire country.



▲ Location of Jeolla and Gyeongsang Provinces



▲ Location of Yeosu, an Ideal Gateway between Eurasia and the Pacific Ocean

KIM Kwangsoo: You believed that the development of the Yeosu Region was essential both for the nation's overall growth and for reducing regional disparities. The argument seems theoretically sound, but it appears insufficient to fully convince the BIE. It seems to focus mainly on the problem awareness and hopes, but lacks a clear explanation of the current state of preparations. To compete with other cities and win, a stronger justification and strategy would have been necessary.

KWAAK YoungHoon: You pointed it out precisely. A specific master plan is also needed for persuasion. To develop a winning strategy, I first analyzed the reasons why we had failed to secure the 2010 Expo. And recalling my experience with the Daejeon Expo bid, I considered which key factors the BIE Evaluation Committee members pay the closest attention to when selecting a host city:

1. Strong Commitment from the Government and Candidate City
2. Future-Oriented Message for Humanity
3. Unique Characteristics and Strengths of the Host City
4. Comprehensive Infrastructure Planning and Readiness

Regarding the first point, Yeosu's determination to host the Expo was beyond question. The enthusiasm shown by the mayor of Yeosu and its citizens was truly remarkable. Even when I repeatedly declined the offer to take on the role of Chairman of the Yeosu Expo Bid Committee, they did not give up. Their unwavering commitment and persistent requests eventually convinced me to accept the position.

KIM Kwangsoo: Surely, the government demonstrated a strong will to host the event, didn't it?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Not really. In fact, there were plenty of problems. At that time, President ROH Moo-hyun was facing impeachment, and the government was in a state of chaos. The government had neither the energy nor the capacity to focus on hosting an Expo. Even my long-time friend, former UN Secretary-General BAN Ki-moon, later admitted that he had opposed the Yeosu Expo proposal during a National Cabinet Meeting, simply because Yeosu lacked hotels and transportation infrastructure. At the time, he was Minister of Foreign Affairs, and we had known each other since 1962, when we were part of a delegation visiting President Kennedy. Yet even a friend who understood my vision was highly skeptical of what I called "reverse reasoning."

Sea, or Peace, or Both

KWAAK YoungHoon: Regardless of the government's will to host the event, my first priority was to conceive a message directed toward the future of all mankind.

KIM Kwangsoo: Are you referring to the official theme of the Yeosu Expo, "The Living Ocean and Coast?"

KWAAK YoungHoon: No, it was not my original theme. The theme I proposed was “Epostemological Wave Among N.E.W.S. to Be Generated.” This theme was deliberately designed as a clear parallel to the Seoul Olympic theme, “Ideological Wall Between the East and the West to Be Broken,” and the Daejeon Expo theme, “Technological Way between North and South to be Found.” N.E.W.S. stands for North, East, West, and South. The message was to spread a wave of harmony in every direction across the world. I hoped to help resolve the North–South divide and the East–West regional tensions within our country, and ultimately to contribute to achieving global peace.

My original sequential logic behind the three main themes was not understood at all, and I was not even invited to participate in the decision-making process. Fortunately, the final theme was set in a direction that highlighted the common challenges of mankind concerning the sea and coasts, taking advantage of Yeosu’s unique geographical features and coastal environment.

KIM Kwangsoo: Daejeon, a science city, has science and technology as its theme, while Yeosu, a port city, focuses on the theme of the sea. These themes effectively highlight the unique characteristics of each city.

Captivating the Secretary-General of the BIE

KWAAK YoungHoon: Deciding on a theme for the Expo was only the initial stage of the bid. We still had to answer two crucial questions: “Why Yeosu?” and “Is Yeosu ready to host the Expo?” Since we couldn’t dispel these doubts head-on, we decided to take a detour.

Just as I wrote a letter to Gorbachev before the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games to encourage participation from the communist bloc, for the Yeosu Expo bidding campaign, Mayor KIM Chung-seok and I invited the Secretary-General Loscertales, the head of the BIE based in Paris, to visit Korea.

KIM Kwangsoo: You intended to persuade Mr. Loscertales directly.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Exactly! In September 2005, I invited Secretary-General Loscertales to the Seoul Olympeace House, which was built in 1987.

KIM Kwangsoo: Do you mean the house that was built for Gorbachev?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Right. I didn’t want to leave the space I had worked so hard to create, and I also needed offices for the businesses and organizations I represented. So, I simply moved in after the 1988 Seoul Olympics. At the Olympeace House, my wife delivered a welcome speech in French, and I introduced the importance of Korea’s balanced regional development. Mayor KIM Chung-seok passionately conveyed the aspirations of Yeosu’s citizens for the Expo to Secretary-General Loscertales and his delegates.

Above all, I spoke to convince him of the justification for choosing this underdeveloped city, Yeosu, highlighting its strategic position as the southernmost point on the National Vigor Axis and its Côte d’Azur-like ambiance, which they found quite familiar. I said, “If you look at the BIE’s articles, it

states that one of the purposes of hosting an Expo is to stimulate the growth of underdeveloped regions. If the Expo is held in Yeosu, both Yeosu and Korea's southern coastal region will develop, which could help ease the severe partisan regionalism between Honam and Yeongnam Regions."

However, even after listening to my entire explanation, Mr. Loscertales still seemed unable to dispel his doubts about me and the venue. Then, I took out various maps and said, "Secretary-General, did you get off the plane and arrive here via the Olympic-daero, enjoying the beautiful scenery of the Han River? You traveled on roads that I designed. Also, the master plan for the Daejeon Expo 1993 — which, as you know, was an unprecedented success — came, frankly speaking, from my MVIP. We will successfully prepare for and host the Yeosu Expo in 2012 just as we did with Daejeon in 1993."



▲ Meeting with Secretary-General Loscertales and Delegates at the Olympeace House

[KIM Kwangsoo: What was the Secretary-General's reaction?](#)

KWAAK YoungHoon: He listened quietly, then said, "I have confidence in you since you are leading the Yeosu Expo Bid Committee. However — and this is a big however — I have received reports that your national government shows little willingness to support the Expo."

[KIM Kwangsoo: He touched on a sensitive issue.](#)

KWAAK YoungHoon: The best way for me to handle it, not as a government official, was simply to express my thoughts as if he was worrying about something trivial. "You don't need to worry about that. As you may know, last year President ROH Moo-hyun went through a very difficult ordeal. He was the first president in the history of the Republic of Korea to be impeached, and his duties were temporarily suspended. However, he had strong support from the people, and the Constitutional Court ultimately rejected the impeachment charges, allowing him to return to office. President Roh is like a younger brother to me. Before he became president, he always called me 'Hyungnim' — which means elder brother in Korean. He will not betray the promise he made to me."

Secretary-General Loscertales nodded, and it seemed that his doubts about the government had finally been resolved.

[KIM Kwangsoo: It seems that your confidence was persuasive.](#)

KWAAK YoungHoon: Maybe. However, the final, decisive blow came from Mayor KIM, who was there with us. He had returned as mayor of Yeosu after four years, pushed by the citizens' strong demand that "the person who first initiated the Expo bid must be the one to bring all Expo-related matters to completion."

After the conversation with Secretary-General Loscertales, Mayor KIM stood up and said, "I was reelected as the mayor of Yeosu because of the Expo. If I fail to host the Expo in Yeosu, the people might just kill me!" When I translated his words into English, Mr. Loscertales laughed out loud.

KIM Kwangsoo: *If the Secretary-General laughed, does that mean it's over?*

KWAAK YoungHoon: (Laughs) Anyway, in November 2007, Yeosu was finally selected as the host city for the 2012 Expo at the BIE General Assembly in Paris. The Yeosu Expo was also successfully concluded, with about 8 million visitors participating over three months.



▲ Expo 2012 Yeosu Korea (The Yeosu Expo 2012)

The 2018 PyeongChang Olympic Winter Games: The Triumph of Dreamers

Yongpyong Ski Resort: The First Infrastructure for the 2018 PyeongChang Olympic Winter Games

KIM Kwangsoo: It is often said that the Summer Olympics, the Winter Olympics, the World Expo, and the FIFA World Cup are the four major global events. By hosting the PyeongChang Winter Olympics, South Korea became the sixth country in the world to have hosted all four, following France, Italy, Germany, the United States, and Japan.

I'm sure you were actively involved as a member of the bid committee during the PyeongChang Winter Olympics as well.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Indeed, exactly 30 years after the 1988 Seoul Olympics, I was once again involved in an Olympic bidding project.

KIM Kwangsoo: You mentioned that your ambition to host the Winter Olympics in the Daegwallyeong Ski Resort area was inspired by the 1968 Grenoble Winter Olympics. Back in 1968, the idea of hosting the Winter Olympics in Korea seemed like an absurd dream. Wasn't there a strong perception at the time that ice and snow sports were considered 'expensive sports' because they require special venues that need to be maintained at specific temperatures, as well as costly equipment?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Of course, special venues would need to be built. Moreover, there were no ski resorts in Korea at that time. I expected that hosting the Winter Olympics would be more challenging than the Summer Olympics. Therefore, I believed we needed to start preparing much earlier and for a longer period. Fortunately, I found another dreamer who shared my vision.

KIM Kwangsoo: Who was that person?

KWAAK YoungHoon: He was KIM Seok-won, former Chairman of the Ssangyong Group, whose family had been close to mine since childhood. We became close friends when we studied in the United States. He even helped me establish my *Taekwondo* studio in Cambridge in 1968. This was before KIM inherited the Ssangyong Group.

Chairman KIM studied at Brandeis University in Waltham, Massachusetts, and lived in Weston with his elder sister and her husband, an MIT graduate. I often dropped by his house to enjoy Korean food and chat with him. He talked a lot about cars and always showed me car magazines.

One day in 1968, while chatting with Chairman KIM as we often did in the neighborhood where he lived, I suggested that, in addition to his interest in the automobile business, he might consider building a ski resort to the north of Daegwallyeong. The idea was to create the necessary infrastructure to promote winter sports early on, so that Korea could eventually host the Winter Olympics someday in the distant future. Chairman KIM laughed heartily and said, "Let's do it!"

Since Korea had never built a ski resort before, I suggested to him that it would be a good idea to visit St. Moritz, Switzerland — where the Winter Olympics had been held twice — to study and benchmark

their ski resorts. After our conversation, Chairman KIM actually went to St. Moritz. He then returned to Korea and built a ski resort on Balwangsan Mountain in PyeongChang, Gangwon Province, in the northeastern part of the country. That was Yongpyong Resort, the first ski resort in Korea, which opened in 1975.

KIM Kwangsoo: Chairman KIM Seok-won also had remarkable foresight and strong determination.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, he did. Chairman KIM jokingly said that he bought 1 million *pyeong* (about 10 million square feet) of Mt. Balwangsan for 1 won per *pyeong*, totaling 1 million won. He said it felt as if Mt. Balwangsan was calling out to him to come.

But I know well that behind such a light joke lies a story of blood and sweat. He is a great man whom I deeply admire, and I am infinitely grateful to him. In the early 1970s, South Korea had no official regulations or guidelines for building ski resorts, and very few people had ever visited one. So, he started from scratch, explaining everything from A to Z to everyone involved in constructing the resort.

KIM Kwangsoo: Starting with Yongpyong Ski Resort, winter sports began to blossom in Korea, so it would not be an exaggeration to call Yongpyong Ski Resort the first major infrastructure for the PyeongChang Winter Olympics.

The NEO Olympeace Movement Powered by Citizens

KWAAK YoungHoon: When I became convinced that Korea had sufficient human resources and infrastructure to host large-scale winter sports events, I proposed to Gangwon Province that they begin preparing to host the Winter Olympics. I shared the idea with Mr. KIM Jin-sun, a very sincere and dedicated young official from the Ministry of the Interior, where I had served a Professor Advisor for over 20 years.

At the time, he was serving as Director of Planning in the Gangwon-do Provincial Government, having been dispatched from the Ministry. He later served as Deputy Governor and went on to be elected Governor for three consecutive terms. He is one of the finest public officials I have ever known in Korea, and I admire him immensely.

Since the 1990s, whenever I visited the Gangwon-do Governor's Office, I would bring up the idea of hosting the Winter Olympics in Gangwon Province. My suggestion was eventually accepted during the tenure of Governor KIM (1998–2010). Even after his term ended, he continued to lead the PyeongChang Winter Olympics bid project at the forefront.

And so, after three attempts, PyeongChang was finally selected as the host city for the 23rd Winter Olympics at the IOC General Assembly in 2011. "PyeongChang!" The moment IOC President Jacques Rogge's voice resonated throughout the conference hall, I felt a shiver run through my entire body.

I truly believe that without Governor KIM, Korea would never have been able to host the 2018 Winter Olympic Games.

KIM Kwangsoo: I imagine you thought, “Now it’s done!”

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes! However, just like with the Seoul Olympics, there were still many barriers to overcome. The situation both at home and abroad was unstable during the preparations for the PyeongChang Winter Olympics.

KIM Kwangsoo: Yes, I remember it well. Tensions between South Korea and North Korea escalated due to North Korea’s development of nuclear weapons and the launch of long-range missiles. The Korean Peninsula was once again overshadowed by the threat of war as U.S. President Donald Trump responded with a hardline military stance and increased sanctions against North Korea.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Right. Some countries even stated they would not participate in the 2018 PyeongChang Olympics unless safety on the Korean Peninsula was guaranteed. Foreign media also kept publishing articles predicting the failure of the PyeongChang Winter Olympics.

KIM Kwangsoo: It’s kind of like *déjà vu* from the 1988 Seoul Olympics. It seems you carried out the Olympeace Movement once again this time.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, it feels like *karma*. However, I couldn’t establish a large organization like the Seoul Assembly of Olympeace, as we did during the 1988 Seoul Olympics. Instead, starting from the end of 2017, several citizen rallies were held in front of the Eternal Peace Flame in Seoul Olympic Park to advocate for the peaceful success of the PyeongChang Winter Olympics.



▲ Appeal for the Peaceful Success of the PyeongChang Olympic Winter Games

After these events, voluntary rallies continued every weekend until just before the opening of the PyeongChang Winter Olympics. In the bitter cold of midwinter, the citizens sang “Step-by-Step,” a version of the Seoul Olympic theme song “Hand-In-Hand” with revised lyrics, to pray for peace on the Korean Peninsula and the success of the 2018 PyeongChang Winter Olympics.

We also wrote an appeal for Olympeace to be sent out to the world, but this time we reached not only

famous celebrities but also ordinary citizens. When I collected the support signatures, I found that people from all sectors of society were well represented.

While leading the WCO Olympeace movement for the PyeongChang Winter Olympics, I realized the power of ordinary yet extraordinary global citizens. I reflected on how much our society and the world have changed over the past 30 years. I felt that the world had matured not only materially, but also spiritually.



**Urgent Appeal for Peace
during the PyeongChang Winter Olympiad 2018**

In the name of all peace-loving people, I, the undersigned, endorse this urgent appeal for peace and harmony during the PyeongChang Winter Olympiad 2018. This upcoming event will mark yet another step toward humanity's determination to promote our "Global Village" to be committed to a harmonious, just, charitable and sustainable world gathering.

There is an urgent mandate for humanity on this occasion of the Games of the 23rd Olympiad, starting on February 9th through February 25th 2018, on the Korean Peninsula, to call on our brothers and sisters around the world to declare and observe a moratorium on all forms of strife, violence and terror. We implore all people to cast aside weapons of conflict and hatred, to make this gathering of our best athletes a festival of comradeship, cultural exchange, and global harmony.

Regardless of differences between nation states, ideologies, races or religions, I pledge my support of this event to witness another great step toward humanity's common goal to live in peace, free from fear of war, persecution, and violence. It is only through peaceful interaction and global gatherings such as this one that the recognition of our common humanity and universal longing for true happiness can be fulfilled.

It is my fervent hope and prayer that the 23rd PyeongChang Winter Olympiad, 2018, will be yet another important catalyst toward securing enduring peace on the Korean Peninsula and around the world.

Signature:

Name:
Position:
Place:
Date:

**PyeongChang Olympeace Committee of
WCO-GCN**

Karel Skornik, Vienna / Stéphane Chevalier, Strasbourg / Jick Kong Chen, Toronto / Sandy Vance, San Francisco / Thomas Buser, Cairo / Ulf Sornmark, Stockholm / Asim Qazi, Giza / Jala Noth Khani, Kathmandu / Ali Abderrahmane, Settat / Abdullah Omroutar, Santiago / Sabina Dizdarevic, Serbia / Chau Ling Candy, Beijing / Ibrahim Idilov, Girona / CHO WanKyu, Seoul / KIM Jin-sun, Wonju / KWAAK YoungHoon, Seoul

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▲ Appeal for Peace



▲ Global Citizen Supporters

A Dream Shared by Many Is No Longer Just a Dream!

KIM Kwangsoo: As is well known, the supreme leader of North Korea, KIM Jong Un, announced his intention to participate in the PyeongChang Winter Olympics during his 2018 New Year's address, and the situation changed instantly. Until just three months before the event, there was widespread speculation that North Korea was deliberately provoking tensions to obstruct the hosting of the Winter Olympics.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I didn't know the detailed story, but it was clear that the PyeongChang Winter Olympics became a peaceful stage for 'sports diplomacy.' The joint entrance of the South-North Korean team at the Opening Ceremony and the formation of a unified women's ice hockey team were surprising. These moments suggested the possibility of inter-Korean peace to the world.

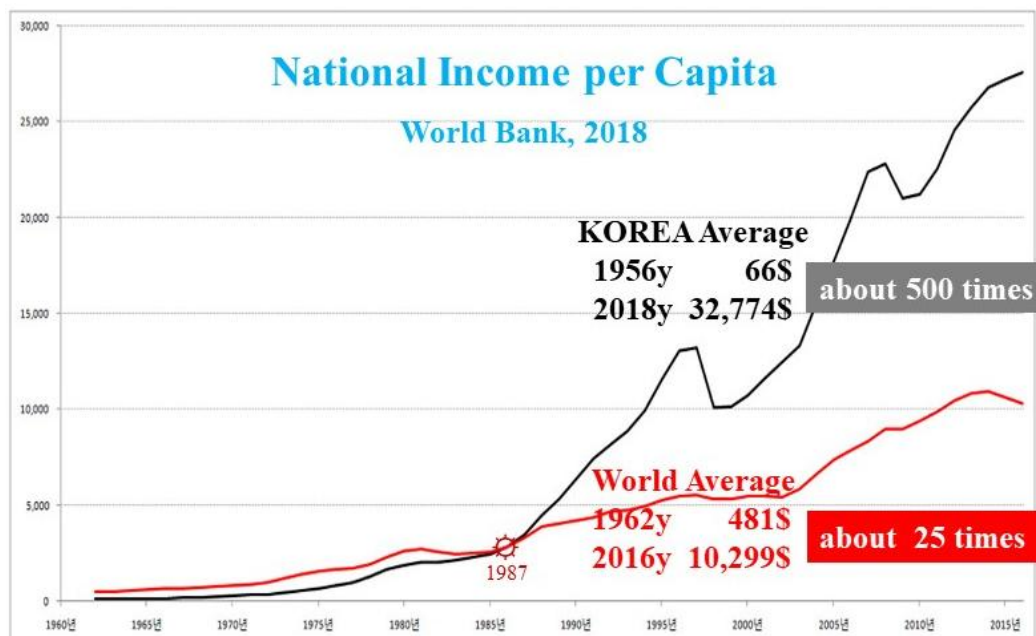
KIM Kwangsoo: Yes, the meeting between South Korean President MOON Jae-in and North Korean Supreme Leader KIM Jong Un was held on the occasion of the PyeongChang Winter Olympics. Hosting the Winter Olympics and a summit between South and North Korea were considered absurd dreams just 50 years ago. Suddenly, the lyrics of John Lennon's "Imagine" come to mind: "You may say I'm a dreamer, but I'm not the only one."

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, even a daydream can come true someday when many people dream together. Of course, it's impossible to predict exactly when it will happen.

KIM Kwangsoo: You mentioned using global events as a means to achieve balanced regional development. What efforts are needed for Gangwon Province to take a bigger leap forward after the Winter Olympics?

KWAAK YoungHoon: If infrastructure like the KTX Gangneung Line, built for the Olympics, is utilized effectively, the growth of the Gangwon Region will be further accelerated. In particular, the KTX is expected to play a crucial role in connecting the Techno-Network within Gangwon Province to other science hubs, cities, and provinces.

This may sound like a dream, but it would be wonderful if we could expand the Techno-Network from Gangwon Province to the Gaema Plateau and other strategic areas in North Korea that I have already identified, hopefully in the near future.



▲ Dramatic Rise in South Korea's National Income per Capita after Hosting the Olympics and the Expos

3

Setting the Capital Region of the Korean Peninsula : Seoul and Metropolitan Region Projects

The Story Behind the Creation of the Modern Han River Landscape

The Rebirth of the Han River

KIM Kwangsoo: It was the mid-1970s when you returned to Korea after studying abroad, right? You must have come back with big dreams about nation-building, land development, and urban design. Where did you think development was most urgently needed in Korea?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It was the Han River. As you may recall, the Han River began to lose its clear blue color as industrialization intensified in the 1970s. The population of Seoul was rapidly increasing, and household waste such as briquette ash, watermelon rinds, and broken furniture mixed with factory wastewater, creating a foul odor.

This was before Gangnam area — the southern part of the Han River — began to develop. At that time, most Koreans regarded Seoul as being limited to the area within the Four Great Gates of Hanyang — the old name of Seoul — located on the northern side of the Han River. So, the Han River was mostly perceived as the southern boundary of Seoul.

KIM Kwangsoo: That's right. At that time, the word "Gangnam" didn't even exist.

KWAAK YoungHoon: In order for Seoul to develop into a world-class city in the future, I believed the city boundaries should be extended to include the southern part of the Han River. Additionally, the Han River should flow through the heart of the city, which meant it needed to be restored and kept clean. I announced the Han River Comprehensive Development Plan on June 28, 1977, at the Annual Landscape Architecture Conference held at Seoul City University.

KIM Kwangsoo: How do you remember the exact date?

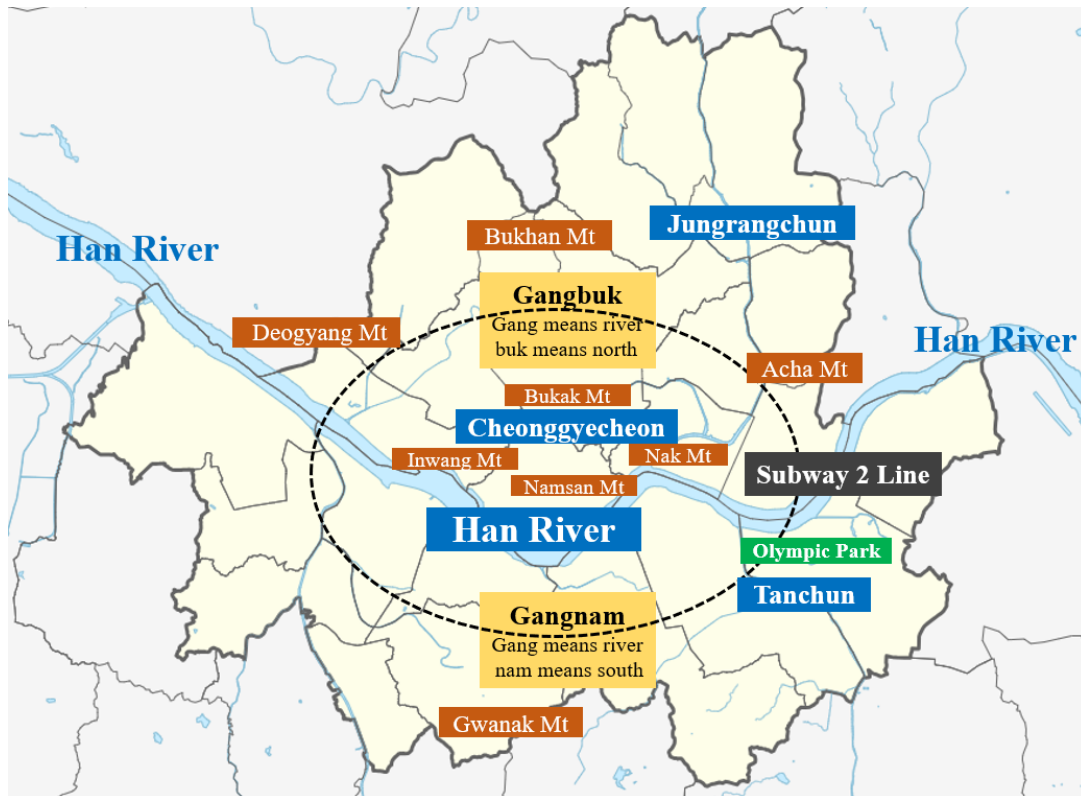
KWAAK YoungHoon: I heard so many criticisms that day. (laughs) It's a joke. Many people there were fiercely opposed.

KIM Kwangsoo: Maybe it was a similar situation when you proposed the bid for the Seoul Olympics.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Somehow, it was a tough period. The Han River Comprehensive Development Plan had three main points:

1. To build a small dam at the mouth of the Han River to transform it into a lake-like riverfront, similar to the Seine in Paris, the Thames in London, or the Charles River in Boston. Private developments such as apartment complexes would be prohibited along the riverbanks
2. To develop both sides of the river in a balanced and harmonious way because the Han River is the center of Seoul — not its southern boundary
3. To create a major green space in Seoul along the Han River, which flows from east to west,

and extend it north to south along Mt. Bukhansan, Namsan, and Gwanaksan. Connect secondary rivers such as the Tancheon Stream and Jungnangcheon Stream, as well as the tertiary tributary Cheonggyecheon Stream, would be connected to the main river, with pedestrian-only roads constructed along the riversides



▲ Key Geographic Features of Seoul

KIM Kwangsoo: Why did the other professors oppose the idea?

KWAAK YoungHoon: They gave three main reasons — economic, geographical, and environmental.

First, it is unreasonable to compare the Han River to the Seine or the Charles River without taking Korea's economic capacity into account.

Second, unlike the flat terrain of the Seine or the Thames, the Han River has steep slopes. Floods are frequent in summer due to concentrated heavy rain, so it is difficult to build a citizen park along the river.

Third, although the plan claims to care about the environment, it would actually harm the natural river ecosystem.

KIM Kwangsoo: Those arguments might sound plausible to someone unfamiliar with civil engineering, but how did you handle criticism coming from all sides?

KWAAK YoungHoon: First of all, regarding the construction costs, I explained that we could raise the necessary budget without using taxpayers' money by excavating and selling sand from the riverbed.

In response to the second criticism regarding topography and climate conditions, I argued that if a dam — similar to the Soyanggang Dam on the Bukhan River — were built upstream on the Namhan River, the flow of water in the Han River could be effectively controlled.

As for the third criticism, I explained that reinforcing the riverbanks was inevitable, since the area would become a major public park. Safety measures and essential urban amenities would need to be in place for the citizens who use it.

AHN Soo-han, a professor at Seoul National University's College of Engineering, unexpectedly appeared as a relief pitcher and strengthened my argument by saying, "My name means 'Safely Protecting Han River!' Topographic, climatic, economic, and environmental problems can all be solved through civil engineering."

[KIM Kwangsoo: How did you respond to concerns about whether the development of the Han River was environmentally friendly?](#)

KWAAK YoungHoon: I said, "Seoul will become a city of 10 million people in the future, so we cannot simply leave the riverside in its natural state. For safety reasons, some artificial structures need to be built. However, we can still preserve green spaces along the banks of the Han River."

After saying this, I listed the techniques that allow aquatic plants to grow. No one objected. That was the end of the debate.

Along the Han River, Olympic-daero (Olympic Motorway)

KWAAK YoungHoon: The Han River Long-Range Comprehensive Development Plan, including the construction of the Chungju Dam, progressed slowly at first. However, after Seoul was selected as the host city for the 1988 Olympics, we had to accelerate the infrastructure development. As you already know, it was my secret strategy to use the Olympics as a major impetus to transform Seoul into a world-class city.

After Seoul's successful bid in 1981, the pace of work changed dramatically. Everyone had to work hard, not only to meet deadlines but also to create beautiful structures. The most urgent initial project was to build Olympic-daero, a motorway along the Han River, and to create a major riverside park stretching along the entire river, as I had already planned. However, progress was very, very slow.

Everyone knew it was too complicated for Seoul citizens to travel from Gimpo International Airport in the west end of Seoul all the way to Jamsil Olympic Main Stadium and the future Olympic Park in the east. I spoke with KIM Jae-ik, the Chief Secretary for Economic Affairs to the President, saying, "We need new roads. If we cannot solve the traffic inconvenience, we may have to give up the Olympic venue." He responded, "Dr. KWAAK, as I told you last year when we first discussed the new capital and national defense strategy, you are the "National Planning President." You make the decisions — we will follow."

Within just a week, the Han River Development Commission was established, and AHN Sang-young,

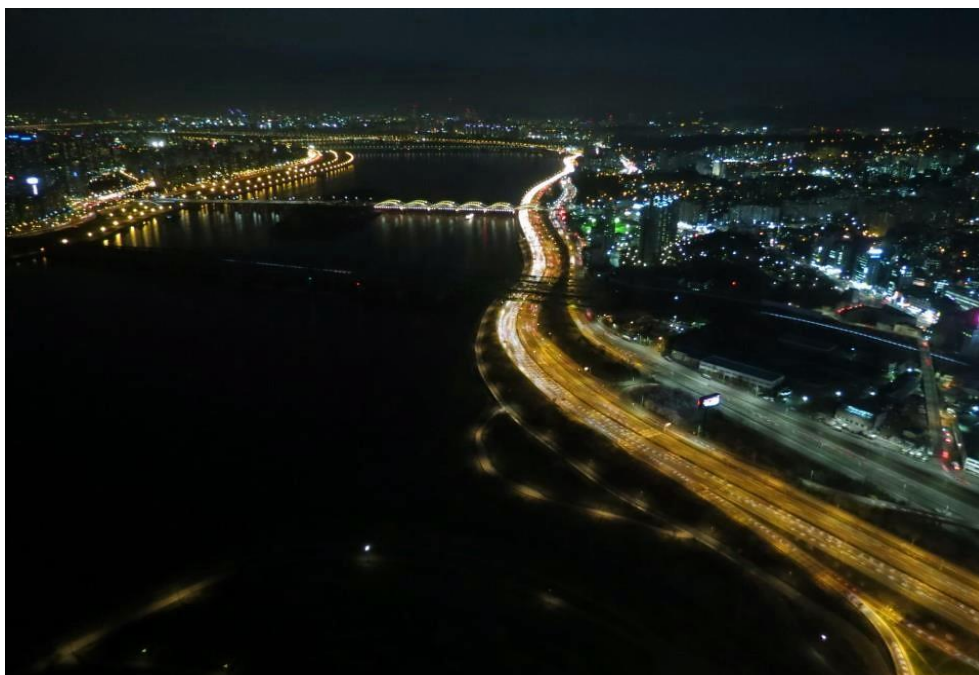
the Director General of Civil Engineering for the Seoul Metropolitan Government, was appointed Project Engineer Director on my recommendation. It was unbelievable.

KIM Kwangsoo: You are the “National Planning President” acknowledged by the “National Economic President.”

KWAAK YoungHoon: (Laughs) As you and every citizen know, President CHUN delegated authority to Dr. KIM and several others. Thanks to Dr. KIM’s strong leadership and the participation of major construction companies like Hyundai E&C and Daewoo E&C, the Olympic-daero was completed in 1986, just in time for the Asian Games. Without Dr. KIM and Project Engineer Director AHN Sang-young, the Han River project could not have been finished before the 1986 Asian Games.

KIM Kwangsoo: Han River Basin maintenance, the Chungju Dam, the construction of the Olympic-daero, and the creation of the Han River Park... It seems the Han River Comprehensive Development Plan largely achieved its intended goals. Do you have any personal regrets about the project?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Every project inevitably leaves some regrets. One of the regrets regarding the Han River development is that the Nodeul riverside area north of Noryangjin, Ttukseom, and Gwangnaru were not preserved in their original natural state. I had hoped to preserve those areas as green spaces where citizens could enjoy the river. However, due to a shortage of housing in Seoul, apartments were built there indiscriminately. It is truly heartbreaking to see rows of apartments stretching along the riverside like an unsightly screen.



▲ Olympic-daero along the Han River

Daehak-ro (University Street): A Street of Art and Eternal Romance

Designer of Downtown Seoul

KIM Kwangsoo: You collaborated on many projects with former Mayor KOO Jachoon of Seoul early in your career — from the urban design of Daehak-ro (University Street) and the restoration of the 600-year-old Hanyang Fortress, to the Mapo District urban plan, and even the planning of Seoul Subway Lines 2 and 3.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes. During Mayor KOO's tenure (1974–1978), I proposed various urban design projects in Seoul, already envisioning that the city could one day host the Olympic Games. I initiated many of these projects, and Mayor KOO was a remarkable leader. I would even compare him to Baron Haussmann of Paris.

After he was appointed Minister of Home Affairs (now the Ministry of the Interior and Safety), we continued to work together on long-term national projects. In that sense, we were partners throughout the 1970s. As a former artillery officer, he had a sharp eye for reading maps, and his strong sense of drive made him an excellent collaborator. Seoul was fortunate to have a mayor like him.

KIM Kwangsoo: It seems that you've preferred making proposals and offering your own ideas, rather than simply receiving commissions.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I have! If you wait for someone to give you an order, it's already too late. My body moves first — driven by the desire to bring to life the blueprint I've already drawn in my head. That's just the way I work. And because of that, I have always been deeply grateful to have met public officials such as Chief Economic Advisor KIM Jae-ik and Seoul Mayor KOO Jachoon, who gave me their full trust.

Crisis of Losing Daehak-ro

KIM Kwangsoo: These days, few people seem to know that the 'University' in 'University Street,' the cultural and arts street near Hyeohwa Station, originally referred to Seoul National University.

Today, only the medical school remains in the area, but until the 1970s, most of Seoul National University's campus was located in Daehak-ro. During that time, the military dictatorship under PARK Chung-hee relocated all Seoul National University facilities — except for the medical school — to the southern end of Seoul near Mt. Gwanaksan. The official purpose was to erase the legacy of Gyeongseong Imperial University and to consolidate the university buildings, which had been scattered throughout the city, into a single location.

KWAAK YoungHoon: You majored in Philosophy and graduated from Seoul National University. You might feel disappointed that your original campus has disappeared.

KIM Kwangsoo: Actually, my anger outweighs my disappointment. I can't dispel the suspicion that the so-called *Yushin* military dictatorship deliberately tried to destroy the Daehak-ro campus — the epicenter of protests — to suppress anti-government movements. Can you imagine what it would be like if they tried to move your *alma maters*, Harvard or MIT?

KWAAK YoungHoon: I fully understand your feelings. My family was also deeply disappointed.

KIM Kwangsoo: Still, it is very fortunate that Daehak-ro has not completely disappeared and has been preserved as a cultural and artistic street. Wasn't the government's original plan to turn Daehak-ro into an apartment complex?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I'm sorry to say that it was indeed the case at the time. I was a Professor of Architecture and Planning at Hongik University and at Seoul National University's Graduate School of Environment. Mr. YOON Joo-young, who had asked me to design the late First Lady Yuk Young-soo Memorial Hall, happened to mention the housing plan in Daehak-ro during our conversation. He was a National Assemblyman and former Minister of Culture and Public Information.

A few days later, feeling uneasy, I went to Daehak-ro, and noticed that several ginkgo trees were being uprooted. I immediately stepped in and demanded that they stop cutting down the trees. Fortunately, the construction workers were very cooperative and halted the excavation. It was a terrifying moment.

I promptly contacted Mayor KOO, who had been introduced to me by National Assemblyman YOON. I urged him, "This must be stopped. Please stop digging up the trees. Please, please, please. This area is close to Sungkyunkwan University, which has over 500 years of tradition, and it holds the intellectual heritage and academic memories of Seoul National University. Building apartments here would mean burying invaluable intellectual history."

I also earnestly appealed for the development of the area around Marronnier Yard into a historic, cultural, and artistic space. Miraculously, Mayor KOO, a truly great man, listened to me.

KIM Kwangsoo: So, the plan to demolish Daehak-ro was canceled, and you were entrusted with the new design and revitalization of the area.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Exactly! It was not an easy decision, even back then, to overturn the government's original plan and entrust a new project to an emerging architect. It would be even harder to make such a decision nowadays.

Designing a New Landscape of Daehak-ro

KIM Kwangsoo: When you redesigned Daehak-ro, you must have carefully considered many factors, as you aimed to preserve the university's atmosphere while removing certain buildings. Specifically,

what kind of space did you intend to create?

KWAAK YoungHoon: You perfectly understood what I felt at that time. I did not want to get involved in the design of individual buildings. Frankly, I also wanted to avoid any misunderstanding that I influenced the mayor to secure a new design job. Therefore, I only prepared the urban design concept schema, and I did so without any remuneration.

There were two key concepts in my urban design schema. The first was to create a space where ‘serendipity’ could occur. I aimed to design an environment where accomplished scholars and the new generation of students could meet by chance, freely converse, and interact with one another. Even better if such coincidental encounters would lead to fruitful learning and teaching relationships. The goal was to create a space where people who love knowledge and the arts could discover unexpected connections and inspiration.

Secondly, I aimed to incorporate a Performing Arts Center and an Environmental Art Gallery, creating a space where both performing and environmental arts could flourish.



▲ Marronnier Yard on Daehak-ro: Urban Design and Overview of Completed Works

KIM Kwangsoo: How closely does the current Daehak-ro match the blueprint you had in mind?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It did not turn out exactly as I had envisioned. When I yielded the architectural design work to my senior, KIM Su-geun, the plans were revised. Although the academies of science and arts that I had strongly wished to build were omitted from the final design, the overall concept and spatial layout were faithfully realized.

The architectural technique of creating a large opening in the center of the building to avoid obstructing the surrounding landscape was first attempted in the design of the university. Later, the same concept was applied to other projects in which I participated or advised, including the Sejong Center for the Performing Arts, the Seoul Arts Center, and the National Museum of Korea.



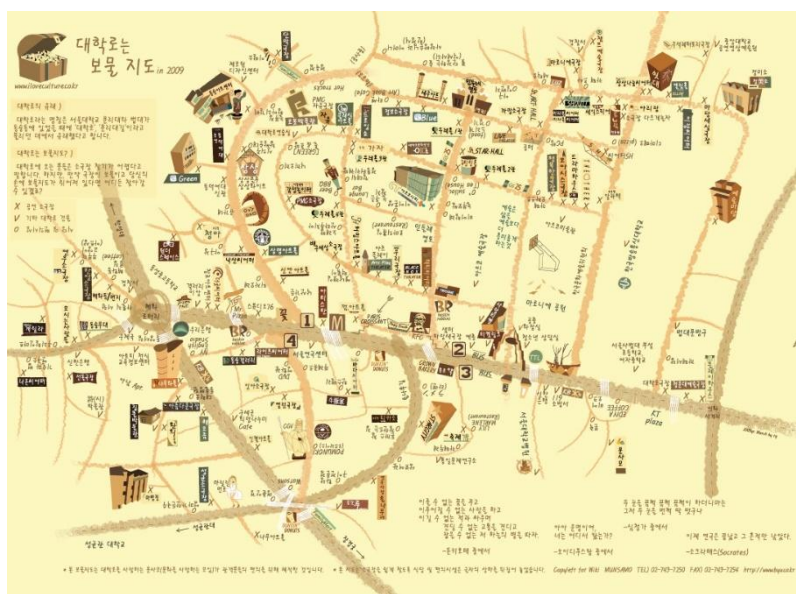
▲ National Museum of Korea in Seoul

KIM Kwangsoo: As Daehak-ro developed into a cultural and artistic street, artists from across the country gathered here in search of a new home. Today, the Daehak-ro area is one of the rare places in the world where performance centers and theaters are densely concentrated. Additionally, several universities have established their arts and culture departments' campuses in Daehak-ro.

If our generation formed memories of our youth with Daehak-ro centered around the Dongsung-dong campus, it seems that the next generation is now nurturing their dreams and romance in the new Daehak-ro, filled with theater stages and street performances.

As the designer of this district, are you proud of what Daehak-ro has become now?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Humbly speaking, yes. It feels truly rewarding to see so many people visiting, exchanging poems, and performing dramas both inside and outside. Daehak-ro has become a place of creative living, teaching, and learning — a space for people, peace, and pace — as I originally envisioned. I am grateful for this. This feeling is difficult to express in words.



▲ Daehak-ro: The World's Densest Theater District and the Birthplace of *Hallyu*

The Hidden Stories of Seoul Subway Line 2

The World's First Circular Subway Line

KIM Kwangsoo: My acquaintances from abroad always praise the convenience of the Seoul subway system. You can travel anywhere within the metropolitan area by subway. The fares are affordable, transfers are easy, and the heating and cooling facilities are fully equipped. In particular, Seoul Subway Line 2 serves as the backbone of the metropolitan transportation network, connecting with all subway lines from 1 to 9.

However, few people probably realize that Line 2 is also your work. To be honest, I didn't know either until I was preparing for this interview. You must have been a little disappointed.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I feel quite disappointed. (laughs) It's a joke. Actually, I don't mind, since there are many such projects. Besides, it's not something I accomplished alone. For example, at the construction site, there were workers digging underground in four shifts of six hours each, others pouring concrete, and many more installing electrical wiring and plumbing. The efforts of countless people — too many to name — went into it. I have absolutely no intention of claiming that Subway Line 2 was done solely by me.

Not only the subway, but all the buildings and facilities known as 'KWAAK YoungHoon's works' are, in fact, the result of the hard work and collaboration of many people whose names remain unknown.

KIM Kwangsoo: You're giving a wise answer to a simple question. So, how did you come up with the idea of building a subway?

KWAAK YoungHoon: I believe it was in 1976. As more and more people left rural areas for the city, the population of Seoul grew exponentially. I became increasingly concerned about Seoul's future. At that time, the population of Seoul was between six and seven million, and it was easy to predict that it would soon surpass ten million.

In the 1970s, urban planning departments at universities around the world taught that business districts should be established in densely populated centers — a concept that was widely regarded as the standard in urban planning. In the case of Seoul, all areas within the Four Great Gates were designated as commercial districts under the Joseon City Area Planning Ordinance, issued by the Japanese Government-General of Korea in 1934.

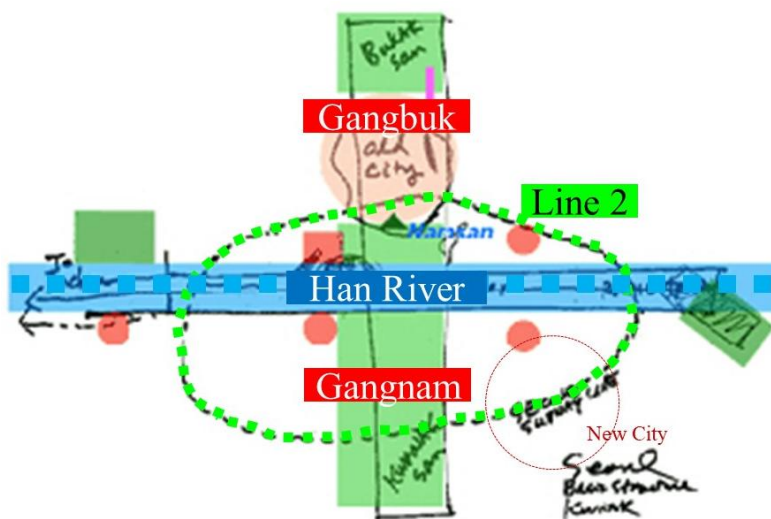
The conventional theories of urban planning didn't seem to suit Seoul, which was on track to reach a population of ten million. Could the Central Business District (CBD) for ten million people really be contained within the traditional four-gated area of old Seoul? Should only the northern side of the Han River be developed for the city's future? It was clear that Seoul would become packed like sardines. The city's water, air, and land would inevitably suffer from reckless development and worsening traffic congestion concentrated north of the Han River.

"How can we relieve development pressure from the traditional city center and redirect it outward? If the Gangnam District, located south of the Han River, is to be developed, how can we ensure that residents of Gangnam and Gangbuk, north of the river, remain connected as citizens of the same city?"

At the end of these questions, the answer was clear — the subway. I became deeply aware of the need for a subway system in Seoul, especially with the anticipation that the city would one day host the Olympic Games.

People usually place subway lines or roads in areas that are already developed. However, in my blueprint, Seoul Subway Line 2 was designed to pass through the traditional downtown of the Gangbuk District — the historical heart of Seoul for hundreds of years — and then continue through the Gangnam District, which at the time was still a rural area filled with orchards and rice paddies. Uniquely, the line was planned in a circular shape.

I envisioned the Han River becoming the centerpiece of a new Seoul, much like the Seine in Paris or the Thames in London. The existing city in the Gangbuk District and the newly developable area in the Gangnam District could be well connected and complement each other. In a sense, it was a strategy to shift from having a single Central Business District for a city of ten million people to developing multiple centers that are interconnected for the convenience of its citizens.



▲ Master Plan for Seoul Subway Line 2

KIM Kwangsoo: The fact that you envisioned the subway in preparation for Seoul's large-scale urbanization clearly shows how you work. By the way, in terms of both its route and circular shape, Seoul Subway Line 2 is quite unique, isn't it?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, it was indeed a very innovative city planning idea. But when Mayor KOO received my blueprint, he asked me — somewhat bewildered — “Shouldn't there be a starting point and an ending point for a subway line? Is it really okay for it to just go around in a circle like this?”

I replied that not only was it possible, but also highly desirable, even though there was no precedent anywhere in the world. I told him that he would become a key figure in history by creating the world's first circular subway line.

KIM Kwangsoo: I'm sure he liked the idea.

KWAAK YoungHoon: (Laughs) He was truly an excellent mayor. The Seoul Subway Line 2 route was implemented very quickly.

KIM Kwangsoo: But why is it called Line 2 instead of Line 1?

KWAAK YoungHoon: To be honest, I'm still not entirely sure myself. Originally, what is now Subway Line 1 was designated as Line 2. However, some city officials insisted that the existing railway line connecting Seoul Station to Cheongnyangni Station should be designated as Line 1. Their reasoning was that, even though the connection was relatively short and underground, both stations held significant historical importance.

KIM Kwangsoo: Line 1 is a number in name only — in reality, Line 2 is the one that truly functions as the first line.

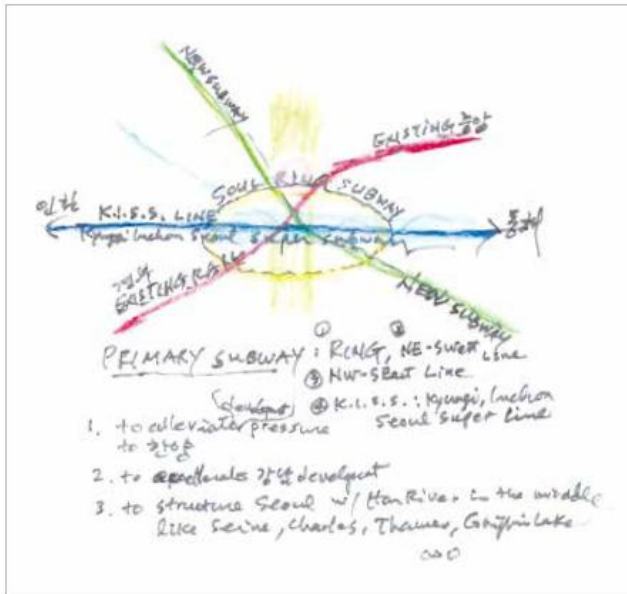
KWAAK YoungHoon: Correct. As a result, the line I had originally planned as Line 2 eventually became what is now Subway Line 3. This route plays an important role in balancing Seoul's transportation system, as it runs diagonally from the northwest to the southeast, effectively crossing Line 1, which runs in the opposite direction.

What was originally planned as Line 3 was actually more similar to today's Line 9 — a linear route extending from the eastern parts of Seoul all the way to Incheon International Airport. This was based on my vision of the Metropolitan Areas of Seoul, Incheon, and Gyeonggi Province forming what I called a "Metapolis"— a combination of "metabolism" and "polis" — representing a city with dynamic, efficient circulation.

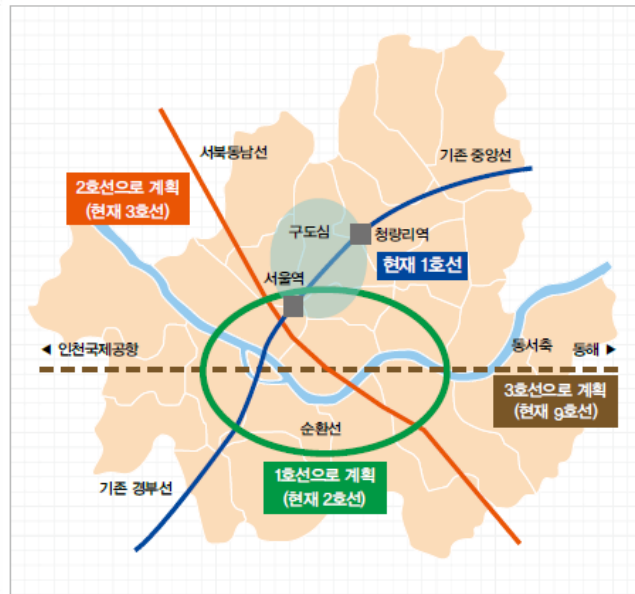
I also envisioned extending that line (now Line 9) toward the PyeongChang Winter Olympic site and Gangneung City, located on the East Sea. In fact, thanks to the 2018 PyeongChang Winter Olympics, we saw the extension of the KTX high-speed train in that direction, which was a step in the right direction. I am confident that, someday, Line 9 and the KTX will be integrated into a single, seamless system.

Correct. Without starting this major urban infrastructure early on, it would have been very difficult — and perhaps too late — for Seoul to host the Olympic Games.

Ultimately, I hope that a new, advanced mobility system will be developed — one that reaches all the way to Dokdo Island in the East Sea.



▲ Sketch of Seoul Subway Lines



▲ Seoul Subway Network

: Planning and Current Operations

Subway Staircase: Designed with Delicate Details

KWAAK YoungHoon: At the start of Line 2's construction, at the request of Mayor KOO Jachoon, KWAAK E.S.P.R.I. Inc., the company I founded, benchmarked subway systems in advanced countries and developed a pilot design for four stations: Hongik University Station, Hapjeong Station, Dongsan Station, Nakseong Station, and Seoul National University Station. Throughout this process, user convenience, safety, and maintainability were prioritized above all else. Also, special attention was given to the stairs, which are heavily used by many citizens.

The subway stairs were traditionally made of flagstone, which is fragile and brittle. Therefore, we replaced the material with a more durable granite. Instead of using concrete and granite panels, we used single-piece granite stones sized to fit each full step. We beveled the risers slightly to extend the tread area, providing more room for foot placement. The edges where the treads and risers meet were smoothly rounded to prevent sharp corners. The stairs were designed with a 30-degree slope to ensure comfortable and safe use for passengers. Additionally, I left a 3 to 4 cm gap between the steps and the side walls to facilitate sweeping and make cleaning easier.

KIM Kwangsoo: I hope you don't blame yourself too much. As you said earlier, there's no such thing as a perfect project. Every project leaves some regrets behind.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, thank you for your kind words.

However, what I regret most about the subway construction is that I was unable to follow the original design due to political interference exercised behind the scenes. When someone influential was connected to a certain area, the subway route was often adjusted in their favor. I thought such demands were unfair, but since the schedule was tight, I had to let them go. It was a kind of strategic silence.

As a result, the subway lines became crooked and inefficient. I wasn't able to minimize unnecessary transfers either. At the time, I thought we could straighten the crooked lines later, but progress has been stagnant ever since. Still, I believe the opportunity will come someday.

Incheon International Airport: A Controversial Project Everyone Opposed

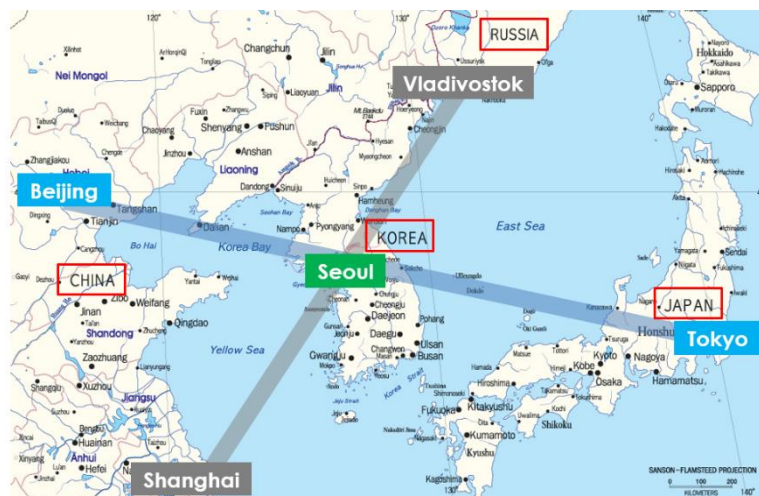
Optical Location for a Northeast Asia Hub Airport

KIM Kwangsoo: Since we're talking about transportation infrastructure, shall we turn our eyes to the sky?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, let's turn the topic to the Incheon International Airport project. It's an interesting case because most people were against my idea at the time.

KIM Kwangsoo: It has been over 20 years since Incheon International Airport opened in 2001. Considering that Gimpo International Airport already exists, why did you propose building a new international airport in Incheon, which is right next to Gimpo?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Seoul is the “Jungkyung (中京),” the central capital of Northeast Asia. I wanted to create a Northeast Asia hub airport in Korea.



▲ Seoul, The Central Capital of Northeast Asia

KIM Kwangsoo: Can you explain it in a simpler way? First of all, I'm curious about what 'hub' means.

KWAAK YoungHoon: A 'hub' refers to a place like the central axle of a bicycle wheel where the spokes come together. Today, a 'hub airport' means an international airport located at the center of a particular continental region. In the case of Incheon, it was intended to be the hub of the Northeast Asia.

The idea to build Incheon International Airport was inspired by the emergence of overseas hub

airports such as Kansai in Japan, Chek Lap Kok in Hong Kong, and Kuala Lumpur in Malaysia. Their goal was also to create international hub airports for Northeast Asia or East Asia.

However, it was obvious to me that the Seoul Metropolitan Area is truly at the center of Northeast Asia. Interestingly, the capital of China is Beijing (北京), which literally means “Northern Capital,” and the capital of Japan, Tokyo (東京), literally means “Eastern Capital.” Geographically, the Seoul Metropolitan Area, including the port city of Incheon, is the “Central Capital” (中京). I couldn’t let this opportunity pass by.

KIM Kwangsoo: If it includes the metropolitan area around Seoul, wouldn’t Gimpo also meet the conditions?



▲ Seoul Metropolitan Area

KWAAK YoungHoon: I did not consider Gimpo International Airport sufficient in terms of location and size to become the major hub airport for Northeast Asia. I had a larger and more ambitious vision for Seoul. I wanted Seoul to become a model city for environmental sustainability and energy conservation on a global scale.

My first idea was to expand the Seoul Metropolitan Area by integrating urban, rural, and marine regions. This meant that the metropolitan area should include Incheon port city and Gyeonggi Province, covering approximately 6,340 square kilometers — more than ten times the current size of Seoul. I thought it would be ideal to combine these areas to create a carbon-zero “Metapolis.”

Although it has not yet been realized, I believed that Incheon “seaport” should also have an “airport” and “teleport” facilities, which I collectively called the “Triports.” To find a suitable location, I researched and selected Yeongjongdo Island.

I consulted closely with a good friend of mine, Professor PARK ChangHo, a highly skilled airport engineer from Seoul National University. Together, we opened a map of the metropolitan area and drew a straight east–west axis stretching from Incheon to the eastern part of Seoul. Then, I extended this green east-west axis further from Yeongjongdo Island in Incheon, across the East Sea and Samcheok City, all the way to Ulleungdo Island and Dokdo Island.

Next, I drew a straight line connecting Mt. Bukaksan and Mt. Gwanaksan, passing through Mt. Namsan, Yongsan, and Umyeonsan, to create a north-south green axis. I then extended this axis to link the ridges of Seoul's four inner mountains — Mt. Bukaksan, Naksan, Namsan, and Inwangsan — as well as its four outer mountains — Mt. Bukhansan, Gwanaksan, Yongmasan, and Deokyangsan.

When ring roads are built in layers around Seoul, Gyeonggi Province takes on a donut-shaped form surrounding the city. Moreover, I envisioned that an ideal environmentally friendly city could be created by designing the urban, rural, and marine areas to intersect at each layer of these rings.

KIM Kwangsoo: Then, you must have seen Yeongjongdo Island in Incheon, located at the western end of the east west Green Axis, as the ideal location for the hub airport.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Exactly! At the same time, I always had to consider land price and size for future expansion as the Northeast Asia Hub Airport. I estimated that it would need to accommodate over 100 million passengers per year, and even more in the future. Yeongjongdo was very affordable — about 4 km by 4 km of reclaimed land — and I didn't have to worry about using taxpayers' money at the very start of the project. If I hadn't chosen this island site over several inland options, my policy recommendation wouldn't have even gotten off the ground.

Principles of Suggestion and Persuasion

KIM Kwangsoo: As always, it seems you've faced fierce opposition again.

KWWAK YoungHoon: Of course. (laughs) However, I persuaded the government decision-makers with the following three points:

1. Other developed countries have done the same. Korea needs to hurry up.
2. This project will be your achievement and a lasting legacy.
3. The geographical location is excellent according to the theory of geomency.

Usually, when you present your arguments this way, the justification for public policy is established.

KIM Kwangsoo: It's simple and clear.

KWAAK YoungHoon: At a time when the concept of a 'hub' was not widely recognized, it was more effective to persuade public officials by pointing out that many other countries had two hub airports, rather than trying to explain the abstract idea of a 'Northeast Asia hub.' So, I said, "There are many hub airports like this in other countries. Look at Paris, doesn't it have both Orly and Charles de Gaulle airports? London has Gatwick and Heathrow, and Tokyo has Haneda and Narita."

KIM Kwangsoo: “This project will be your legacy” appeals to the desire for recognition among those who wish to leave their name in history, while “The site has excellent geomantic energy” resonates deeply with the Korean sentiment rooted in geomancy.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes. However, even after the proposal for Incheon Airport became official policy, we continued to face the question — “Why does it have to be there?”

There were many opposing opinions, such as “It’s too close to North Korea,” “There’s too much fog,” “Why is it on the same side as Gimpo International Airport,” “There’s an 8-meter tidal difference twice a day,” and “Why are you damaging the marine environment through land reclamation?”

As a result, alternative locations such as the Sihwa District and Gunsan City were also considered. The Minister of the Environment at the time, Mme. SON Sook, even said in a radio interview, “Professor KWAAK, can you take responsibility for this?”

We also had to be concerned about the tight budget, as always. The airport construction began with government funding, and the Hyundai Group took charge of building the railway between the airport and Seoul. However, securing financing for the construction of the new highway turned out to be a major challenge.

KIM Kwangsoo: How did you solve the problem?

KWAAK YoungHoon: In 1995, I invited major Korean companies to establish a consortium. Board members from Daewoo, Samsung, SK, Lotte, and others gathered at the Korean restaurant in the Hilton Hotel. The first thing I had to do was explain the meaning of a “consortium” and the “Build-Operate-Transfer (BOT)” concept.

Fortunately, they agreed to establish a consortium and accepted the BOT method. As a result, we were able to build the toll gates and the highway through the BOT system. The business model was simple — the companies would cover the construction costs, operate the infrastructure and collect profits for a set period, and then transfer ownership back to the government.

KIM Kwangsoo: Didn’t you participate in the construction process?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Absolutely not. I had a firm and unwavering principle — I do not participate in any consequential projects arising from my MVIP or other related national development public policies that I have proposed. This is to prevent any misconception that I propose policies in order to secure contracts. Thanks to this principle, I have been able to focus on making national development policy proposals and master plans for the past 50 years, except in cases where I had no choice but to be directly involved, such as with the construction documents for Seoul Subway stations.

KIM Kwangsoo: I can see why you didn’t become rich despite taking on so many projects. (laughs)

Cheonggyecheon Stream (Cheonggyecheon) Flows Again

KIM Kwangsoo: I heard that you also proposed the Cheonggyecheon restoration project when Mr. LEE Myung-bak was the Mayor of Seoul. However, to be honest, I was disappointed with the restored Cheonggyecheon. It feels like an artificial canal made of cement, and the water is drawn from the Han River. It seems like a typical example of an “administration for show.”

KWAAK YoungHoon: That’s understandable. Just as I advised Mayor KOO Jachoon to creatively restore heritage sites such as Daehak-ro and the Joseon Dynasty castle walls, I also advised Mayor LEE to restore the covered natural Cheonggyecheon, the Blue Valley Stream, which once meandered through the center of the capital city of the Joseon Dynasty. I believed that we needed to tear down the harsh-looking highway built over the Cheonggyecheon at the same time. Let me briefly explain the history.

The Cheonggyecheon has long been a stream infamous for being difficult to manage, which troubled the kings of the Joseon Dynasty. However, since the Korean War in the 1950s, many homeless citizens began squatting along its edges. When it was not raining, household sewage flowed into the stream, causing a foul stench, and during the rainy season, flooding often occurred. As you may know, the Cheonggyecheon coverage project was initiated to address these problems, and the Cheonggye Overpass was built over the covered stream.

I raised the need to restore the Cheonggyecheon along with the Han River in the mid-1970s, but after Mayor KOO left to become Minister of the Interior, no mayor dared to undertake the restoration of the Cheonggyecheon. However, after the successful hosting of the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games, I was pleased to see that citizens and some civil society groups began to raise their voices. Seoul residents had come to realize that the Cheonggye Overpass was aging and posed safety risks. Additionally, citizens and civil organizations highlighted another serious problem — the completely covered Cheonggyecheon was filled with gas due to poor sewage treatment, putting the residents squatting nearby at risk of gas explosions.

However, the Cheonggyecheon restoration project was very difficult to pursue because the livelihoods of merchants in the Cheonggyecheon area were at stake. I believed it was one of the most challenging urban renewal projects in the world. At that time, I thought it was a good opportunity to speak with Mr. LEE Myung-bak, an ambitious National Assembly member elected from Jongno District, which includes Cheonggyecheon. He was also well known to the public as an experienced construction CEO of Hyundai Group. I called Mr. Lee and had dinner with him, during which I asked whether he would consider restoring Cheonggyecheon and mentioned the famous Boston “Big Dig” project as an example.

KIM Kwangsoo: What is the “Big Dig” project?

KWAAK YoungHoon: I will show you an article from the *Boston Globe* dated February 23, 2000, in which I discussed the need to create pedestrian-oriented land use on the demolished Route 95 highway. This major American civil engineering project was originally funded by former Massachusetts House Speaker Tip O’Neill. Mr. LEE Myung-bak made the restoration of Cheonggyecheon a central pledge during his campaign for Mayor of Seoul. To support this vision, I arranged a guided tour with my engineer friend, President Robert Daylor of Daylor Associates in Braintree, southeast of Boston. Robert took Mr. LEE to visit the Big Dig site in Boston.

think,” says Cox. “This isn’t just some kind of utopian pipe dream. What really impresses me about Kwaak is that he’s doing it.”

...

Sussing out the Big Dig

Boston, home of the Big Dig, should take note. The city, state, and turnpike officials in charge of – and sometimes quarreling about – the fate of the 26 acres that will be recovered once the Central Artery goes under might well bring Kwaak to the table, if not for actual design input, at least for his contagious and unifying enthusiasm. In addition to peace activist, Kwaak’s way with words make him a design poet.

“Why is this here? Why did they do this?” he can remember asking about the Central Artery when he first came to MIT four decades ago and saw a highway cutting off the North End from the rest of the city. When first conceived, he says, projects such as the Central Artery were not about “vision, but division.” He shakes his head. “People make mistakes. Smart people make mistakes. Holyoke Center in the middle of Harvard Square is a mistake. The Central Artery was a huge mistake.”

To Kwaak, burying the Central Artery becomes much more than a Big Dig plan to solve downtown traffic nightmares; it’s a city’s healing process. Tracing on a map how the shape of the North End resem-

bles a heart, the highway burial becomes a grand act “to have a wholesome heart again.” In this way, the challenge of what to do with the 26 acres becomes a chance to “restore the heart’s function” and, once repaired, Kwaak imagines a string of thriving parks and public spaces appealing to city residents and tourists alike, with the edges set aside for new commerce. To him, the new restaurants, boutiques, and galleries should be variegated – family-owned and ethnic – because, crucial to the heart’s functioning, “Special things happen in those settings. Real life goes on in those kitchens. They put their heart into their cooking. The result is socially just and equal and you get real stuff, not the phony institutional stuff.”

For most Bostonians, the Big Dig has become a Big Headache. Kwaak, ever optimistic, urges that the city – and especially the power brokers trying to decide the fate of the 26 acres – take a collective deep breath. “Let’s have a broader mind. The 26 acres is a wonderful opportunity,” he says, adding that the area can be seen as a first step in a greater regional overhaul. Pulling out notes and rough sketches, Kwaak describes a “millennium vision” for the Boston area, in which the recovered 26 acres becomes a strand in a larger “Beantown Loop” of greenery that connects North and South Station

The Boston Globe

▲ *Boston Globe*, February 23, 2000: Pedestrian-Oriented Land Use and the Big Dig Project

Starting in January 2003, just a year after his inauguration as mayor, Mr. LEE Myung-bak boldly launched the Cheonggyecheon restoration project. By 2005, 5.8 kilometers of Cheonggyecheon had been restored to its current state. You know the rest of his success story after serving as the Mayor of Seoul, he went on to become the President of Korea.

KIM Kwangsoo: Having lived for a while in the Cheonggyecheon shantytown during my youth, I am very happy to see the revival of Cheonggyecheon. However, I still feel some regret that it has become an artificial river made of cement. Compared to natural rivers, I believe it is less suitable for supporting aquatic life such as plants and fish.

KWAAK YoungHoon: If you’re worried about that, I think you can put those concerns aside. Before the restoration, there were 98 living species in Cheonggyecheon, but after the project, that number increased to 626 species — including 308 plants, 25 fish species, and 36 bird species — about 6.4 times more than before. Habitats for special species such as the Korean dark chub, Korean spine loach, dark sleeper, common sandpiper, gadwall, and salamander have also been confirmed.

Central Bus Lane System: Revolution of Seoul's Transportation System

KIM Kwangsoo: You also suggested creating bus-only lanes in downtown Seoul, right?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I did. When proposing the new bus route system alongside Seoul's subway system, I was inspired by a highly successful example of bus-based public transportation in Curitiba, Brazil.

Between 1990 and 1993, I visited Curitiba several times because one of my good Swedish friends, Peter Lindbergh, then head of Volvo Truck Korea, Inc., encouraged me: "Go to Curitiba to see their excellent public bus transportation system. I will arrange your trip." As you may know, Curitiba was reborn as the "World Ecological Capital" in 1971, after Jaime Lerner, a 33-year-old architect and urban planner, became mayor. Lerner served as mayor for more than 20 years — three times by government appointment and three times by public election — earning widespread praise for his environmental initiatives and effective city management.

KIM Kwangsoo: What was your impression when you visited Curitiba?

KWAAK YoungHoon: I saw how the city thrived when an architect became mayor. (laughs) Lerner even went on to become governor later. We became good friends, and he seriously encouraged me several times to run for mayor of Seoul. He said, "It is much, much more effective to improve a city as a mayor than as a planning official!"

KIM Kwangsoo: You might have wanted to be mayor too, right?

KWAAK YoungHoon: (Laughs) You know that I ran, don't you? As you always pointed out, the political situation in Korea was not only very bad, but really, really bad. I don't want to dwell on that now.

KIM Kwangsoo: Was the public transportation system in Curitiba well established as expected?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes! In Curitiba, I witnessed the reality of urban planning that I had envisioned. The city had well-developed public transportation and well-maintained bicycle and pedestrian paths. It was always simpler, as you know, to showcase real-life examples than to explain my planning visions, theories, and implementation strategies.

So, in 2003, I suggested to Mayor LEE Myung-bak that he visit Curitiba and introduce a central bus lane system in Seoul. The following year, bus-only lanes were established on several major trunk roads in Seoul, and bus service times were shortened and became more reliable thanks to the new system. That same year, a transfer system between buses and subways was also implemented, allowing citizens to use public transportation more conveniently.

KIM Kwangsoo: The Central Bus Lane System is a very good example of successful benchmarking. You must have felt proud seeing how it improved citizens' daily commutes.



▲ Central Bus Lane System in Seoul

Seoul Development Vision for the Future

KIM Kwangsoo: You have done a lot for the development of Seoul and its Metropolitan Area. How would you like Seoul and the Metropolitan Area to change in the future?

KWAAK YoungHoon: After becoming the capital of the Joseon Dynasty in 1394, Seoul was a fortress city with a population of around 100,000. When its name was changed to Gyeongseong in 1910 under Japanese colonization, the population had grown to about 230,000. Today, Seoul has become the political, economic, and cultural center of the Republic of Korea, with ten million people — one fifth of the country's population.

Unfortunately, the rapid development that began in the 1960s and 1970s led to the destruction of much of its precious cultural heritage and natural environment. However, Seoul is still a city with very favorable natural conditions. The Han River, which is as wide as a lake with an average width of about one kilometer, runs through the city center. Additionally, there are many mountains and hills, giving Seoul richer biodiversity compared to other large cities. In the past, many thought it was not an ideal site for a city, but now citizens have come to realize that it is a blessed terrain.

Until the mid-1970s, some professors even argued that many mountains in Seoul made urban development difficult and suggested that Mt. Namsan be leveled to flatten the terrain, as in large cities of so-called “advanced countries.” But no one would say that now. If we take advantage of Seoul's excellent topography and unique characteristics, I believe Seoul can become an environmentally sustainable city, distinct from many other large cities around the world.

KIM Kwangsoo: Could you explain in more detail?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Above all else, we need to design the urban environment with careful consideration of the mountain ranges, waterfronts, and abundant green spaces. I have mentioned this many times before, and we must pay as much attention to conservation as we do to development.

Currently, the total area of parks in Seoul alone is more than five times that of New York's Central Park. Increasing the percentage of green spaces throughout the city could make Seoul one of the world's greenest cities in the 21st century. Additionally, it is essential to preserve as much cultural heritage as possible and to approach new construction from a long-term perspective. A good example of this is the restoration of the Hanyang Fortress Walls and the preservation of traditional hanok villages such as Bukchon, Namchon, and Seochon. We must strive to make Seoul a sustainable city with a unique character.

Currently, in the Banpo area of Gangnam District, entire apartment complexes that are only about 40 years old have been demolished and replaced with uniform, characterless buildings by increasing the floor area ratio. After another 40 or 50 years, these buildings will likely be demolished and rebuilt again. This short-sighted approach to construction is harmful to both the development and preservation of the city. Cities should be viewed as living organisms, yet the culture that naturally develops over time is largely overlooked in Seoul's planning and management. This is very unfortunate for future generations. A city is a container of civilization, and the container itself is part of that civilization.

4

Planning the Core of the Korean Peninsula : Daejeon and Middle Region Projects

The Erased Master Plan and the 620 Project That Redrew the Map of the Korean Peninsula

Confidential Capital Relocation Plan

KIM Kwangsoo: As I looked around the room where your collections were displayed, a drawing with the unusual title “Blank-Slate Plan” caught my eye. Could you tell me, what is the Blank-Slate Plan?

KWAAK YoungHoon: In short, it was a secret capital relocation plan quietly developed by the Yushin regime. The name “Blank-Slate Plan” may sound like it refers to envisioning a new administrative capital from a blank slate, but in reality, it more strongly implies that the plan could be wiped clean or nullified at any time.

The PARK regime appeared to be concerned that in the event of a sudden provocation by North Korea, the capital, Seoul, could be paralyzed all at once. Such concerns likely deepened following the armed communist infiltration of the Blue House on January 21, 1968.

In the 1970s, the government, in order to secretly develop plans for relocating the capital, established an Administrative Capital Relocation Team under the Heavy and Chemical Industry Planning Division, entirely unrelated to the project itself, and carried out the planning under strict confidentiality.

A location for the new administrative capital was chosen within a ten-kilometer radius between the cities of Jochiwon and Gongju. However, when I began the planning process, the Blue House did not disclose the exact site. Instead, they instructed me to design the city on a theoretical level, envisioning a self-sufficient city with a population of 500,000.

Then, in the summer of 1977, the PARK Chung-hee regime entrusted around 30 university professors with this special task. At the time, I was the Head of the Department of Urban Planning at Hongik University, and I received the call as well. That’s how I became the city planner for the new capital.

KIM Kwangsoo: As the name implies, it was a very secretive plan. What was your main role in the project?

KWAAK YoungHoon: There were three main tasks:

1. Comprehensive Master Plan for the New Capital
2. Environmental Design of the Central District of the New Capital
3. Comparative Study of International New Capital Projects

Back then, I was so overwhelmed by teaching in the Departments of Architecture, Urban Planning, and Landscape Architecture, barely finding time to spare. But once I took on the task of the Blank-Slate Plan, every day felt like a struggle. I guess I could manage it because I was thirty-five back then.

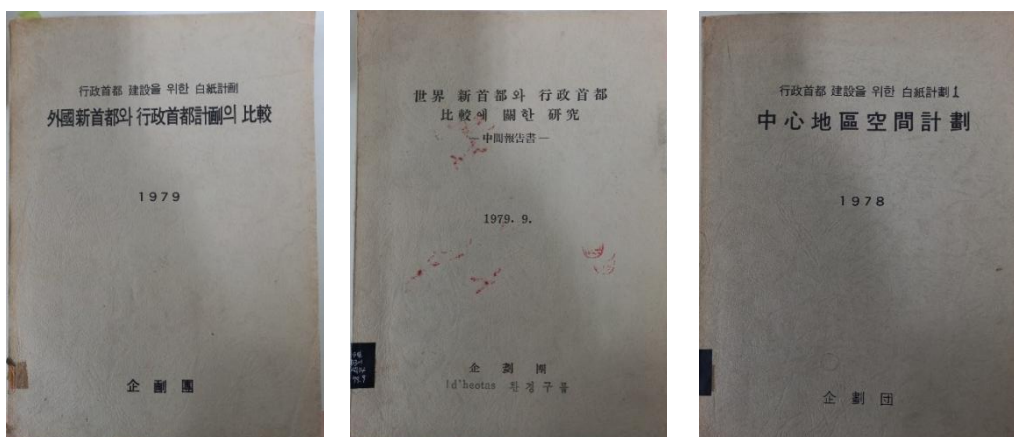
KIM Kwangsoo: You were carrying out a project that was unilaterally ordered by President PARK

Chung-hee, who had previously tried to block your career. Given his past behavior, you probably didn't want to be involved in his project.

KWAAK YoungHoon: That was in the past, and what he did was not personally directed at me. More importantly, I worked not for a particular president, but for the future of the country. So, I accepted the Blue House's request to do whatever I could to either prevent potential wrongdoing or help create the best possible plan. I wanted to design something that would stand as an exemplary case in the history of public policy and urban planning in Korea.

The site selection had been made by Chief Economic Advisor OH Won-chul before my involvement. However, as I studied and developed various design alternatives, I came to realize that the selected site for the new capital was not suitable. Firstly, it would have a negative impact on the existing city, Daejeon, and its surrounding areas. Secondly, it failed to meet the original national security rationale. A group of professors formed a task force to propose alternative sites and conduct a comparative analysis, but the original site remained unchanged. Above all, it would waste taxpayers' money.

In the same vein, I believed it was crucial for political decision-makers to study the development of new capitals in other countries before deciding on Korea's new capital. I asked President PARK's Chief Economic Advisor, Mr. OH, for permission to visit foreign new capitals. The four destinations I selected were Brasilia (Brazil), Chandigarh (India), Islamabad (Pakistan), and Canberra (Australia). Before leaving, I made it clear that I would "not only look at the good examples, but also examine the bad cases and mistakes." After visiting the four new capital developments over the course of a month, I submitted a report to "the Heavy and Chemical Industry Planning Division."



▲ Reports on the New Capital Development and Comparative Studies

KIM Kwangsoo: Since Korea's administrative capital has remained Seoul, does that mean the Blank-Slate Plan was ultimately abandoned?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Although the project was secret, information appears to have leaked because so many people were involved. All kinds of speculation and criticism poured in, and President PARK was eventually forced to announce that "the new capital development plan is only for preparatory purposes, and we call it the Blank-Slate Plan."

At any rate, after President PARK was assassinated on October 26, 1979, the Blank-Slate Plan was abandoned.



▲ The Master Plan Designed by KWAAK E.S.P.R.I.



▲ Urban Design Plan for the Central District Designed by KWAAK E.S.P.R.I.

The 620 Project: Secret of Daejeon City's Growth

KIM Kwangsoo: What kind of project was the “620 Project?” It seems to have a similar connotation to the Blank-Slate Plan.

KWAAK YoungHoon: It was a project to design a new city that could serve as a backup for the capital in case of emergencies.

It was June 1980. I was asked by KIM Jae-ik, the newly appointed Chief Advisor to President CHUN, to have a meeting at the Blue House. Dr. KIM requested that I resign from all my positions, including my university professorship, and work confidentially on this national project only.

We sat down and discussed the future of Korea comprehensively. Afterward, he made a phone call to an economic planning officer and allocated a budget of one million dollars in advance. A little later, he decided to officially start the project on June 20th, which he subsequently named the “620 Project,” based solely on the date we met.

KIM Kwangsoo: What does the 620 Project include?

KWAAK YoungHoon: You will be surprised at how many “Nation Building” projects were realized based on the 620 Project and how they impacted Korea’s “Miraculous Development.”

Unlike the previous Blank-Slate Plan which I did not have the complete control over any site selection and real public policy decisions, Dr. KIM gave me full authority so that I could make any decisions, based on our first trusting conversation in the Blue House in early 1980.

I started analyzing Daejeon City and its vicinity as a new alternative capital city, in case of a national disaster. I realized that Daejeon, including the areas of Yusong District and Daedeok District, could become viable as a contingent capital city. So, I completely discarded the Blank-Slate Plan, which was a plan to build an entirely new city.

The first thing I did was select the site for *Gyeryongdae*, the command center of the Republic of Korea’s armed forces.

KIM Kwangsoo: Did you select Sindoan-myeon, located in the southern area of Mt. Gyeryongsan, as the site for Gyeryongdae, also known as the Pentagon of Korea?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I did. I conducted a survey of the Sindoan area in Mt. Gyeryongsan as a potential site for military and national security research activities. I referred to it as the “Octagon House,” similar to the Pentagon in Washington, D.C.

Secondly, I recommended that Daedeok Science Town, which spans over 2,400 hectares in Daedeok District, be considered as a site for scientific development and be incorporated into the Daejeon Metropolitan Area.

Lastly, I suggested establishing the Korea Institute of Technology (KIT) within Daedeok Science Town. I envisioned creating a Korean MIT, and as a result, KIT was established. Later, KIT changed its name to the Korea Advanced Institute of Science and Technology (KAIST).

I am incredibly happy to see that KAIST has grown into one of the best universities in the world today. Both KAIST and Daedeok Science Town have been performing exceptionally well.

KIM Kwangsoo: Gyeryongdae, Daedeok Science Town, and KAIST — you planned all of these. Were there any other projects you had planned as well?

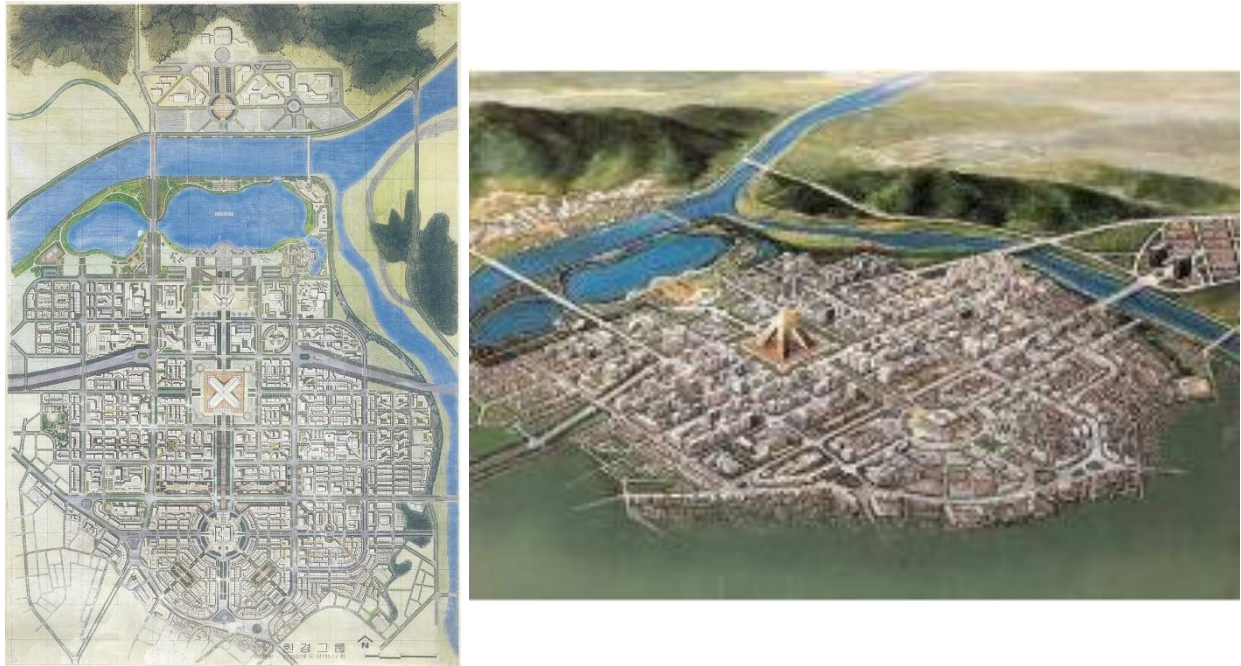
KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, the Daejeon Expo 1993 site was also planned in the southern part of the Daedeok Science Town, and as you know, it played a significant role in accelerating Korea’s technology-based development.

KIM Kwangsoo: I heard that you also converted the Dunsan Air Force Base into the new Central Business District (CBD) for the Daejeon Metropolitan Area.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I did! You really know more details than I expected.

I also proposed the redevelopment of 660 hectares of the Dunsan Air Force Base, which is now the very center of Daejeon. I even created a detailed urban design plan, including an underground city, to function as the National Administrative Center in the event of a national security contingency.

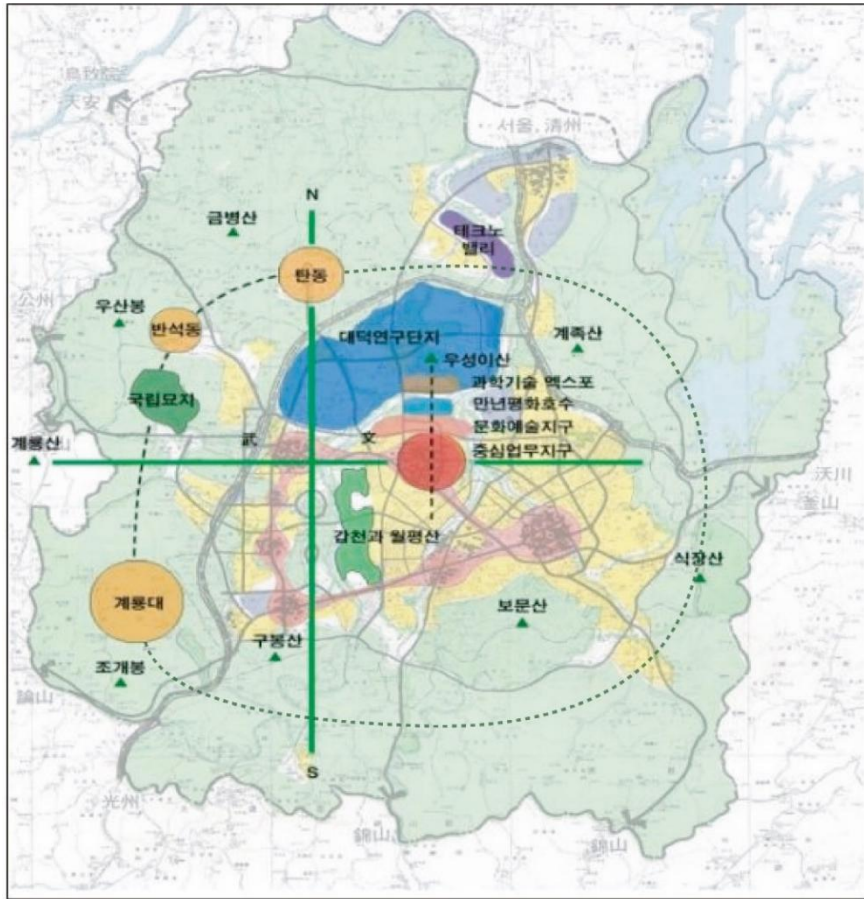
Dr. KIM was particularly fond of the Daejeon contingency idea. I originally planned for the Octagon Building, known as Gyeryongdae, to be connected to this Dunsan administrative area. If I had not included the conversion of the Air Force Base into the Daejeon CBD, it would not have been possible today.



▲ Daejeon Expo Site and Dunsan Administrative Area Plan

KIM Kwangsoo: Did you also select the site for the second National Cemetery?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes. I selected the site for the second National Cemetery with the assistance of Mr. JI Chung-rong, who was recognized as one of the leading geomancy theorists.



▲ Daejeon Master Plan as Part of the 620 Project

KIM Kwangsoo: Were there any other plans?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, there were several more. However, as you know, Dr. KIM Jae-ik was assassinated in Aung San, Myanmar, and I was unable to discuss the confidential matters with anyone. As a result, I couldn't fully realize several additional contingency plans.

KIM Kwangsoo: What were those plans?

KWAAK YoungHoon: One of them was a massive underground facility for food storage, which I called the "Shikjangsan Project," named after Mt. Shikjangsan in Daejeon, as it literally means "storage mountain." The second plan was a national security research institute, and the third was an extensive underground circulation system connecting various national capital functions in case of a contingency or emergency. It is regrettable that all of these plans were never realized.

Administrative Capital Relocation at Every Change of Government

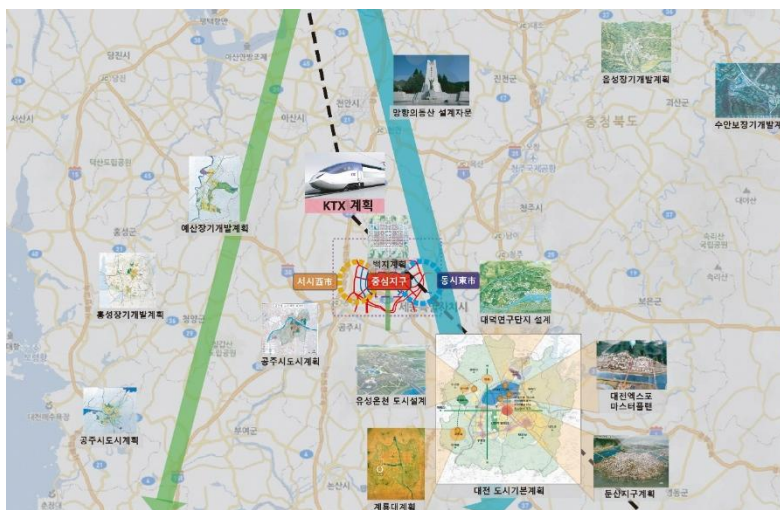
KIM Kwangsoo: The relocation of the administrative capital is a recurring topic during election seasons. Does this mean we should revive the Blank-Slate Plan and the 620 Project?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It's not like that. As you know, when ROH Moo-Hyun Administration pushed to relocate the administrative capital, the Blank-Slate Plan and the 620 Project got attention again. President ROH's plan to relocate the administrative capital was ruled unconstitutional by the Constitutional Court, but in 2012, under the PARK Geun-hye government, the administrative capital of Sejong was launched.

The current location of Sejong Special Self-Governing City corresponds to the eastern city within the central district planned during the Blank-Slate Plan.



▲ Sejong Special Self-Governing City: Location in the Blank-Slate Plan and the 620 Plan



▲ Key Projects in Daejeon and the Middle Region

Korea's High-Speed Train, KTX: Transforming Transportation Infrastructure

KIM Kwangsoo: When the Gyeongbu Line was completed in 1905, the travel time between Seoul and Busan took approximately 17 hours. In 1960, with the introduction of the Mugunghwa train, the journey was reduced to 6 hours. Later, in the 1980s, the Saemaeul train further shortened the travel time to 4 hours. Today, thanks to the high-speed KTX, the same trip takes just 2 hours.

The KTX was originally planned as part of the transportation infrastructure for the Daejeon Expo. You were responsible for the master plan of the Expo, so you also participated in the development of the KTX, right?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, when I proposed hosting the Daejeon Expo to Dr. KIM Jae-ik in 1981, I also immediately suggested the introduction of high-speed train infrastructure. I said, "Japan connected the 1964 Tokyo Olympic Stadium and the 1970 Osaka Expo site with the Shinkansen, and the high-speed rail network established at that time became a cornerstone of its economic development. Likewise, if we are to host the Daejeon Expo, we should build a high-speed railway to connect Seoul, Daejeon, and Yeosu."

KIM Kwangsoo: I'm curious how you were able to lead the introduction of high-speed train in Korea, given that you're not a railway expert.

KWAAK YoungHoon: As the nation-building architect planner, the development of high-speed trains was naturally an essential part of the infrastructure we needed to build. As you mentioned, I was always searching and researching ways to further develop Korea. For a long time, I have closely studied Germany's ICE, Japan's Shinkansen, and France's TGV.

In 1985, I asked Daejeon Mayor KWON Yong-tae to visit France to study the TGV system, and I recommended that he accompany staff members involved in Daejeon's urban development. Thanks to arrangements made by a senator, we took a high-speed train from Paris to Lyon, which operated at speeds of up to 300 km/h.

While the terrain in France is mostly flat, Korea's landscape is mountainous, which meant that we faced the challenge of drilling numerous tunnels. In order to address these problems, I traveled to Sweden and Finland to study the Tunnel Boring Machine (TBM), a circular rotating excavator well-suited for cutting through granite. I then introduced the TBM technology to CHUNG Ju-yung, Chairman of Hyundai Group.

When selecting the high-speed train system, companies from Japan, Germany, and France participated in a highly competitive bidding process. Considering economic feasibility, operational experience, and technology transfer conditions, the Korean government ultimately chose the French TGV system in 1994.

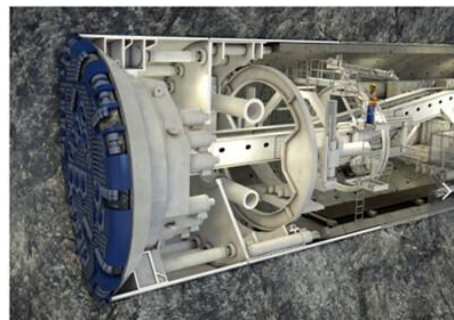
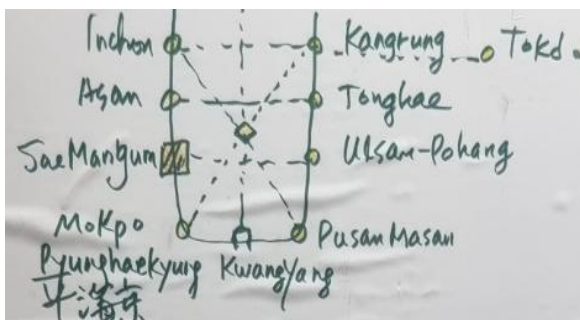
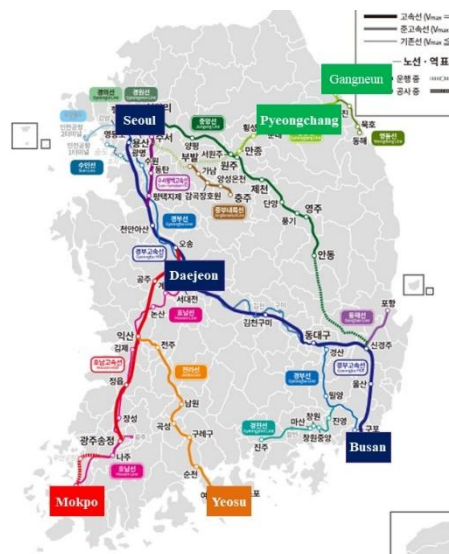
However, the construction period was extended due to the outbreak of the IMF financial crisis in Korea. Finally, after 10 years of development, the Seoul-Busan high-speed train, KTX, was officially opened in 2004. As a result, Korea became the fifth country in the world to operate high-speed rail and subsequently opened six KTX lines: the Gyeongbu, Honam, Gyeongjeon, Jeolla, Donghae, and Gangneung Lines.

The KTX has effectively reduced travel across the country to a half-day radius, completely transforming the concepts of travel, commuting, and business trips. It became possible to travel anywhere in the country within a day. The KTX has also revitalized the economies of cities and surrounding regions at major stops. In particular, the Gangneung Line, which opened at the end of 2017, played a crucial role in the success of the 2018 PyeongChang Winter Olympics, transporting approximately 1.06 million people to the mountainous Gangwon Region.

KIM Kwangsoo: The KTX fundamentally changed Koreans' perception of distance and time. Since its opening, the KTX operated one million trips over 15 years until 2019, carrying a total of 720 million passengers. Considering Korea's population is around 50 million, this means the entire nation has ridden the KTX an average of more than 14 times.

From highways to subways and high-speed trains, I believe you have played an indispensable role in the history of transportation infrastructure in Korea.

KWAAK YoungHoon: As I have repeatedly emphasized, my role was limited to providing schematic ideas and master plans. However, I really appreciate your kind words.



▲ KTX Line Planning and Tunnel Boring Machines (TBM)

Manghyang Park in Cheonan: The Final Resting Sanctuary for Overseas Koreans

KIM Kwangsoo: I think this would be a good point to wrap up our discussion on Daejeon and the Middle Region projects. Before we move on, is there any other project you would like to introduce or highlight?

KWAAK YoungHoon: I would like to introduce Manghyang Park in Cheonan City. It is a cemetery established by the Korean government for overseas Koreans who wished to be buried to rest in their homeland. Originally, it was built as a final resting place for those who had passed away abroad during the Japanese colonial period and World War II, but whose family ties could not be confirmed.

Over time, it has come to serve as a memorial for all Koreans living abroad who hoped to return to their homeland in spirit, even after death. Although I was not directly involved in its design or construction, Manghyang Park is among the places I feel most personally connected to, out of the many projects I have advised on.

KIM Kwangsoo: Manghyang Park is a precious resting place for souls who long for their homeland. May I ask how you came to be involved as an advisor for the Manghyang Park project?

KWAAK YoungHoon: In 1976, KIM Young-kwang, Director of the Evaluation and Planning Bureau of the Central Intelligence Agency, asked me to consult on planning a grave and memorial site for Korean residents in Japan, as many of them wished to be buried in their homeland after death.

After much consideration, I recommended Cheonan, a city with convenient transportation and a name that means “a place where the sky is at ease.” The entire process, from construction to completion, took less than three months. If you have the chance, I highly recommend visiting this place.



▲ Manghyang Cemetery Park

5

Toward the Sea : Yeosu and Southern Region Projects

Fifty Years with Yeosu

Yeosu: A Strategic Base for the Development of Honam and the Southern Coastal Areas

KIM Kwangsoo: You mentioned that, thanks to the persistent efforts of Yeosu citizens, you became the Chairman of the Yeosu World Expo Bid Committee. It seems you must have a special relationship with Yeosu.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, indeed. Since 1976, I have frequently traveled to Yeosu for business, as I designed Yeosu City Hall, Yecheon New Town, and the Yeoseo and Munsu Districts.

KIM Kwangsoo: Traveling from Seoul to Yeosu is quite a long business trip — one of the longest, in fact. Compared to other regions, the transportation is not very convenient even now, so it must have taken a lot of time and energy just to get there and back.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Exactly. So, I usually took the night train. When I arrived at Yeosu Station at dawn, I would wash up at the public bath in front of the station and then go straight to City Hall for an urban environment planning meeting. The old Yeosu City Hall had wooden floors, but they were so worn that they creaked loudly with every step.

KIM Kwangsoo: The creaking wooden floors of City Hall give me an idea of what conditions in Yeosu were like at the time.

KWAAK YoungHoon: In the 1970s, not only Yeosu but the entire Jeolla Province faced economic hardship compared to other regions. Until the liberation from Japanese colonial rule, Honam region, which had been a key contributor to the national treasury, was stigmatized by subsequent authoritarian regimes as a hotbed of communism. During the process of industrialization, it was marginalized, and as a result, its standard of living fell behind that of other regions.

Whenever I traveled to places in Jeolla-do such as Yeosu, Suncheon, Mokpo, Naju, Yeongsanpo, and Gwangju, I heard about the unfortunate stories and hardships of the local people. I vowed to do my best within the scope of what I can do to help Honam develop further and improve the lives of its local residents. With that resolve, I chose Yeosu, one of the key points of Korea's Active Axis, as a hub for the development of Honam Region.

The Only Traditional Hanok-Style City Hall in Korea

KIM Kwangsoo: The current Yeosu City Hall building stands out for its distinctly Korean design inspired by traditional *hanok* architecture. It is very impressive that you designed the City Hall in the form of a hanok in the 1970s, when most people were eager to demolish traditional hanok houses and

replace them with modern buildings.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Originally, I wanted to use not only the hanok-style form but also traditional building materials. The first design I created for the city hall was a traditional wooden hanok. However, the plan was revised because Prime Minister CHOI Kyu-ha argued against the plan and urged me not to proceed with it. He said, “Why are you building a traditional hanok instead of designing it in a modern style, especially after studying at MIT? Wood is precious and expensive here. Use cement to build it.”

This happened at a time when President PARK Chung-hee was emphasizing national reforestation efforts.

KIM Kwangsoo: I remember that, too. Before briquettes were introduced, people used wood for firewood. As a result, the mountains across the country became almost bare, and a nationwide tree-planting project was launched.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I suggested to the Prime Minister that the City Hall should be built in a traditional style to showcase Korea’s unique beauty when a global event is eventually held in Yeosu, but it was not easy to overcome the practical obstacles.



▲ Yeosu City Hall, Designed in Traditional Hanok-Style

KIM Kwangsoo: In the end, you compromised — keeping the hanok shape but using concrete as the building material. You must have been disappointed.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I have. However, I am satisfied that the building was completed in the Korean style I had envisioned. For your information, Yeosu City Hall is the only hanok-style city hall in Korea.

Yeocheon New Town, Designed from a Helicopter

KWAAK YoungHoon: When Yeosu City Hall was newly built, Yeocheon New Town was developed as a hinterland city supporting the Yeocheon Industrial Complex, located near Gwangyang Bay. I designed the city by observing the terrain from a helicopter, accompanied by KOH Geon, the Governor of Jeollanam-do (South Jeolla Province).

The most important consideration when designing Yeocheon New Town was to avoid damaging historical sites, including Jinnamgwan, which General YI Sun-sin had used as his headquarters. I chose the site for Yeocheon City Hall at a location with a clear view of the shipyard where the turtle ships were built, and created a spacious park between Yeocheon City Hall and Gamak Bay.

KIM Kwangsoo: Was Yeocheon New Town built according to your original plan?

KWAAK YoungHoon: I wish it had been. I envisioned a city without high-rise buildings, but during the construction process, my urban design was ignored and transformed into a series of characterless, tawdry apartment complexes — so drastically that the original layout became unrecognizable.

Yeoseo and Munsu Districts: A Stepping-Stone Bridge Between Yeosu and Yeocheon

KIM Kwangsoo: Today, Yeosu has developed into one of the five largest cities in Jeolla-do. However, at the time Yeosu was selected as a base for the development Honam region, it was just an ordinary port city on the southern coast. It seems that you drew up a roadmap in advance for Yeosu to grow into a major tourist city capable of hosting significant global events, such as the Expo.

KWAAK YoungHoon: The primary goal was to unite the administrative districts, which had been divided into three separate areas, into one combined district. After liberation from Japanese colonial rule, Yeosu was divided into Yeosu City and Yeocheon County. However, with the development of Yeocheon New Town in the late 1970s, the administrative structure was reorganized into a system of two cities and one county: Yeosu City, Yeocheon City, and Yeocheon County. The existence of three separate administrative districts within one area caused the potential of Yeosu to be dispersed.

I believed that the development of Yeosu could gain momentum only when its population and industry were unified through the integration of these three districts. Therefore, by developing Yeoseo-dong and Munsu-dong, located between Yeosu and Yeocheon, as a new town, I devised an urban plan to integrate Yeosu, Yeoseo/Munsu, and Yeocheon into a single cohesive living area.

At first, I proposed the development plan to the Korea Land Development Corporation (now Korea Land and Housing Corporation), but they responded that construction would be difficult because the Yeoseo and Munsu areas are located in narrow valleys. After discussing this with Mayor SONG Jaegu, a very visionary and capable city manager, we decided to initiate a public development project at the Yeosu city level.

KIM Kwangsoo: If it is a ‘public development,’ does that mean it is developed directly by the local government?

KWAAK YoungHoon: That’s right. If the development results had been unsatisfactory, Mayor SONG would have had to take full responsibility and resign from office.

KIM Kwangsoo: He made a difficult decision.



▲ Yecheon New Town Plan



▲ Urban Parks Plan:
Yecheon Mangma, Yonggi, and Ansan

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, indeed. He was willing to sacrifice himself for the public good.

The public development of a new city was unprecedented in Korea’s history. Since it was a high-risk project, we carefully devised a master plan. To minimize civil construction costs, the design preserved the natural topography, and the residential areas of existing residents were maintained. By pre-selling the land created through the development, we were able to raise funds for the project without using Yeosu City’s budget.

KIM Kwangsoo: Was the development of the Yeoseo and Munsu Districts considered successful?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes! it was very successful! Yeosu made a profit of about 40 billion won from this project. Since then, the public development of new towns modeled after the Yeoseo and Munsu Districts has continued across the country.

KIM Kwangsoo: Yeosu City essentially created a new business model.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes. Yeosu City has introduced another innovation: an eco-friendly tunneling technique that does not cut through mountain ranges. The Hanjae Tunnel, which connects Yecheon and Yeosu, is the first ecological tunnel in Korea. Despite objections over the high cost of construction, Mayor SONG pushed forward with the project and successfully completed the drilling of the tunnel.

Today, many local governments are replacing mountain roads with ecological tunnels.

Thanks to a series of efforts since the 1980s to integrate Yeosu City, Yecheon City, and Yecheon County, the unified Yeosu City was officially established in 1998 under the leadership of its citizens.



▲ Urban Development Plan
for the Yeoseo and Munsu Districts



▲ Hanjae Tunnel

The Sea of Yeosu That Attracts Tourists

KIM Kwangsoo: What followed after the integration of the three cities, which was the primary goal of the Yeosu Development Plan?

KWAAK YoungHoon: When I was designing the urban plan for Yecheon New Town, I considered the larger regional context, as I had envisioned back in 1971 that this southern coastal area would one day host an Expo.

I divided the Yeosu, Suncheon, Namhae, and Gwangyang Regions into four thematic belts and proposed specific directions for development and conservation:

1. Industrial Belt: Inland areas near Gwangyang Bay
2. Leisure Belt: The sea and islands around Gamak Bay
3. Environmental Belt: Areas surrounding Suncheon Bay
4. Marina and Resort Belt: Namhae Island

The inland areas centered around Gwangyang were planned to develop as industrial cities, while the coastal areas centered around Yeosu were intended to grow into tourist cities. Based on this plan, we carried out several projects, some of which were successful, while others, unfortunately, were not.



▲ Schematic Plan of the Four Development Belts

KIM Kwangsoo: Ultimately, it seems that the decades of hard work and dedication you invested in developing Yeosu and its infrastructure have not been in vain. Yeosu, which had been steadily growing, succeeded in hosting the Yeosu Expo 2012 and has established itself as a leading tourist city. According to statistics, Yeosu ranked as the most visited city in Korea by tourists in 2018.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I really like that statistic! I feel the decades I spent traveling between Seoul and Yeosu by night train were rewarding. I hope Yeosu becomes a city where both visitors and residents want to stay for a long time.



▲ Yeosu City

The Turning Point in Gwangyang's Development

Establishing Steel Mill in Gwangyang City

KIM Kwangsoo: Gwangyang is one of the cities located on the Active Axis passing through Honam area. When I hear the name “Gwangyang,” the first thing that comes to mind is “steel mill.” As far as I know, you played a key role in transforming Gwangyang into a city centered on the steel industry. When Pohang Iron & Steel Company (POSCO) was looking for a site for its new steel mill, it was you who recommended Gwangyang, right?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I did. In 1972, POSCO began searching for a location to build its second steel mill, but no decision was made for nine years. The candidates were eventually narrowed down to two areas: Gwangyang Bay and Asan Bay. Consulting teams from the United States and the Netherlands, along with various domestic experts, recommended Asan Bay in Chungcheongnam-do (South Chungcheong Province) due to its proximity to the Seoul Metropolitan Area. In contrast, I consistently advocated for Gwangyang Bay.

KIM Kwangsoo: I think I understand the reason. It was probably to develop the underdeveloped Honam region and achieve balanced regional development.

KWAAK YoungHoon: You're right! It feels as if you can see right through me now. In addition to that reason, I emphasized that the climate of Gwangyang Bay, being at a low latitude, rarely drops below freezing even in winter. The steel mill was ultimately built in Gwangyang Bay based on the judgment of JEONG Myeong-sik, POSCO Vice Chairman and an expert in civil engineering.

KIM Kwangsoo: With the creation of the world's largest single-site steel mill, Gwangyang achieved financial independence, and the income levels of its residents rose sharply. Today, Gwangyang, together with Yeosu — a neighboring tourist city — is leading the economy of the eastern part of Jeollanam-do. If the steel mill had been built in Asan Bay instead of Gwangyang Bay, the gap between Chungcheong Province, which is close to the Seoul Metropolitan Area, and Jeolla Province, which is farther away, would have widened even more.

The Person Who Made Today's Gwangyang Port Possible

KIM Kwangsoo: You were also involved in selecting the site for the Gwangyang Container Terminal, which, together with the Gwangyang Steel Mill, drives the regional economy of Gwangyang, right?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, it was around the time when the Gwangyang Steel Mill was being established. In 1986, the Korean government requested a loan from the World Bank to finance the construction of a container pier. As a result, World Bank officials visited Korea.

KIM Kwangsoo: So, the World Bank sent experts to assess which location would generate the greatest profit for building the container terminal and to decide on the site, right?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes. If the expected profits from the container pier were not sufficient to repay the loan, they would not have provided the funding.

KIM Kwangsoo: So, which site did the World Bank officials ultimately choose?

KWAAK YoungHoon: All of them were in the Busan area. Gwangyang wasn't even considered as a viable option. After hearing the results of the review, I made a firm decision and visited the World Bank officials at dawn on the day of their departure to have breakfast with them. Then, I explained why a container port should be built in Gwangyang.

The person in charge at the time was an African-American economist, and I appealed to him by comparing regional discrimination in Korea to racism in the United States. I explained, "The reason Gwangyang lacks infrastructure is that Honam region has long suffered from regional discrimination. We must think in reverse: we must build infrastructure because there is no infrastructure. This is why a container port must be constructed in Gwangyang. It is essential for the balanced regional development of the Republic of Korea."

In fact, at the time, a construction secretary at the Blue House opposed building a container pier in Gwangyang, arguing that the development of Honam was politically undesirable.

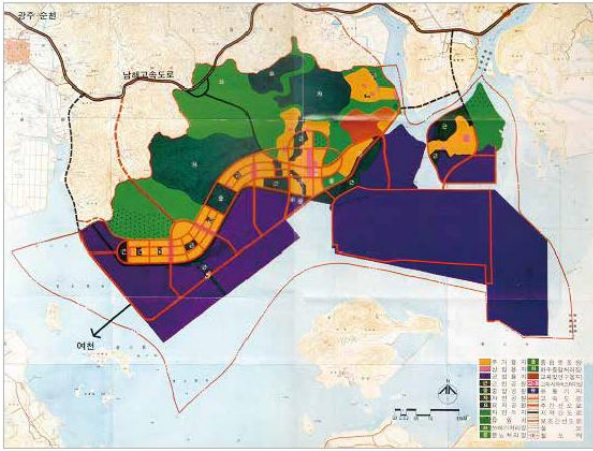
KIM Kwangsoo: Did that economist take your words seriously?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Thankfully, he understood well what I meant. He said, "I will write a report stating that the construction of a container pier for one berth in Gwangyang Bay is feasible. Please use my report to persuade the Korean government." Then he took out his laptop, revised the policy proposal, and showed it to me. In his report, he wrote that one berth — meaning a section of water equipped with facilities to accommodate a single vessel — could be constructed in Gwangyang Bay.

KIM Kwangsoo: He is a very open-minded person, as he listened to and accepted the words of a stranger who suddenly appeared. You have met a noble man.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Fortunately, he listened attentively and revised his study paper on the spot. As soon as he left for the airport, I rushed to a public telephone booth and called JEON Seok-hong, the governor of Jeollanam-do, urging him to immediately establish a branch office in eastern Gwangyang. He gave the order to build the Eastern Gwangyang Branch, and I went on to design the new town around the temporary city hall, located near the site I had designated for the future Gwangyang Port.

A few years ago, I inquired about the economist's whereabouts to the World Bank to inform him of the development of Gwangyang Port and express my gratitude. I learned that he had died in a car accident while on official duty in Africa. I should have reached out to him earlier, but it was too late.



▲ Eastern Gwangyang City Master Plan



▲ Gwangyang Port Hinterland: Madong District Plan



▲ Gwangyang Container Port

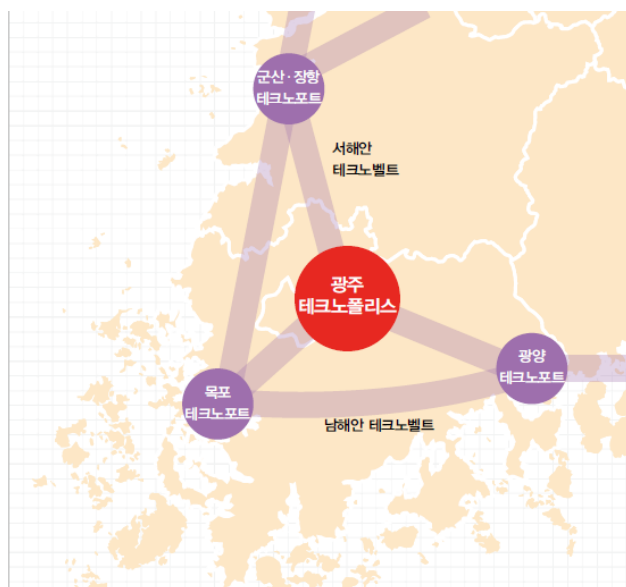
Transforming Gwangju into a “City of Light”

KIM Kwangsoo: When it comes to the Honam region, Gwangju City cannot be left out. Since Gwangju and its surrounding areas suffered greatly from the armed repression carried out by the CHUN Doo-hwan regime during the May 18 Gwangju Democratization Movement in 1980, I believe it was a region of particular concern for you within Honam.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, it truly was. So, I really wanted to make Gwangju a “City of Light,” just as its name implies.

KIM Kwangsoo: What was the first project you started?

KWAAK YoungHoon: The first project I undertook was a long-term, comprehensive development plan for Mt. Mudeungsan Provincial Park in 1983. Whenever I visited Gwangju on business, I would climb Mt. Mudeungsan and stay at Wonhyosa and Jeungshimsa temples. I was shocked to see the extensive damage to the mountainsides. In particular, I noticed that the natural rock area called Nudulbawe was being destroyed due to the construction of a road around Mt. Mudeungsan. I brought this issue to the attention of the Jeonnam-do Provincial Government and proposed a nature-friendly conservation and development plan for Mt. Mudeungsan.



▲ The West Coast Techno-Network Centered on Gwangju

KIM Kwangsoo: As far as I know, you’re not the kind of person who would sit back and watch deforestation. (laughs)

Gwangju was one of the three key vertices of the National Science and Techno-Network you envisioned along with the cities of Daejeon and Daegu.

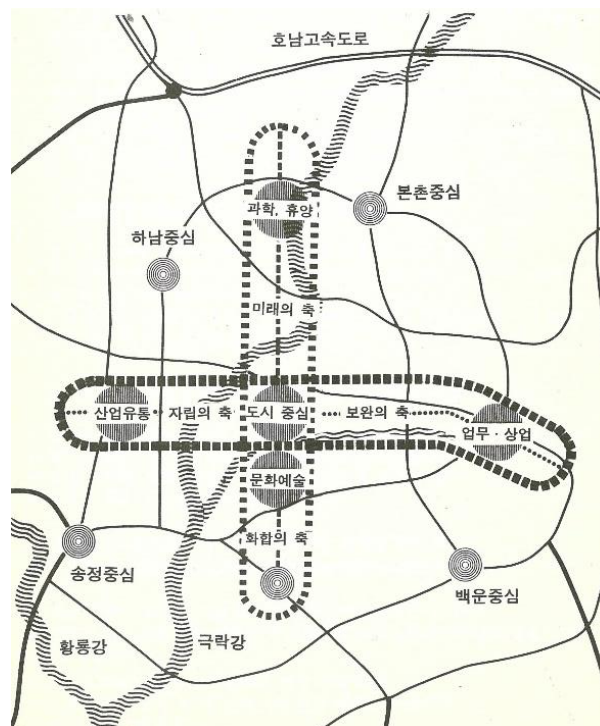
KWAAK YoungHoon: The plan was to create technology valleys — science and technology complexes — in three regions: the Seomjingang line, centered on Gwangju (Gwangyang–Suncheon–Yeosu); the Yeongsangang line, the Big Mokpo area (Naju, Yeongampo, Muan, Haenam, Yeongam, and Jindo); and the Geum River estuary (Gunsan–Janghang). I also planned to develop Yeosu, Mokpo, and Gunsan into science- and technology-based port cities, “Techno-Ports.”

Furthermore, I envisioned Gwangju not only as a techno-pole but also as a cultura-pole. To make this possible, I believed that both the population and the area of Gwangju needed to be expanded. In 1986, Gwangju absorbed Songjeong-ri and the surrounding areas and was promoted to a metropolitan city following the direction I had envisioned. I also proposed to Mayor CHOI In-ki in 1988 a long-term comprehensive development plan covering downtown Gwangju, Songjeong-ri, the Sangmu Military Base. The plan additionally included establishing Gwangju Science Town, while the existing provincial government administrative site was to be transformed into a new cultural and arts complex.

Thanks to Mayor CHOI’s decisive action and leadership, Gwangju, which had once been a city stained with blood, was able to rise again as the “City of Light.”

KIM Kwangsoo: I believe that Gwangju’s potential has not yet been fully realized. From now on, I am confident that Gwangju will shine even brighter than before.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I hope so, too. The new Gwangju Science Town would also be connected to the Daegu Science Town and the Daejeon Science Town, forming the nation’s major Research Triangle. You may be well aware of how the Research Triangle functions as a center of scientific innovation and excellence.



▲ New Gwangju Metropolitan Plan

The Painful Lesson of the “Big Mokpo” Plan

Big Mokpo, Bigger Future

KIM Kwangsoo: When explaining the West Coast Techno Valley, you used the name “Big Mokpo” to refer to a combination of several cities and counties, including Naju, Yeongsanpo, Muan, Haenam, Yeongam, and Jindo. How did the concept of “Big Mokpo” come about?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It was created based on the concept of “national territory.” When people refer to the spatial size of a country, they usually consider only its land area, but this is an incomplete standard because it does not include the territorial waters. The spatial extent of a country should be assessed based on the national territory that includes both land and maritime areas, and national policies should be formulated accordingly.

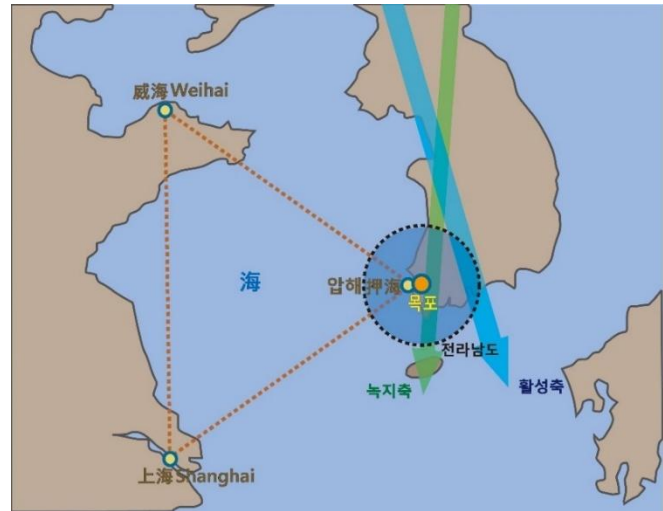
The land area of the Korean Peninsula is only 220,000 square kilometers, but the national territory, including maritime areas, amounts to 700,000 square kilometers. This means that the sea accounts for 480,000 square kilometers. While North Korea’s land area (120,000 square kilometers) is larger than South Korea’s (100,000 square kilometers), South Korea has a larger maritime area (350,000 square kilometers) compared to North Korea (130,000 square kilometers). Using the concept of national territory, it becomes clear that South Korea has a geopolitical and geoeconomic advantage over North Korea in terms of trade with foreign countries.

Now, let us turn our attention to Jeollanam-do, where Mokpo is located. Three-quarters of Jeollanam-do is covered by sea, and one-quarter by land. Considering both land and sea together, the Mokpo area becomes the center of Jeollanam-do. In order for the Mokpo area to grow into a major port city and a new provincial capital, I decided to adopt the name “Big Mokpo” by combining nearby counties such as Muan, Yeongam, Haenam, and Naju City. Many people have overlooked this fact and misunderstood my intention to develop Jeollanam-do and Gwangju simultaneously.

KIM Kwangsoo: In short, you considered not only Mokpo itself but also the surrounding areas as part of Big Mokpo.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I believed that Big Mokpo had the potential to develop into a hub of maritime trade in Northeast Asia. My argument is supported by the following three points:

1. It is a port city suitable as a gateway for exchanges with China, as it is within 400 nautical miles (740 kilometers) of major Chinese cities such as Shanghai, Dalian, Qingdao, and Weihai.
2. It is at the crossroads of the Southern Coastal Economic Belt (Busan–Jinju–Gwangyang–Mokpo) and the Yellow Sea–West Coast Axis (Mokpo–Gwangju–Gunsan–Jeonju–Incheon–Sinuiju), positioning it to become a hub for the exchange of goods in Northeast Asia.
3. It is one of the four major regions with high potential to develop into an international city in the event of Korean unification: the Mokpo area in the southwest, the Busan area in the southeast, the Sinuiju area in the northwest, and the Rajin area in the northeast.



The Reason Why the Jeonnam Provincial Office Moved to Muan

KIM Kwangsoo: What did you do to realize Mokpo's potential?

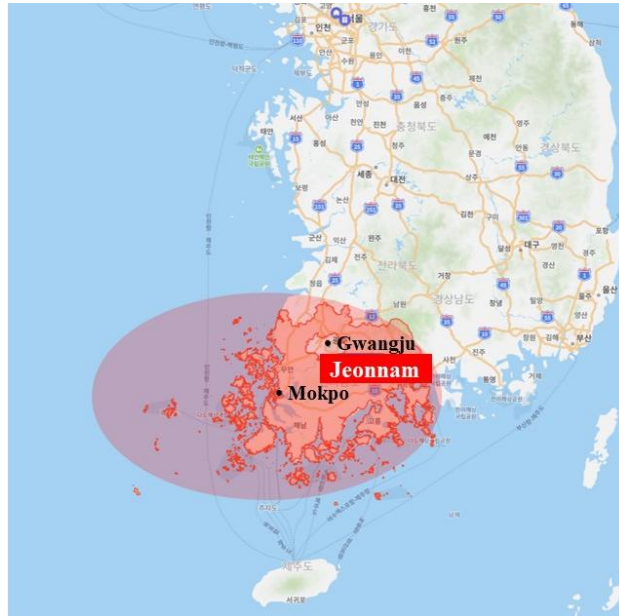
KWAAK YoungHoon: I suggested relocating the Jeonnam Provincial Office to the Big Mokpo City area. It was 1988, and despite being busy preparing for the Seoul Olympics, I took the time to create a Big Mokpo city development plan, which led to the creation of the new Hadang-Okam Districts and the Namak New Town.

KIM Kwangsoo: When you insisted on integrating administrative districts into Big Mokpo and relocating the Jeonnam Provincial Office, I imagine many people must have been puzzled. It also seems that the citizens of Gwangju, where the Jeonnam Provincial Office was originally located, strongly resisted the idea.

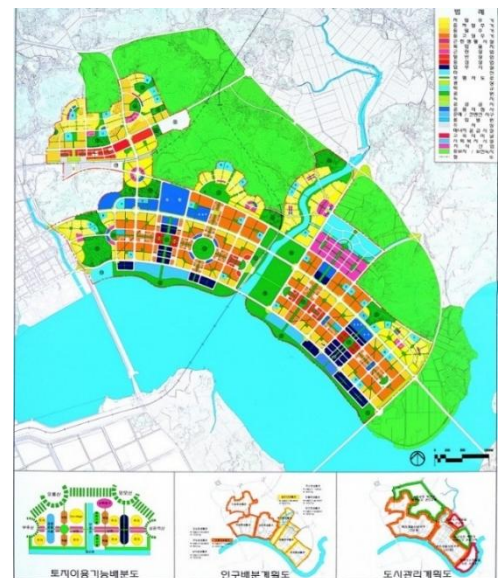
KWAAK YoungHoon: As usual, I got a lot of criticism at that time. Some Gwangju citizens even held a rally in which they made dolls of the officials involved in the relocation projects and conducted a burning ceremony, claiming, “They are trying to take away the democratic center and weaken Gwangju.” However, I was able to persuade Presidents KIM Young-sam and KIM Dae-jung, and the Jeonnam Provincial Government Office was relocated to Big Mokpo in 2005.

KIM Kwangsoo: After all, without the consent and cooperation of local residents, it is difficult to carry out administrative district mergers or relocate provincial government offices.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, it is. As I planned and pushed forward the Big Mokpo Project, I came to deeply understand that people cannot be convinced by the policy's merits or expected outcomes alone. I realized that emotions are just as important as logic in persuading others.



▲ Location of Jeollanam-do and the Cities of Gwangju and Mokpo



▲ Hadang-Okam Districts and Namak New Town Project

Saemangeum Comprehensive Development Plan: The Unfinished Project

KIM Kwangsoo: The Saemangeum Comprehensive Development Project, for which you were in charge of the master plan in 1997, was a remarkable project. It was the largest construction project since the time of Dangun, the legendary founding father of Korea, and was significant enough to reshape the map of Korea.

KWAAK YoungHoon: You're right. By building 33 km of seawalls connecting the coastal waters of Gunsan, Gimje, and Buan in Jeollabuk-do (North Jeolla Province), 291 square kilometers of reclaimed land and 118 square kilometers of the Saemangeum Lake were created. The new land, equivalent to 140 times the size of Yeouido Island in the center of Seoul, was developed.

KIM Kwangsoo: How did the Saemangeum project begin?

KWAAK YoungHoon: While presenting the National Master Vision and Implementation Plan (MVIP), numerous development projects were suggested. For example, Jeollabuk-do considered relocating its provincial government office, following the plan for Jeollanam-do. Jeonju City was envisioned as the national gastronomical capital and a center for traditional music, while the Gyodong District was preserved as a village of traditional hanok houses.

In addition, the Saemangeum Project, a large visionary initiative, was planned. Its name, "Saemangeum," reflects the goal of creating new land by combining the Mangyeong ("Man") and Geum ("Geum") Plains. The concept emerged in the early 1980s. It began when the national government announced a development plan for the Mangyeong River area, aiming to secure land, establish an agricultural and fishery industrial complex, and expand transportation infrastructure. There were four main directions in my master plan:

1. Securing production and trade bases in the Yellow Sea Region for the 21st century
2. Promoting balanced regional development and improving land-use efficiency
3. Contributing to the establishment of a future-oriented agricultural foundation
4. Developing an eco-friendly canal city with cultural and tourism functions

I was greatly inspired by the reclaimed city of Almere in the Netherlands — a new city built on an island within embankments in the open sea outside Amsterdam. I also carefully studied and used as a reference from Venice in Italy and Suzhou in China.

KIM Kwangsoo: Considering the scale of the project, I'm sure you faced numerous difficulties.

KWAAK YoungHoon: As you know, difficulties always arise.

Unfortunately, in this case, it remains an unfinished project. After beginning the preliminary work in 1991, the project took 19 years to complete, finishing in 2010. My concept was to construct a canal

KIM Kwangsoo: Given that you started with such a big dream, I can imagine that you must have had many regrets.

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Jeju Island Sightseeing Course Developed ‘Using’ the Presidents

Jeju Island Comprehensive Development Plan: An Expansion of the 620 Project

KIM Kwangsoo: Now, after discussing Jeollanam-do and Jeollabuk-do, we finally turn to the planning of Jeju Island.

KWAAK YoungHoon: To explain the Jeju Island Comprehensive Development Plan, we need to go back to the so-called 620 Project.

KIM Kwangsoo: You’re talking about the National Comprehensive Development Plan for emergencies that you were secretly called in for and instructed on alone by Dr. KIM Jae-ik?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, that’s right. Confidentiality was required at the time due to concerns over land speculation. The first task, in particular, was to acquire a vast area of land to build the Octagon Building for the Department of National Defense and other related facilities.

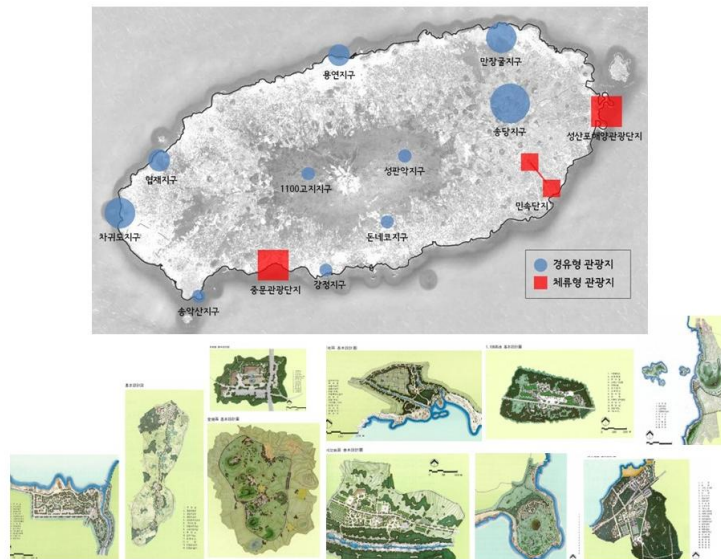
Dr. KIM asked me to prepare national development plans, and I included the Jeju Island Regional Comprehensive Plan. KWAAK Environmental Studies & Policy Research Institute (KWAAK E.S.P.R.I.) and the Korea Research Institute for Human Settlements (KRIHS) jointly developed the Jeju Island Comprehensive Development Plan in 1982.

By evaluating the tourism resources of Jeju Island, ten districts — Yongyeon, Manjanggul, Songdang, Seongpanak, Donnaeko, Gangjeong, the 1100 Altitude Wetland, Songaksan, Chagwido, and Hyeopjae — were selected to create a master plan for each.

KIM Kwangsoo: It overlaps with *Dullegil*, a trail that tourists enjoy these days.

KWAAK YoungHoon: You are right. Dullegil refers to the continuous coastal pedestrian path that circles around Jeju Island. I believed that Jeju Island should be a jewel of Korean tourism, and Dullegil was intended to be one of the first planning frameworks to implement as early as possible. I was inspired by Cape Cod in Massachusetts, USA, where all coastal areas are publicly accessible, allowing the waterfront to remain continuous and unobstructed.

Additionally, the Jungmun Resort New Development was introduced as part of the 620 Project. As you know, President of the USSR, Gorbachev visited Jungmun Resort town for a historic peace talk with President ROH Tae-woo. Thanks to the 620 Project framework, Jeju Island was included and has now become the most popular tourist destination in Korea, taking advantage of its uniquely clean natural scenery and warm climate. The 620 Project was not only for national defense purposes but also included plans for tourism and economic development.



▲ Jeju Island Comprehensive Development Plan: The Basis for *Dullegil*



▲ The Dullegil of Jeju Island

Ranking	Operating Area	Users (Persons)
1	Gimpo(Seoul) - Jeju	13,460,306
2	Melbourne - Sydney	9,090,941
3	Haneda(Tokyo) - Sapporo	8,726,502
4	Haneda(Tokyo) - Fukuoka	7,864,000
5	Mumbai - Delhi	7,129,943
6	Beijing - Shanghai	6,833,684
7	Hanoi - Ho Chi Minh	6,769,823
8	Hong Kong - Taiwan	6,719,030
9	Jakarta - Surabaya	5,271,304
10	Haneda(Tokyo) - Okinawa	5,269,481

▲ World's Busiest Air Routes in 2017 (Official Airline Guide, 2018)

Beyond the Constraints of Practical Politics

KIM Kwangsoo: From Daejeon to Jeju Island, the impact of the 620 Project appears to have been enormous.

It must have been challenging for you to undertake such a major project under the CHUN Doo-hwan government. I recall what you said earlier — that you did your best for the future of the country, not for any specific regime or administration.

KWAAK YoungHoon: When you work within a specific administration, you become part of that government. Then, whenever the administration changes, you are unable to continue ongoing projects. One must remain independent of everyday politics to avoid being drawn into political turbulence when governments change. We need to go beyond partisan divisions in order to bring a large-scale, long-term project to a successful completion.

As you may have realized by now, I was firmly determined to devote my life to making Korea a nation as developed and prosperous as the United States. After witnessing the suffering of Koreans during and after the Korean War, my elder brother and I would ask ourselves what we could do for Korea's future, and we promised to dedicate ourselves to Korea's rapid development.

Two years after making this resolution, in 1960, we were profoundly inspired by a message from President J. F. Kennedy. In his inauguration speech, President Kennedy said, "Ask not what your country can do for you — ask what you can do for your country."

KIM Kwangsoo: Everybody knows that speech. Then you had an even more unbelievable experience — I heard that you personally met President Kennedy at the White House in Washington in 1962. That is truly an incredible story. How could such a thing have happened?

KWAAK YoungHoon: I really don't know — only God knows. As I mentioned earlier, I joined the Operation VISTA program as one of the Korean delegates. Each group of 12 delegates was assigned a program to travel to three American cities and stay with three American families for three weeks. At the end of the three weeks, all delegates gathered in Washington, D.C. It was then that we learned there was a confidential program to meet President Kennedy at the White House.

KIM Kwangsoo: Wow! What was he like?

KWAAK YoungHoon: He was very statuesque and handsome. He greeted and looked at each delegate individually. When it was my turn, he looked at me and asked, "Are you from Korea?" I remember he emphasized the importance of youthful enthusiasm in creating a better world.

KIM Kwangsoo: So, you must have been very impressed by him. Now I understand better why you were so determined in Korea's nation-building.

By the way, based on your career history, I get the impression that you primarily worked under conservative governments. I think this also reflects the fact that conservative administrations have held power for a significant part of our modern history.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I can see why you might think that. When I returned from America in mid-1975, it was not under a conservative president, but a military dictatorship.

Let me share an old story from the time of the PARK Chung-hee regime. One day, lawyer LEE Tae-Young came to my office and yelled at me, “How could you work for PARK Chung-hee? Why are you helping the dictator?”

I was startled because we had known each other for a long time, and she knew very well what kind of person I was. I answered with a smile, “I am not working for President Park, but rather I am using him. I could not wait or waste time, as I needed to prepare for the Seoul Olympic Games, build the Seoul Subway, preserve and develop the Han River, construct the Olympic Main Stadium, and so on.”

Lawyer LEE immediately responded aloud, “I lost! You are right. I misunderstood you.”

I believe I have made good use of the authority of the eight presidents over the past 50 years, always trying to remain free from practical politics.

KIM Kwangsoo: Incidentally, as a talented individual whose abilities are widely recognized, you must have received numerous offers for key government positions, regardless of which administration was in power.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I received several offers, but I turned them all down. When the government called, I told them that I would take the people’s small boat rather than their aircraft carrier. My political credo has always been: “Governance — In the People, With the People, For the People!”



▲ Meeting with John F. Kennedy in the White House Rose Garden



▲ Operation VISTA, 1962

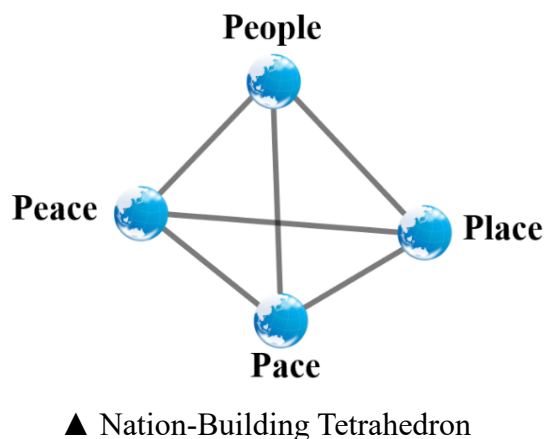
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Knocking on the Door of Hope : The DMZ and North Korea Projects

The DMZ: A Starting Point for Peace Between South and North Korea

May There Be No More Wars on This Land

KIM Kwangsoo: Through our conversation, I was able to identify the keywords that run through your work and life: “nation building,” “people,” “place,” “pace,” and “peace.” Given that the painful memories of the Korean War are deeply engraved in your hearts, it seems that you have been eager to develop Korea rapidly and have longed for peaceful reunification on the Korean Peninsula.



KWAAK YoungHoon: You’ve identified the keywords very well. Peace on the Korean Peninsula and the reunification of North and South Korea are my lifelong wishes. Keep “Pace,” achieve “Peace,” and build “Place” for the Korean “People” (inscribed on the DMZ Stone Monument, erected in the Swiss NNSC compound in 1980).

Do you remember the incident when the U.S. intelligence-gathering ship was captured in the North Korean port of Wonsan?

KIM Kwangsoo: Are you referring to the hijacking of the USS Pueblo in January 1968? It was a shocking incident that occurred just two days after the Blue House raid, when North Korean special forces infiltrated near the Blue House with the aim of assassinating President PARK Chung-hee on January 21. In the middle of Seoul, an armed communist guerrilla was captured, and in the East Sea, the North Korean army was holding a U.S. naval vessel. It was an atmosphere so tense that war could have broken out at any moment.

But why are you suddenly bringing up the Pueblo incident? Weren’t you at MIT at the time?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I was. At that time, public opinion in the United States was overwhelmingly in favor of dropping a nuclear bomb on the Korean Peninsula. I was determined to prevent a nuclear war by any means. So, I reached out to the Director of the American Red Cross and asked for his help in arranging a meeting with the Secretary of State. Thanks to his efforts, I had the opportunity to speak briefly with Secretary Rusk at the State Department in Washington.

I said, “I know from the newspapers that many Americans want to drop nuclear bombs on Pyongyang and Wonsan. Of course, I do not believe the U.S. government would make such a reckless decision. But as a Korean, I was deeply concerned, and that is why I came here from Boston. I cannot bear to imagine another war breaking out on the Korean Peninsula.”

Secretary Rusk replied with a gentle smile, “Young man, go back to Boston. We will not use the bomb. Don’t worry. Study hard for the future of Korea.”

In the end, the U.S. government did not drop a nuclear bomb on North Korea, and the Pueblo incident was resolved without major clashes as the United States and North Korea reached a negotiated settlement later that year.



▲ Report on the Hijacking of the Pueblo



▲ Dr. KWAAK YoungHoon in His Twenties: An Appeal to Secretary of State Rusk to Prevent War on the Korean Peninsula

KIM Kwangsoo: It's very fearless of you to go to the U.S. Secretary of State as an international student and ask him not to start a war.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Fearless? Nothing to fear. I wanted to prevent a nuclear war at all costs. I would act the same even if the situation were repeated.

KIM Kwangsoo: If it's to accomplish your goals, you would go as far as the bottom of the ocean.

KWAAK YoungHoon: For a just cause, I would even meet the Grim Reaper.

KIM Kwangsoo: (Laughs) You are very bold.

DMZ Peace City: A Life-long Dream

KIM Kwangsoo: Now, let's go back to the story of your childhood dream. You said you decided to build a peace city in the DMZ when you were in middle school, right?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes. I thought, "If it is difficult for South and North Korea to reunite immediately, why not establish a model place where peace is guaranteed and people — especially separated families — can live in harmony?" I had held on to that dream for far too long, and in 1988, I finally had the opportunity to take a step toward realizing my vision of establishing the DMZ Peace City.

KIM Kwangsoo: Since you first conceived the DMZ Peace City in 1958, this opportunity came exactly 30 years later. What was it?

KWAAK YoungHoon: In 1988, I requested Dr. LEE Hong-gu, the Minister of Reunification, to provide funding to develop a plan for the entire DMZ. Essentially, I had presented a schematic policy plan to build a "Peace Park" and a total of three "Peace Cities" in the western, central, and eastern areas along the DMZ. This was actually a visionary project, conceived before 1988, intended to encourage North Korea's participation ahead of the Seoul Olympics.

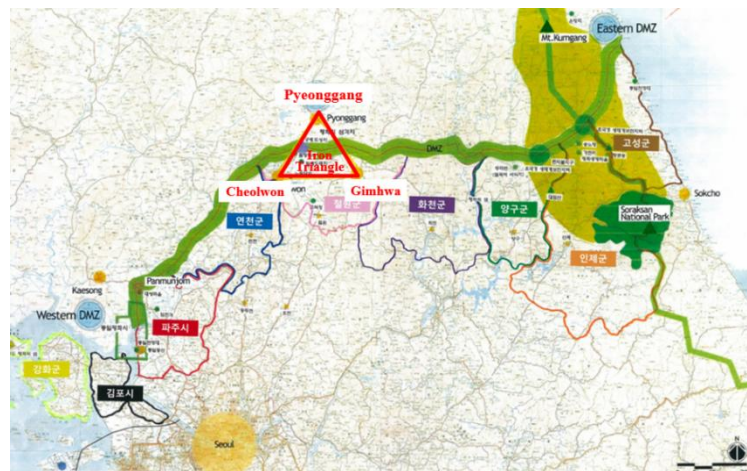
I made a bird's-eye-view sketch of the Cheolui Samgakji (Iron Triangle Battlefield: Cheolwon–Pyeonggang–Gimhwa) and a basic plan for "Peace City" around the eastern part of the DMZ, where the Imjin and Han Rivers meet, as well as a "World Peace Park" encompassing Mt. Geumgangsan in North Korea and the Mt. Seoraksan region in South Korea.

With this conceptual framework, on October 19, 1988, at the UN General Assembly, President ROH Tae-woo delivered a speech saying, "We can build a Peace City near the DMZ." Of course, before President ROH's departure to New York, I had meetings with Minister of Foreign Affairs CHOI Gwang-soo and Minister of Reunification LEE Hong-gu. In a way, it was the first time I showcased my dream to build the DMZ Peace City.

KIM Kwangsoo: It seems that the DMZ Peace City plan was officially announced at the UN General Assembly. You must have been impressed.

KWAAK YoungHoon: After that, in 1990, I wrote a report entitled *A Basic Plan for Regional Development for the Establishment of a Peace Zone between North and South Korea* and submitted it to the Ministry of Unification. Overseas media also showed interest in the DMZ plan. In 1990, *The Far Eastern Economic Review* introduced my concept of the DMZ Peace City under the title “Gentrifying the DMZ,” and in 1995, the French weekly *Courrier International* featured the DMZ Peace City as one of the frontier cities of the 21st century.

I also had a meeting at the UN Headquarters in May 2003, where I briefed Maurice Strong, Under-Secretary-General of the United Nations, and Natun, Director of the Northeast Asia Regional Department of the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), on the DMZ Peace City. Gratefully, Mr. Strong supported my initiative, seeking the North Korean government’s opinion on the DMZ Peace City and sending out an Emergency Appeal for DMZ Peace City Construction to the world. Unfortunately, however, the DMZ Peace City did not see much progress afterward.



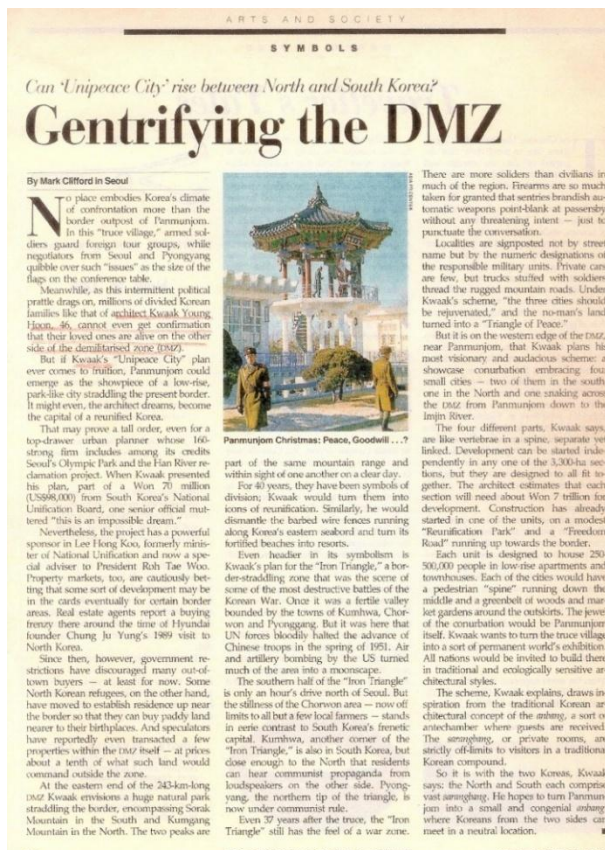
▲ DMZ Peace Park and the Eastern, Central, and Western Peace Cities



▲ An Article in *Courrier International* (1995):
DMZ Peace City as One of the 21st Century Frontier Cities

KIM Kwangsoo: It would have been nice if people's interest in the DMZ Peace City had continued.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes. Still, there were people, like Under-Secretary-General Maurice Strong, who listened to my voice, which made me feel that all hope was not lost. We became like brothers and met many times until his passing.



▲ *Far Eastern Economic Review* (1990)

▲ Letter to UN Secretary-General Kofi Annan (2001)

KIM Kwangsoo: Earlier, you said that a dream shared together is not just a dream, and that someday it will surely come true. The time has not yet arrived, but the DMZ Peace City will definitely be built.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, when that day comes, peace will also come to the Korean Peninsula.

A Herd of Cattle Crossing the DMZ

KIM Kwangsoo: As the vision of establishing the DMZ Peace City reflects, your words and actions have always been driven by a strong desire for peace. After the establishment of diplomatic relations



The World Citizens Organization

March 19, 2001

H.E. Kofi A. Annan

United Nations Secretary-General

New York, NY, The United States of America

Excellency,

The new millennium commenced last year with a historic summit meeting in Korea after 50 years of its separation. Yet the reality of separated families continues to exist on the Korean Peninsula -- a most blatant human rights violation -- and 10 million Koreans anxiously miss and long for their family members separated during the Korean War. Further, most of the first generation people have already reached an old age, which makes it more urgent from a humanitarian point of view to provide them with opportunities of reunions at the earliest date possible. Although the Red Cross of the two Koreas have finally succeeded in arranging unions of separated family members in small numbers both in Seoul and Pyongyang, most of them, separated once again after a few days of reunion, do not expect to see each other again in their lifetime.

Many Koreans have thus pointed out the necessity of permanent reunion centers that can accommodate more frequent meetings between the separated family members.

In this regard, the World Citizens Organization would like to establish a 'Peace Town' in the DMZ jointly with the two Koreas, and with international support, that will not only serve as a place for Korean reunions but, taking one step further, as a place for common living in realization of the virtues of the civilization of a global village.

We consider that the best site for such World 'Peace Town' is in the DMZ of the Chollwon area, located midway between Panmunjom and Mt. Kumgang, and the Gangwon Provincial Government (of ROK) is thoroughly studying the feasibility together with us. The Chollwon area is where the Seoul-Wonsan Railway once passed, which is currently considered for renovation and to be linked to the Trans-Siberian Railway.

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between Korea and China in 1992, I heard that you sent 100 cattle to Koreans living in China. How did that happen?

KWAAK YoungHoon: I did not send the cattle directly. Instead, I sent 5 million won, equivalent to the price of 100 cattle, to Janghang Village, about an hour and a half from Yanji in Jilin Province. At that time, the village had no source of income other than corn farming.



▲ Visit to Janghang Village and Welcome Ceremony (1998)

KIM Kwangsoo: It reminds me of Hyundai Group's honorary chairman, CHUNG Ju-yung, crossing the DMZ with a herd of 1,001 cows. Didn't Chairman CHUNG take inspiration from you sending 100 cows to Janghang?

KWAAK YoungHoon: (Laughs) When I met Chairman CHUNG, I told him the anecdote about donating 100 cows to Janghang Village, and he said with his characteristic smile, "Dr. KWAAK is an idealist." I replied, "No. I am an idealistic realist. I am also a realistic idealist." Upon hearing this, he smiled and said, "Oh, okay. You are complicated and simple."

Then, in 1998, Chairman CHUNG crossed the DMZ, the ceasefire line, with a total of 1,001 cows — 500 cows during his first visit to North Korea in June, and 501 cows during his second visit in October.

KIM Kwangsoo: I remember hearing Chairman CHUNG from North Korea say that when he was 17, he stole 70 won from his father — the money from selling a cow — and went to Seoul. So, he added one more cow to the 1,000 to repay that debt.

KWAAK YoungHoon: One was the principal and 1,000 was the interest. That's how it worked out.

Thanks to Chairman CHUNG's herd visit to North Korea, an agreement was reached in 1988 with North Korea to develop Mt. Kungangsan, the Diamond Mountains, in the eastern part of the DMZ World Peace City. Come to think of it, my DMZ Peace City plan hasn't been entirely unrealized.

Tumen River and Baekdu Mountain Development Projects:

Tumen River Area Development Programme (TRADP): Dreaming of a UN City, District of Respect and Trust (DRT)

KIM Kwangsoo: Your development plan for the Korean Peninsula also includes the Tumen River, which borders North Korea. Although the Tumen River estuary is an important transportation hub connecting Eurasia and the East Sea Region, it still feels very distant to us. How did you become involved in the Tumen River Area Development Programme (TRADP)?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Immediately after the highly successful 1988 Seoul Olympics, when both the “Iron Curtain” and the “Bamboo Curtain” were lifted, the vision for the TRADP began to be discussed among scholars and global observers. As the original conceptualizer and master planner of the Seoul Olympics, my elder brother and I considered how we might leverage the global event to achieve some concrete results. My brother spoke with Mr. KIM Inho, Director General of the Economic Planning Board (EPB). He was my brother’s high school classmate and a brilliant economic planner. I believe that my brother initiated the idea of developing the Tumen River area, and I became involved early on as a physical planner.

Discussion on the development of the Tumen River estuary, where the borders of China, North Korea, and Russia meet, had become a hot topic, and UNDP was considering it as an immediate target project in Northeast Asia. UNDP also convened a meeting in Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, in July 1991, where China, South Korea, North Korea, and Mongolia agreed to develop the Tumen River basin. As a bordering country, Russia initially participated as an associate member but became a full member in October 1992. Japan remained an observer because it preferred bilateral cooperation, and a Japanese expert noted that they wished to continue several bilateral relations.

At the Pyongyang Preliminary Meeting in October 1992, I traveled to Pyongyang, North Korea, where we discussed what should be done during the pre-investment stage over the next 18 months and decided to establish the Planning and Management Committee (PMC) as an intergovernmental consultative commission to continue reviewing TRADP’s progress. I attended the Pyongyang meeting as UNDP chief architect/planner and senior advisor, for a nominal salary of one dollar per year. I was happy to serve in advancing peaceful development in the Tumen River Delta area. As the then leader of North Korea, KIM Il-sung was very eager to develop the region, and his son KIM Jong-il expressed a desire to meet with me. I was prepared to meet him, but the South Korean delegate told me not to, citing prohibitions under South Korean law. Whew...

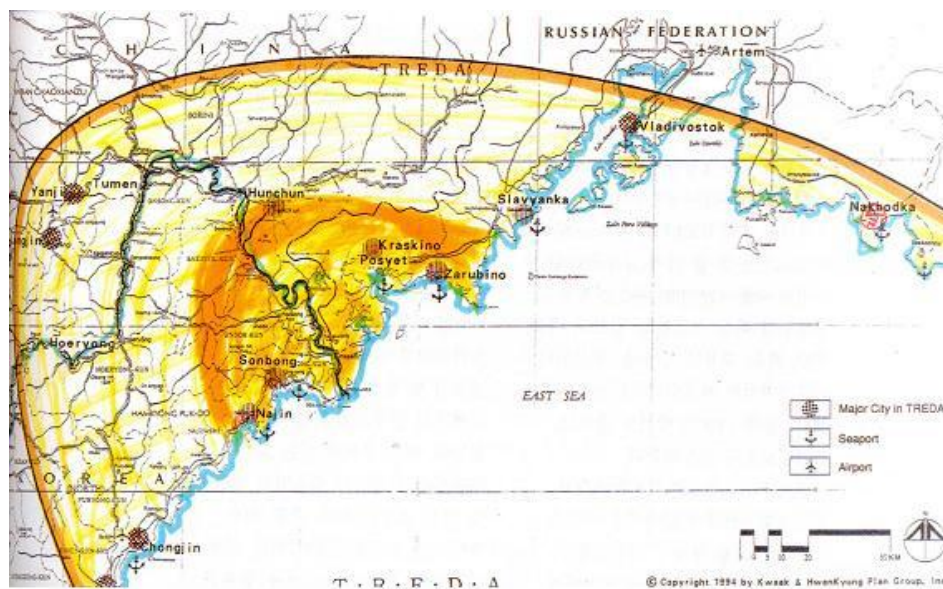


▲ Pyongyang Preliminary Meeting, 1992

KIM Kwangsoo: I think you made an ambitious proposal.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I proposed building a UN city, District of Respect and Trust (DRT), in a region called Kyungshin, which literally means “respect” and “trust.” The site was located in the middle of the Tumen River Small Delta Economic Zone, which was designated by North Korea in 1992. I thought that if China, North Korea, and Russia lent the border land to the United Nations to prepare the site and create a city without nationality, it could grow into a major trade center, even surpassing Vladivostok.

However, the Vice-Governor of Primorsky Krai spoke to me privately in his office in Vladivostok, asking that the area not be developed. He said that once the area develops, too many Chinese would come. He also said that the Ekspeditsii Estuary is environmentally fragile and needs to be fully preserved.



▲ Tumen River Area Development Programme (TRADP)

Project for the Environmentally Friendly Development of Mt. Baekdusan and Mt. Changbaisan

KWAAK YoungHoon: The TRADP did not make much progress, but I believed it was critical to preserve Mt. Baekdusan before it was unduly developed. I prepared a UNDP report on the environmentally friendly development and preservation of Mt. Baekdusan.

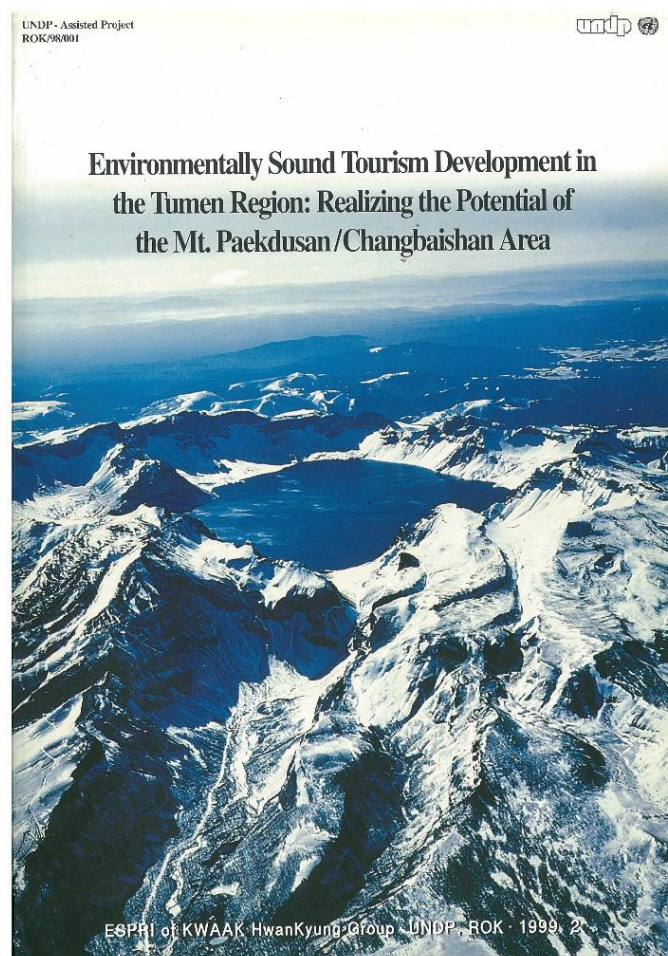
In 1998, I attended the UNDP meeting for the “Project for the Environmentally Friendly Development of Mt. Baekdusan and Mt. Changbaisan.” After a discussion with the Chinese representative over the name — “Mt. Baekdusan” or “Mt. Changbaisan” — we decided to use both names.

KIM Kwangsoo: You fought for the pride of the country.

KWAAK YoungHoon: It had nothing to do with pride. But I realized that half of Mt. Baekdusan had been designated as Chinese territory. I was told that KIM Il-sung and ZHOU Enlai had made the agreement. Deciding the name of the mountain turned out to be even more difficult than coming up with a comprehensive tourism plan. (laughs)



▲ UNDP Meeting in Changchun, China, 1998



▲ Report on Mt. Baekdusan and Mt. Changbaisan

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Urban Environmental Design : Balancing Ideals and Reality

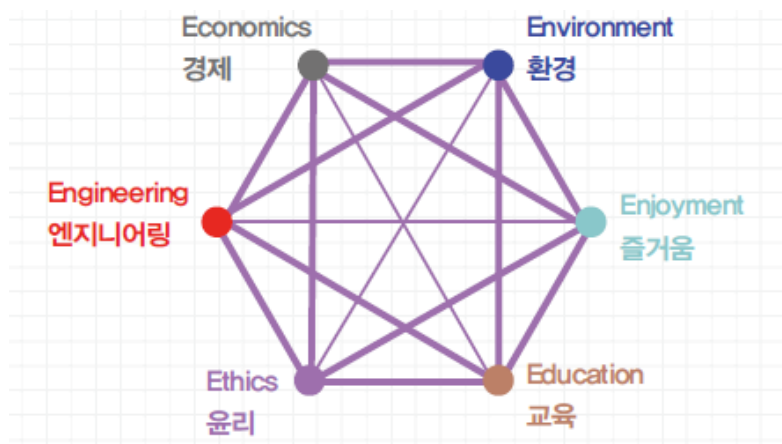
Philosophy and Strategy Required for Urban Planners

Human-Centered Considerations in Urban Development

KIM Kwangsoo: Listening to your words, I realized that before creating an urban environment, it is necessary to establish the right humanistic mindset in the minds of those who draw the master plan. This is because urban environment design and architecture are high-level tasks that require consideration not only of the region's topography but also of all factors such as society, culture, politics, economy, and the education system.

With what kind of humanistic spirit do you think an urban environment should be designed?

KWAAK YoungHoon: When creating an urban environment, most projects prioritize economic goals, but that shouldn't be the case. In addition to the economy, we need to consider aspects that can include and enhance the environment, education, ethics, engineering, and the enjoyment of life. I call these six goals the “6E” factors — Economy, Environment, Education, Ethics, Engineering, and Enjoyment.



▲ Elements to Pursue in Urban Design (1E + 5E)

With the 6E factors in mind, we should follow the five steps below to build the city:

1. Schematics
2. Design Development
3. Working Drawing / Construction Document
4. Construction and Supervision
5. Management and Feedback

It involves developing a rough concept of the city you want to create, materializing that concept through schematic drawings, producing the necessary construction documents, proceeding with construction, and supervising the site.

I believe we should include a fifth step — “management.” To me, “management” means anticipating what needs to be prepared for each process to proceed smoothly, documenting the lessons and insights learned during each stage, and then applying that knowledge in future projects.

In the 1970s, when I began working as an architect, the concept of urban environment design and architecture was not yet established in Korea. Without proper conception and supervision, projects moved directly from schematic drawings to construction, and that was the end. This approach omitted the essential “6E” thinking at the initial conception stage. They jumped straight into construction documentation and execution. In a sense, the design process had no “head” — the schematic stage — and no “feet” — the supervision stage. It consisted only of the “torso” of the five-step process.

Although the supervision system, which had been largely ineffective, was somehow revitalized, it was difficult to institutionalize the fundamental planning based on a humanistic approach.

City environment architecture and design represent the crystallization of human civilization, fusing geography, society, culture, engineering, and aesthetics. Civilizations create cities, and cities, in turn, embody civilizations. The very structure of a city is a form of civilization, while the city itself is an organism — a constantly evolving place of life. It is a place of work, of learning, of play, and of shelter. Therefore, in designing a city, it is fundamentally necessary to adapt to the local environment, and for this, a humanistic mindset is essential.

KIM Kwangsoo: Just a moment, please. The word “environment” is a bit unclear. Could you explain more specifically what you mean by “environment”?

KWAAK YoungHoon: When we hear the word “environment,” we often think only of the “natural environment,” but that’s not the case. The environment is everything around us.

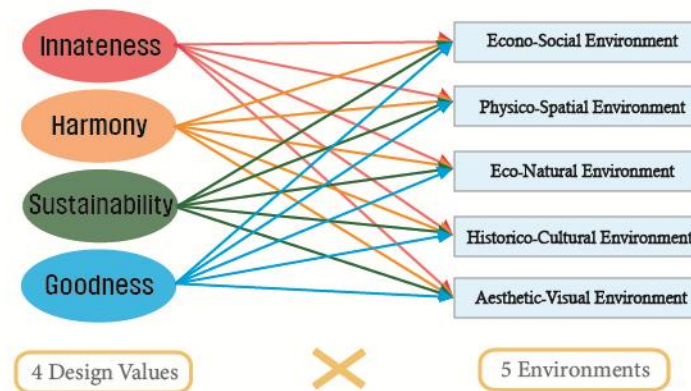
I will tell you a small anecdote. In 1967, I attended a lecture by Dr. Buckminster Fuller at the MIT Kresge Auditorium. I asked him, “Dr. Fuller, what is your concept of environment?” He told the audience, “Your environment is everything except yourself. So, the architect I. M. Pei, who is sitting next to you, is included in your environment.” He also commented that there is no place on Earth that is exactly the same, and that every city should be built differently. Since then, I created my own five environment categories to keep in mind when designing any project:

1. The Physical and Spatial Environment
2. The Economic and Social Environment
3. The Aesthetic and Visual Environment
4. The Historical and Cultural Environment
5. The Natural and Ecological Environment, including Forests, Rivers, and Mountains

In addition to the five environments above, the following four humanistic values should be considered:

1. Innateness: Unique characteristics
2. Harmony: Alignment with the surrounding environment
3. Sustainability: Durability and longevity
4. Goodness: Morality

When the four humanistic values are applied to each of the five environmental categories, the humanistic considerations that need to permeate the urban design and policy planning process result in a total of 4×5 , or 20 in total.



▲ 20 Humanistic Considerations for Urban Design and Policy Planning

KIM Kwangsoo: It must be a formidable task to consider all 20 humanistic values whenever designing a city or a building. I believe that university architecture students should study the humanities, including ethics.

It reminds me of a poem by Longfellow:

*“In the elder days of Art,
Builders wrought with greatest care
Each minute and unseen part;
For the Gods see everywhere.”*

In the past, carpenters were conscious of the eyes of the gods, paying meticulous attention even to places invisible to human eyes. But what should one do if the gods are not watching? Nevertheless, one must still dedicate oneself fully. One must follow one’s conscience. This inevitably involves endless struggle. It seems that you are expressing, in your own words, the carpenter’s duty that Longfellow sang about.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Actually, the humanities should be studied not only by architecture students but by all students. The humanities help us reflect on human morality and dignity.

KIM Kwangsoo: Currently, South Korea is economically developed. Your Master Vision and Implementation Plan (MVIP), Long-Range Comprehensive Development (LRCD) Plan for the year 2000, and the Techno-Cultra Plan, along with their related strategies, in a way, became a clear blueprint for Korea’s rapid development. However, it seems that the mental and emotional well-being of the population has not kept pace with the economic growth. The suicide rates among both young and elderly people are the highest among so-called OECD countries.

Today, departments in the humanities and basic sciences are being removed from universities because they are considered “not helpful for employment or daily life.” In this way, Korea cannot become a truly developed country in the real sense of the term.

KWAAK YoungHoon: It is truly unfortunate. South Korea is ranked No. 6 in national power according to research and evaluations carried out by U.S. News & World Report. However, I experienced many difficulties while carrying out nation-building projects. I will not go into them now... perhaps later.

2022 The world's most powerful countries

A leader, Economically influential, Has strong exports, Politically influential,

Strong international alliances, Strong military

 United States 1 #1 in Power #4 in Best Countries Overall The United States of America is a North American nation that is the world's most dominant economic and military power. READ MORE	 United Kingdom 5 #5 in Power #8 in Best Countries Overall The United Kingdom is a highly developed nation that exerts considerable international economic, political, and cultural influence. READ MORE
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▲ Research Findings, *U.S. News & World Report*, 2022

Strategic Plan for Implementing the Vision

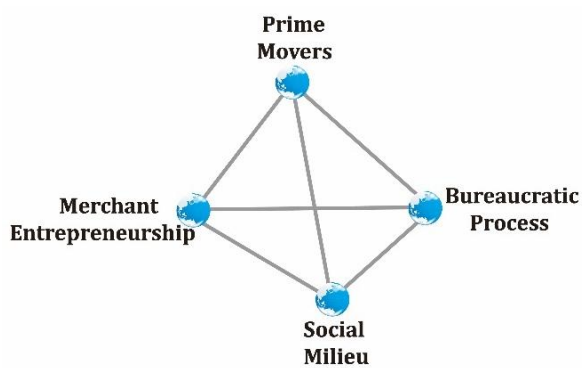
KIM Kwangsoo: Even if a project is conceived according to 6E goals and 20 humanistic values, it is all in vain if the plan cannot be put into practice. It seems that a concrete implementation strategy is required.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Of course. I used four strategies and interrelated them when implementing policies and plans for Korea's development. I learned this at Harvard University Graduate School in the late 1960s and early 1970s:

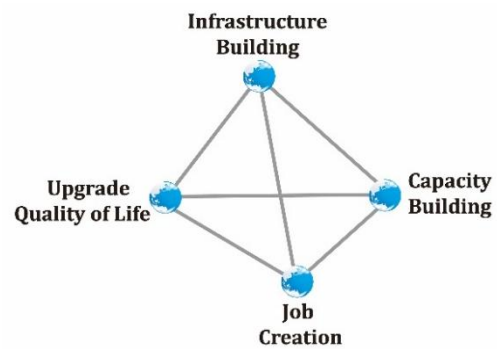
1. Prime Mover Model: Convince the top decision-maker of the legitimacy of the plan
2. Bureaucratic Process Model: Understand bureaucratic idiosyncrasies and processes
3. Social Atmosphere Model: Align with the prevailing spirit of the time
(e.g. the *Ppali Ppali* (“quickly, quickly”) spirit in 20 Century)

4. Entrepreneurial Spirit Model: Attract entrepreneurs by helping them recognize the business opportunities and encouraging a business-minded and risk-taking mindset

By taking at least these four factors into account to win the support of politicians, administrators, entrepreneurs, and ordinary citizens, the implementation of the plan gains momentum.



▲ Vision Implementation Strategies



▲ Multiplier Effects of Visioning

KIM Kwangsoo: If you want to realize a vision, you must first understand the psychology of the stakeholders.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes. In fact, this concept of policymaking and implementation existed even before the Harvard Kennedy School was founded in 1969. It is the “Policy Implementation Conceptual Framework,” developed jointly by Dean Richard Neustadt, Professor Graham Allison, Professor John Steinbruner, and myself.

In the case of South Korea, the advantage of this strategy is that things get done *Ppali Ppali*. Decision-makers and bureaucrats want to achieve as much as possible during their terms, so the faster a project progresses, the more satisfied they are. Businesspeople and citizens can also gain significant profits and benefits in a short time, so naturally they will actively cooperate.

KIM Kwangsoo: Are there any shortcomings?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Rushing or sprinting through a project in a short period of time often ignores the details and makes the work process very rough. Another issue — and perhaps the saddest — is that development and the conservation of nature and culture often collide. Past governments have consistently prioritized development over conservation. I fought with them with all my effort, but it was very difficult to win them over.

The Unfortunate Reality of Urban Architecture in South Korea

The Apartment Republic: The Era of Inhumane Cities

KWAAK YoungHoon: I'm very concerned about the Korean-style urban construction and residential model these days. We are building only high-rise apartment buildings without considering the surrounding nature, the existing city form, or the available space. Such high-rise buildings absolutely do not fit the human scale and completely ignore people's long-term quality of life. As a result, they are not sustainable. Many apartments are demolished and redeveloped in a very short period, sometimes even after just 30 years.

In Korea, the uniform appearance of apartments is a problem, but what is particularly concerning is the culture that evaluates a resident's social and economic status based on the size of their apartment.

KIM Kwangsoo: That's right. It makes people think, "I live in a 66-square-meter apartment, and that person, being more successful than me, lives in a 198-square-meter one."

KWAAK YoungHoon: In Korea, real estate has become a means of hoarding wealth, and construction companies prioritize making money above all else. Unfortunately, this is the reality. It was disastrous to build blocks of apartments that ignored the 20 humanistic values while raising the floor area ratio to solve the housing shortage. Politicians make numerous promises to build apartments on both green and farmland every election season. In this way, politicians, developers, and speculators work together, taking the lead in chaotic and unplanned development. If development is pursued solely for economic gain, it is bound to produce ugly and unsustainable cities.

However, an even bigger problem is that, since we build everything at once, we will have to demolish it all at once in about 50 years. Then, the culture that has accumulated in the buildings over a long time will also disappear. It's truly frightening.

Not long ago, I had a conversation with a European ambassador in Korea at his official residence. He said, "Whether you go to Daejeon or Daegu, the image of the city is exactly the same. There are no local characteristics. I think it's because they were developed quantitatively, without considering the environmental characteristics of the area at all. I heard that you planned the cities of Korea. What happened?"

Then the ambassador asked me to go see Aleppo. Aleppo is an ancient city in northern Syria that was recently destroyed during the Syrian Civil War. At first, I didn't understand what the ambassador meant. He led me to the bedroom on the second floor of the official residence and pointed out the window. Oh my goodness, what I saw outside the window was a battlefield. All the houses near the Seodaemun area were in ruins. This was the site where redevelopment into an apartment complex had been planned.

At that moment, I was reminded of the devastated fields I had seen during the Korean War. The ambassador was reminded of the ruined city of Aleppo when he looked out the window. He lamented why this couldn't have been stopped. I had nothing to say.

KIM Kwangsoo: It's even sadder that things like this are happening all over the country.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Living site is not a lifeless mass of Lego blocks that can be built and destroyed. Traces of people's sorrows and memories should not be arbitrarily removed. What makes European cities look beautiful is that they have a legacy of time. The people who live there have painted the house by themselves for a long time, and gradually repaired it, adding traces of time. No city becomes more beautiful without the passage of time.

In the medieval city of Siena, Italy, there is the Piazza del Campo, which was designed by Michelangelo. It is an open space surrounded by a building in the shape of a seashell. In Campo Square, the ground is slightly inclined. I wondered what it would be like in Korea. I thought the sloping ground would have been bulldozed and flattened.

I thought that the Namsan Town apartments, built on the eastern slope of Mt. Namsan in Seoul, could have become as beautiful as the hilly city of Siena. However, the entire area was leveled, and the Namsan Town apartments were built without regard for the hill at all. I don't think it's an exaggeration to say that "they were built recklessly." Some parts of Dasan-ro Street have become completely deprived of sunlight. In 1994, the Namsan Foreigners' Complex was demolished to restore the Namsan view, but an even larger and more monstrous complex was built in its place.



▲ The Tawdry Uniformity of Namsan Town Apartments

Preserve the Green Axis

KWAAK YoungHoon: *The Green Axis* and *the Vigor Axis*, which I first drew on the map of the entire Korean Peninsula, were intended to reinvigorate the harmony between the two and to permeate every human settlement design and development. The original intent of the plan was lost, and the Green Axis that should have been preserved was carelessly destroyed. This will become a heavy burden for the next generation.

KIM Kwangsoo: We should stop this and look further ahead, but it's frustrating.

KWAAK YoungHoon: On the Korean Peninsula, green areas are connected by the Baekdudaegan Mountain Range. From Mt. Baekdusan to Gaema Plateau, from Mt. Geumgangsan to Mt. Seoraksan,

from Mt. Odaesan to Mt. Taebaeksan, and from Mt. Jirisan to Mt. Wolchulsan, the Green Axis flows from North to the southern coast. The mountains and rivers must be preserved and any development should respect that.

Taking Seoul as an example, not only the Cheonggyecheon Stream but also the Manchocheon Stream must be restored as soon as possible. Also, the Jungnangcheon, Anyangcheon, Tancheon, and Susaekcheon Streams should all be revived. There is a hierarchy between the tributaries. I insisted to do national land development and urban planning by making good use of this hierarchy, but unfortunately my blueprint was damaged a lot.

If all the lines of the Baekdudaegan are properly utilized, people could walk from Mt. Wolchulsan in South Korea to Mt. Baekdusan in North Korea. Even in Seoul, doesn't everyone know that the natural environment is far superior to that of London, Tokyo, Paris, or New York? When you step outside, there are small hills nearby. Yet people continue to cut down those beautiful mountains, and even farmland is disappearing, being transformed into apartment complexes.



▲ Baekdudaegan: The Largest and Longest Mountain Range on the Korean Peninsula

KIM Kwangsoo: Listening to you, I came to see that building houses requires a macroscopic perspective.

KWAAK YoungHoon: That's right. A city is not merely a collection of buildings. Residents should not be confined within the city. They must be able to live in continuous interaction with the areas beyond it. Therefore, in order to build a city properly, one must look beyond the city itself, consider the entire country, and even take the world beyond the country into account.

This emphasizes the importance of a continuous environment. Why does the Korean word *woaju* (meaning universe) use the Chinese characters 宇 (woo) and 宙 (joo), both of which contain the "house" radical (the Chinese character component meaning "house")? Houses come together to form neighborhoods, neighborhoods form villages, and villages form cities. On average, half of a city's area is residential, while the other half consists of urban service functions and amenity elements.

More than half of the world's population now lives in cities, and the world now functions primarily through city-to-city connections. Building houses without considering the wider world is truly regrettable.

A City: A Vessel of Civilization

KIM Kwangsoo: I've heard the saying, "A city is a line." Could you explain what it means?

KWAAK YoungHoon: That expression is more than 50 years old. After Mayors KIM Hyun-ok and YANG Taek-sik, it was used frequently when KOO Jachoon was the Mayor of Seoul. Mayor KOO himself also used the phrase. I think he felt that way when he saw Subway Line 2. There were even banners on the streets displaying the phrase, "The city is the line."

When I asked, "Mayor, what do you mean by saying that a city is a line?" he replied, "We need to create a wide and large line on both Mapo-daero (Mapo Boulevard) and Gangnam-daero (Gangnam Boulevard)." He mainly referred to the roads as the line. He also mentioned that as the number of cars gradually increases, the old-style city, with its narrow roads, makes the alignment of subway lines and roads very important.

However, a city is not only a line, but also a plane. A city is not only a plane but also three-dimensional, and it is three-dimensional yet inhabited by people. Therefore, a city is a vessel that contains civilization.

Urban design is a field concerned with how forms and spaces are created, and therefore it is inherently three-dimensional. In particular, Seoul has many mountains and a highly three-dimensional terrain, so urban design there must also be three-dimensional. Furthermore, since a city grows, develops, and declines like an organism, urban design must be considered in four or even five dimensions, and the city's administration and finances should be managed accordingly. To create a proper city and civilization, at least twenty dimensions must be taken into account.

KIM Kwangsoo: I completely agree with you! Now seems to be the time to bring in fresh air, just as farmers turn over the soil before sowing their seeds.



▲ Gangnam-daero



▲ Mapo-daero

8

Yet Again, We Move Forward : The Big Picture for the Next Generation

Conditions for a World City

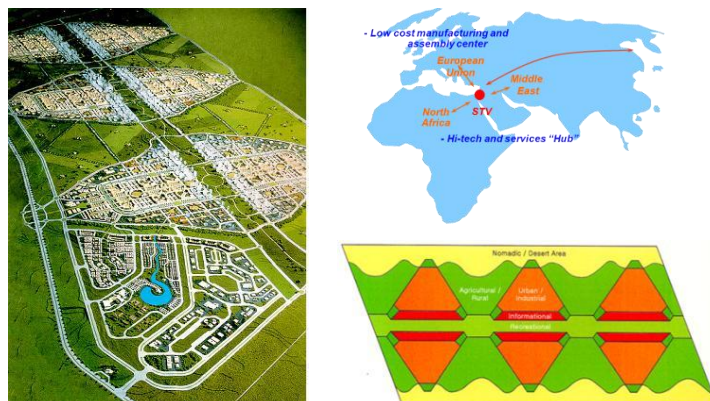
KIM Kwangsoo: What conditions are required for a World City?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It would be desirable for a World City to have the following characteristics:

1. It should be a transportation hub. To ensure smooth exchange of goods and global citizens, it would need to have a port and an airport.
2. If the location is a border area between two or more countries that has not yet been fully developed, it would be suitable for new experiments. Border regions are particularly well-suited for legal designation as administrative special zones. Following the successful hosting of the 1988 Seoul Olympics, I traveled to the Tumen River's "small triangle" area, a border point shared by Russia, China, and North Korea, with the idea of developing it into a World City.
3. The best locations are underdeveloped regions where local residents — especially the youth — can cultivate the qualities of global citizenship. From this perspective, the African continent offers significant potential.
4. Ideal locations are unspoiled areas where people can live close to and learn from the Earth's environment and nature. These include the Gobi Desert in Mongolia, the regions of Alaska and the Bering Strait, and tropical zones near the equator.
5. It is a place where new alternatives for living can be tested. The DMZ and its surrounding areas on the Korean Peninsula offer an opportunity to break down ideological walls and experiment with a global civilization where people live together. It is an ideal region to serve as a platform for grand efforts toward human peace.

KIM Kwangsoo: Are there any regions that currently meet these conditions?

KWAAK YoungHoon: I would mention Sinai Technology Valley (STV), a new city on the Sinai Peninsula in Egypt, as an example of a place suitable for a World City. I envisioned it as a city for nomads, farmers, business people, and new high-tech professionals.



▲ Sinai Technology Valley Master Plan, Egypt, 1997

The Sinai Peninsula is a region that connects Europe, Asia, and Africa, with great potential to develop into a global transportation hub. It spans a large area, and has five ports, and borders both Israel and Palestine. Its mountains, deserts, and coastlines remain largely in their natural state, so the natural environment will require careful protection in the future.

KIM Kwangsoo: I wonder if there is a suitable city in Korea that could be developed as a World City, like STV.

KWAAK YoungHoon: There are several potential locations in Korea. I consider the Tumen River Region, the Yeongjong–Gyeonggi Bay area, and the Mokpo–Dadohae (archipelago) Region to be strong candidate sites, and I have already developed basic concepts for them. The World City concept for the Mokpo–Dadohae Region was established through an urban planning study in 1990, and for the Tumen River Region through a UNDP research project in 1993.

The Yeongjong area was included in the 1993 Incheon Long-Range Development Plan, where Yeongjong, Songdo, and Cheongna were conceptualized as a “Triport.” I worked on this project together with experts from San Francisco and Washington in the United States, Rotterdam in the Netherlands, and Milan in Italy.

Yeongjong Island is an island area with Seoul and Incheon as its hinterland, and it has a geopolitical advantage in that there are as many as 47 international cities with populations of over one million within a three-hour flight radius based on current aircraft speeds. In addition, Asia’s largest hub airport equipped with state-of-the-art facilities is located in Yeongjong Island. If the nation establishes cutting-edge information and communications infrastructure and a logistics complex there as part of a national plan, it is expected to become an ideal site for a World City.

I made this suggestion when recommending “the Triport City Concept” to Mayor CHOI Kisun of Incheon. For this project, I collaborated with five architects, planners, and professors.



▲ Potential Areas for a World City in Korea

KIM Kwangsoo: How did you collaborate with them?

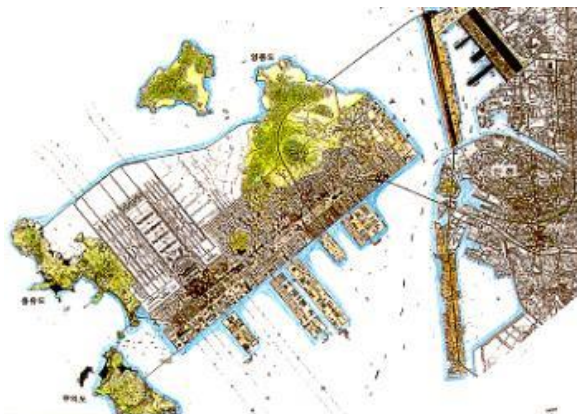
KWAAK YoungHoon: I traveled to all the cities where the chief architects and planners had their offices. Before each trip, I sent them the basic World City concept and maps so they could study them in advance. I collaborated with Sandy Vance from Stanford University in San Francisco, the President of EDAW in Washington, D.C., Rem Koolhaas of OMA in Rotterdam, and architect Sottsass of Sottsass Associati in Milan, Italy. I had a wonderful time exchanging ideas and exploring different approaches for the future of “Yeongjong World City.”



▲ Master Plan with Stanford University



▲ Master Plan with EDAW



▲ Master Plan with OMA



▲ Master Plan with Sottsass

KIM Kwangsoo: I heard that you not only worked with professionals, but also held seminars on the project with professors and visionaries.

KWAAK YoungHoon: You are right. I thought I needed to hear directly from the professors. Professors from MIT, Harvard, and the Joint Center of Harvard and MIT held a seminar for me at the Kennedy School.

KIM Kwangsoo: Could you tell me who they were?

KWAAK YoungHoon: They were Professor John Montgomery of the Harvard Kennedy School, Professor Harvey Cox of the Harvard Divinity School, and Professor Lloyd Rodwin of MIT. In addition, at Stanford University, I attended a seminar with several professors on future studies.

KIM Kwangsoo: I can imagine that they would have had critical perspectives on this somewhat utopian idea.

KWAAK YoungHoon: They were not really negative. Rather, they offered very thoughtful comments. Professor Harvey Cox, who wrote *The Secular City*, believed that utopian thinking should not be discouraged. Professor Montgomery shared his thoughts on political and policy matters, while Professor Rodwin was encouraging about realizing the concept. He asked what the point of creating this World City was, which prompted me to elaborate on several key points. I appreciated all of their views, whether critical or supportive.

Don't you think the idea to establish "the Yeongjong World City" is both practical and desirable?

KIM Kwangsoo: Well, Yeongjong Island was a vacant island, and you have already succeeded in building the Incheon International Airport, Northeast Asia Hub Airport, which has been rated as the best-served airport in the world for the past 15 years or so. I remember that many people in the economic and environmental fields were against your idea of building a new airport, but you overcame the opposition. So, I am hopeful that the idea to establish the World City will become another success story.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Thank you for your kind words. One more important point I would like to mention is that, with Seoul and Incheon as its base cities, the location has a "geopolitechnomical" advantage — a term I coined. There are 47 international cities with a population of one million or more within three hours, based on current airplane speeds. In addition, Yeongjong Island now has the largest hub airport in Asia with state-of-the-art facilities. In the future, if state-of-the-art information and communication facilities and logistics complexes are built as part of my MVIP nation-building plan, it is expected to develop sooner than the other sites I mentioned.

KIM Kwangsoo: You are optimistic as always. I hope your unusual idea is realized.



▲ Boston Research Center's Working Seminar on the World City Network

Connecting Cities, Silk Road Mayors Forum

KIM Kwangsoo: I recently heard that you also have an idea to connect several World Cities.

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, I do. As I planned new cities in Korea and other countries, I envisioned that they could be linked or networked. Some people have already supported my idea, and experiments are currently underway in several cities to create a World City Network.

The World Citizens Organization (WCO), founded in 1987 for the Olympeace Movement, is planning and developing a project to connect the ancient Silk Road cities across the Eurasian continent.

KIM Kwangsoo: Could you explain what kind of project it is?

KWAAK YoungHoon: It is the Silk Road Mayors Forum (SRMF), which has been held annually since 2006. To date, 209 cities from 69 countries have participated. At each forum, mayors, government officials, business leaders, representatives of international organizations, civil society members, university professors, and students — typically from 20 to 30 countries and 50 to 80 cities — participate.

The Forum covers topics such as “harmony among civilizations,” “global citizenship,” “the economy and tourism.” Based on the discussions and the key issues of the host city, the SRMF Declaration is then announced.



▲ SRMF Host Cities: 13 cities in 8 countries

KIM Kwangsoo: I wonder how this large-scale event came to be held on a regular basis and where it all began.

KWAAK YoungHoon: After the 1988 Seoul Olympic Games, the Cold War era miraculously collapsed, and the land route crossing Eurasia from east to west was opened. This enabled WCO officials to travel freely from China to Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, Iran, Turkey, and other countries.

In consultation with the resident representative of the UNDP in Beijing, the WCO conceived the SRMF as a way for Silk Road cities to exchange and coexist in the fields of culture, economy, and tourism. It was expected that by hosting the Forum in different city each year, every city would increase its international recognition and gain a “forum effect.”

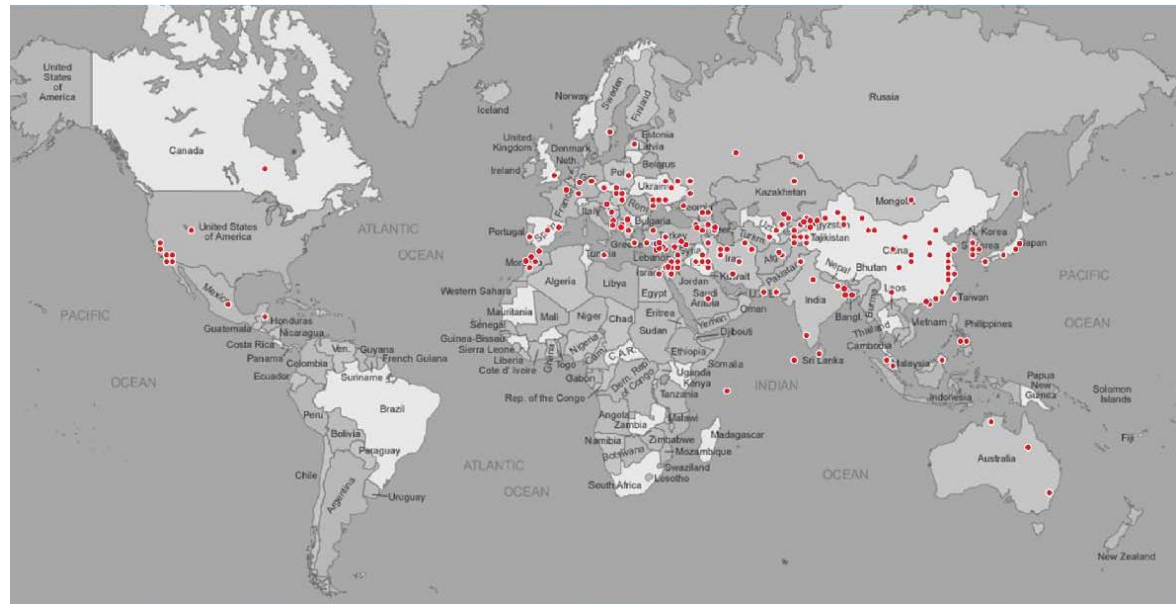
KIM Kwangsoo: It is interesting that the establishment of networks among cities is based on the ancient trade route that once connected China to the Mediterranean Sea.

KWAAK YoungHoon: The total population of the cities that have participated in the SRMF is about 3.5 billion people, which is close to half of the world’s population.

KIM Kwangsoo: This is an event that is not well known in Korea, but its scale is truly enormous.

KWAAK YoungHoon: I believe that the successes, trials, and errors accumulated through the SRMF will serve as material for drawing a sketch of the World City Network.

	Afghanistan	Bamyan, Kabul		Iran	Hamedan, Kashan, Mashhad, Qazvin, Semnan, Shiraz, Tabriz, Tehran, Yazd		Philippines	Cebu, Iloilo, Manila
	Albania	Durres		Iraq	Amarah, Baghdad, Erbil, Mosul, Ramadi, Wassit		Poland	Warsaw
	Armenia	Yerevan		Israel	Jerusalem, Tel Aviv		Portugal	Lisbon
	Australia	Darwin, North Queensland, Sydney		Jamaica	Kingston		Russia	Azov, Belgorod, Derbent, Grozny, Kazan, Moscow, Naberezhnye Chelny, Omsk, Taman, Vanino, Veronezh
	Azerbaijan	Astara, Baku, Gence		Japan	Fukushima, Karatsu, Obama, Tokyo		Saudi Arabia	Riyadh
	Bangladesh	Bogra, Kushtia, Nongla port bagerhat		Jordan	Amman, Aqaba, Irbid, Karak		Serbia	Tutin
	Belize	Belize City		Kazakhstan	Almaty, Astana, Cim Kent, Turkestan		Seychelles	Victoria
	Bolivia	La Paz		Kosovo	Prizren		Spain	Madrid, Valencia
	Bosnia and Herzegovina	Mostar, Zenica		Korea	Gyeongju, Pyeongteak, Seoul, Yosu		Sri Lanka	Colombo
	Canada	Alberta, Calgary, Ontario, Toronto, Vancouver		Kyrgyzstan	Balykehy, Bishkek, Jalal-Abad, Karakol, Naryn, Osh, Talas, Uzgen		Sudan	Khartoum
	China	Baoji, Beijing, Changhi Hui, Chengdu, Guangzhou, Hami, Hangzhou, Ili Kazakh, Jiuquan, Kashgar, Kunming, Lanzhou, Lianyungang, Lishui, Macau, Ningbo, Quanzhou, Rizhao, Shanghai, Shihzei, Talyuan, Urumqi, Xian, Xuzhou, Yangzhou, Yinchuan, Zhengzhou, Hong Kong		Latvia	Riga		Sweden	Stockholm
	Croatia	Zagreb		Lebanon	Tripoli		Syria	Damascus
	Cyprus	Nicosia		Macedonia	Skopje		Taiwan	Taipei
	Czech	Ostrava, Prague		Maldives	Male		Tajikistan	Dushanbe, Khorog, Khujand
	Egypt	Cairo		Malta	Birgu		Thailand	Bangkok
	France	Paris, Strasbourg		Malaysia	Alor Setar, Klang, Kota Kinabalu		Tunisia	Tunis
	Greece	Athens		Mexico	Queretaro		Turkey	Agt. Akceki Antalya, Alanya, Ankara, Antalya, Bursa, Demre Antalya, Finike Antalya, Gaziantep, Hatay, Istanbul, Izmir, Kahramanmaraş, Konya, Korkuteli, Şanlıurfa, Serik Antalya
	Georgia	Barumi, Tbilisi		Moldova	Chisinau, Kishinev, Komrat		Turkmenistan	Ashgabad
	Germany	Bonn, Kassel		Mongolia	Ulan Bator		Ukraine	Kharkov, Kiev, Odessa
	Hungary	Budapest, Heviz, Pecs		Montenegro	Budva, Kotor		UK	London
	India	Cochin, Jaipur, New Delhi		Morocco	Casablanca, Kenitra, Rabat, Settat, Tetouan		U.S.A.	Berkeley, Boston, Irvine, Los Angeles, New Port Beach, New York, Oceanside, San Francisco, Salt Lake City
				Nepal	Kathmandu, Lalitpur		Uzbekistan	Bukhara, Samarkand, Tashkent
				Norway	Oslo		Vietnam	Hue
				Pakistan	Gwadar, Islamabad, Karachi			
				Palestine	Gaza			



▲ SRMF Participant Cities: 206 Cities in 69 Countries



Lanzhou 2007



Almaty 2008



Pyeongtaek 2009



Shiraz 2010



Grozny 2011



Gaziantep 2012



Yeosu 2013



Urumqi 2014



Bursa 2015



Qazvin 2016

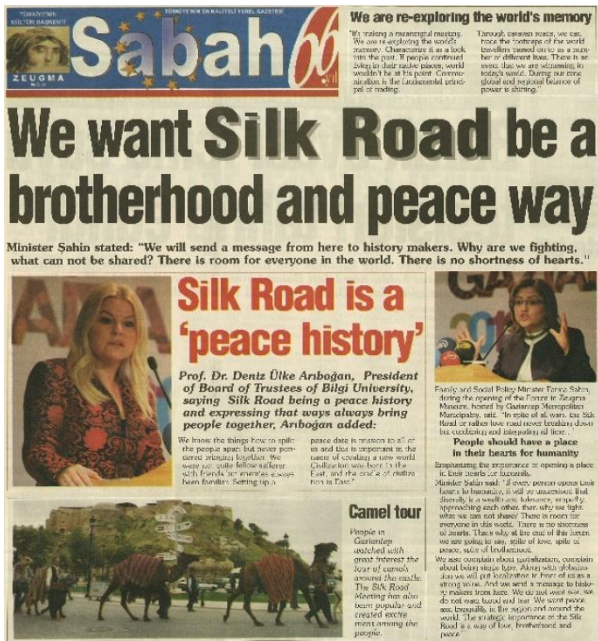


Kabul 2017



Antalya 2018

▲ SRMF Host Cities



▲ Articles on the Gaziantep SRMF, 2012

In Pursuit of Utopia

KIM Kwangsoo: I was reminded of Thomas More's *Utopia* while listening to the concept of the World City. Utopia, which refers to an "ideal society," paradoxically means "a place that is nowhere to be found." It must be very difficult to achieve an ideal society. Wouldn't it also be difficult to realize your dream of a World City?

KWAAK YoungHoon: Yes, it certainly would. However, nothing can be achieved without dreaming. The planning of World City Network must be a collaborative effort, with intellectuals and citizens from around the world coming together to discuss and experiment. Furthermore, establishing a global network of World Cities will require consensus on a planetary scale. I believe that now is the time to focus on defining the concept and developing exemplary cases.

A World City must not be standardized. Even though COVID-19 has hindered progress, advances in science, technology, and socio-cultural development allow people today to travel anywhere in the world. In this era, it is easy for other cultures to become subordinated to — or even erased by — a small number of cultures that hold hegemony. Therefore, a World City must be conceived with an understanding of and respect for ecological diversity and cultural differences.

KIM Kwangsoo: In order for the World City Network not to be transformed into a new form of "imperialism," education that emphasizes balance and harmony seems necessary.

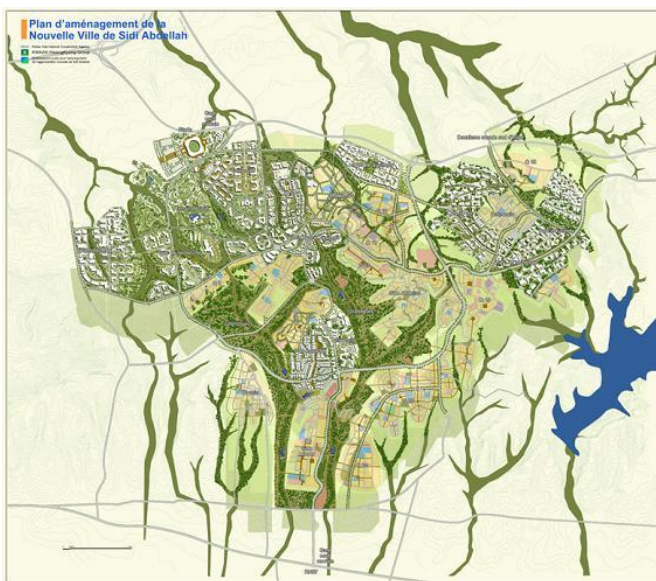
KWAAK YoungHoon: Exactly. In that sense, from now on, philosophers like you must take the lead in promoting the philosophy of glocalization for humanity, justice, and sustainability.

KIM Kwangsoo: You are passing the final role to me. (laughs)

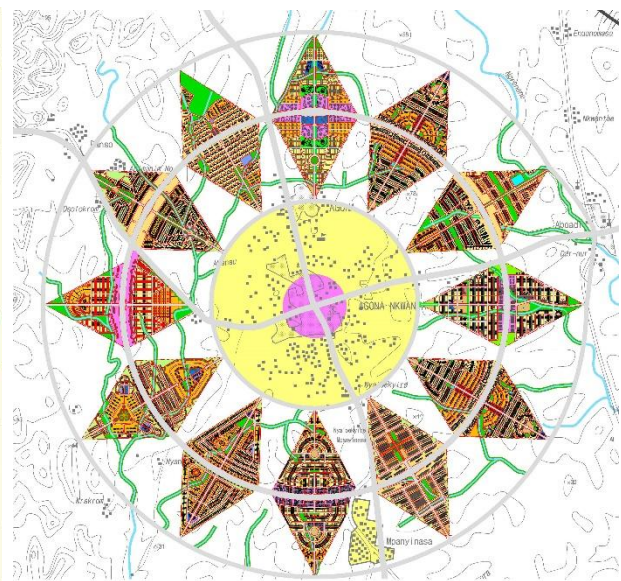
KWAAK YoungHoon: Of course, an experimental city should also be built where people from different backgrounds can come together to learn how to live together in real life. In fact, the Lumbini Peace and Harmony District (PHD) was designed precisely for this purpose. In Lumbini PHD, there would be no air, noise, or water pollution.

KIM Kwangsoo: I hope that such a city will also be established in the DMZ.

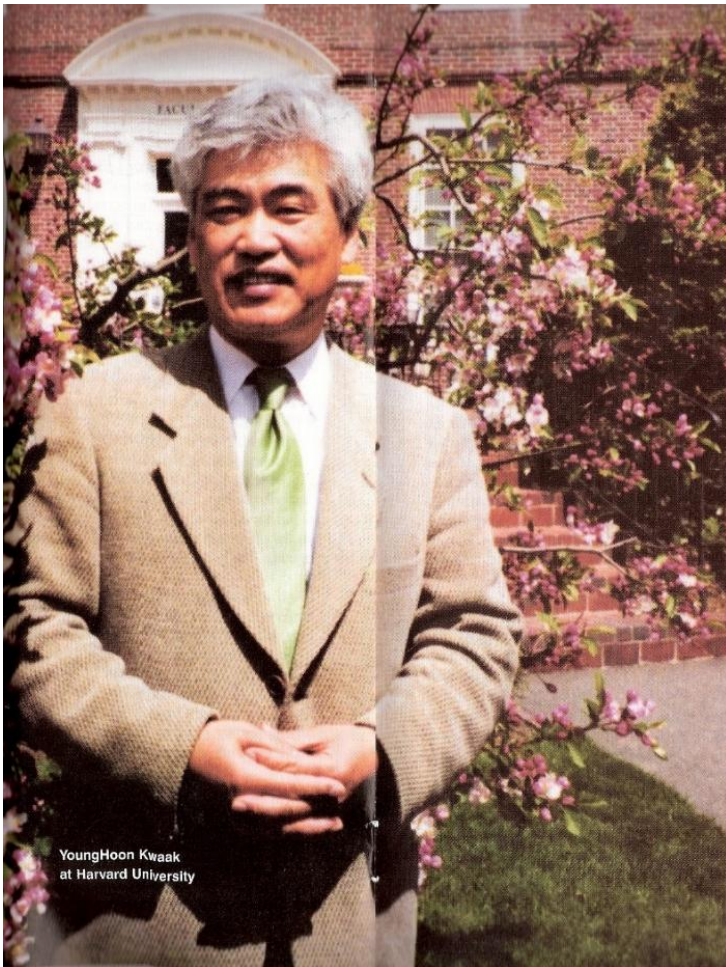
KWAAK YoungHoon: I truly hope so, too. As you know, to establish a World City in the DMZ was my first dream. That dream led me to study many cities around the world, and it drove me to work globally. That is how I have lived my life so far. I still hope that my life will not end before realizing the DMZ World City where separated families can live together in a more peaceful, just, and sustainable world!



▲ Sidi Abdellah Plan, Algeria



▲ Ahanta West District Plan, Ghana



YoungHoon Kwaak
at Harvard University

Peace design **for the world**

*An interview with Korean
architect and planner
YoungHoon Kwaak*

BY KIM SHIPPEY

IN THE OLYMPIC Stadium in Sydney this week is someone whose thoughts will range far beyond the events unfolding in front of him. He is Professor YoungHoon Kwaak, one of Korea's best-known architects, and a key member of the Assembly of Olympeace (the spirit of the Olympics joined with humanity's yearning for peace), which was conceptualized by Professor Kwaak shortly before the Seoul Olympics in 1988. He planned and supervised the redevelopment of the Han River Waterfront, and the construction of Olympic Park, where the cultural events were held in Seoul.

His goal for Olympeace was to use Olympic occasions as a rallying point for prominent people from many walks of life to keep the spirit of the games alive at all times and to discuss their continuing role as an instrument for world peace. Professor Kwaak had just completed a series of lectures and discussions with the

▲ Article from the *Christian Science Sentinel* Introducing Dr. KWAAK YoungHoon as a Designer of World Peace (September 18, 2000)



▲ Construction of the *Ttukbawi* Memorial Rock Dedicated to the Reunification of North and South Korea, 1991, and Cobblestone Placement Ceremony at the VISTA 55th Reunion, 2018